JOHN

The Gospel of John was written towards the end of the first century AD by someone referred to as 'the beloved disciple' (21:20, 24). It is likely that this person was one of the three disciples who were especially close to Jesus, namely, Peter, James and John (Matt 17:1; Matt 26:37; Mark 5:37;). Since Peter is often described as being with the beloved disciple (13:23–24; 20:2; 21:20–21), he cannot be the author. Nor can the author be James, who was killed by Herod Agrippa I no later than AD 44. John is left as the most likely candidate to be the 'beloved disciple'. He later describes himself as an eyewitness of all that Jesus did (1 John 1:1).

The purpose of the book is spelled out in 20:30–31: 'These [signs] are written that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name.'

The gospel is organized around seven specific signs which John has chosen out of many other possibilities (20:30; 2I:25; see also the miracles recorded in the other gospels). These are the changing of water into wine (2:1–11), the healing of a royal official (4:46–54), the healing of a lame man (5:1–9), the feeding of more than five thousand people (6:1–14), walking on water (6:15–25), the healing of a man who was born blind (9:1–41), and the raising of Lazarus (11:1–46). John sees these events as more than mere miracles; they are signs that force readers to ask, 'Who is this man who can do all these things? How can he be master over quality, distance, time, quantity, natural laws, misfortune, and death?'

John believes that the evidence proves that 'Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God.' The Greek title 'Christ' is equivalent to the Hebrew title, 'Messiah', which means 'one who is anointed'. Anointing sets someone apart for a specific purpose. But whereas others who were anointed for specific tasks fulfilled their task and then died (for example, Aaron and his sons—Exod 28:41), Jesus, God's Son, has been anointed by God to deal with sin for ever (1:29).

Jesus is the Son of God because of his eternal relationship with the Father. The Father identified him as his Son at his baptism (Matt 3:17; John 1:32–34) and at his transfiguration (Matt 17:5, Mark 9:7, Luke 9:35). John does not record these two occasions, but he does include a similar incident in 12:27–28. There Jesus addresses God as Father, implying that he is God's Son, and God acknowledges him with approval.

The relationship of the divine Son and Father is difficult for us to comprehend. We need to remember that God is describing an eternal relationship in a way that we humans can understand. He has chosen to reveal his plan of salvation to us in terms of the Father who sends the Son, the Son who dies on the cross, and the Holy Spirit who applies all this to our lives.

In 20:31, John also speaks of life, which is another great theme in this gospel. Eternal life is available only to those who believe, and they receive it immediately when they believe. Everyone who believes is assured of the possession of this life from that moment on.

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COMMENTARY

1:1–51 Introduction

1:1–18 In the Beginning Was the Word

The gospel begins by speaking of someone referred to as *the Word* (1:1, 14). In Jewish thought, the Word of God was the way God communicated himself. In Greek thought, the Word was the central idea that holds the universe together. It is clear from 1:17 that the person John is referring to is Jesus.

The first thing that John stresses about the Word is that he is eternal—*in the beginning was the Word* (**1:1a**). The 'was' indicates that the Word already existed at that point in the past labelled 'the beginning'. Some commentators note the similarity between this phrase and Genesis 1:1, and assert that it means the Word was already there when the world was created. While this is true, it is too limiting. John is saying that the Word has existed from eternity.

Next, John stresses the status of the Word in eternity: *the Word was God* (**1:1b**). The past tense 'was' does not indicate that his status has changed since then. Rather, it indicates the contrast

between his status in eternity past and his entrance into humanity when *the Word became flesh* (1:14).

Some think that John 1:1b should be translated 'and the Word was a god', arguing that in Greek a noun with an article is definite while a noun without an article is indefinite. But this rule does not always apply. At times an article is omitted in order to stress the quality of something. In this particular case, Jesus' status is that of God, but he does not exhaust what God is. If John had said that Jesus was 'the God' here, he would have been leaving out the Father and the Holy Spirit, who are also persons of the Trinity.

Those who argue for the 'a God' translation deny the full deity of Jesus. But throughout his gospel, John strongly affirms Jesus' deity. In 1:18 he refers to him as *God the One and Only,* and both he and Jesus approve of Thomas' recognition of Jesus as 'my Lord and my God' (20:28). Thus at three key points in Jesus' life—in eternity (1:1), at his incarnation (1:18), and after his resurrection (20:28)—the deity of Christ is asserted.

John also stresses the eternal relationship between the Word and God the Father. The words *with God* (**1:2**) emphasize Jesus' face-to-face relationship with the Father. Throughout this gospel, John repeatedly states that the Father loves the Son and the Son seeks to glorify the Father. Their association, companionship and mutual glorification started in eternity.

The Word, who is eternal, created all things. John states this truth both positively and negatively. Positively, he says, *Through him all things were made* (**1:3**). Negatively, he says, *without him nothing was made* (1:3). In the Greek, a strong p 1279 distinction is drawn between the status of the Word and that of creation. While the Word 'was' in the beginning (1:1), the creation 'came to be' (1:3). The Word existed before the beginning described in Genesis 1:1 and was in fact responsible for all that was made in that beginning.

John does not only present Jesus as the 'Word' but also as the source of life and as light (1:4–5). He provides life to and illuminates the way for those who acknowledge him.

Creation had a beginning, and so did the man named John the Baptist, whose testimony in **1:15** reveals his awareness that Jesus existed before he did—even though Jesus was six months younger than he was (Luke 1:26). John the Baptist recognized the difference in status between himself and Jesus. He was merely *a man who was sent from God* (**1:6**); Jesus was the Word who was 'with God'. Jesus was eternal, while John the Baptist was temporal.

John the Baptist was also very clear about the contrast between Jesus' job and his own. He knew that his place was to be a servant, one sent *only as a witness to the light* (**1:7–8**), while Jesus' place was that of master, for he was himself *the true light* (**1:9a**; see also 3–4). Literally, the text says that he was 'the light, the true one'. Jesus is the primary light. All other lights are secondary and shine only as they reflect his light.

The *coming into the world* (**1:9b**) of this true light brought at least two blessings. First, it brought light for all to share, giving light to every man (and woman). Second, it brought the right of belonging (**1:12–13**). Although many may reject him (1:10–11), his arms are open to all those who want to receive his message. He gives them the power or the authority to belong to God as his sons and daughters. This right to belong to God's family was not based on race (Jewish or non-Jewish descent) or on anything a person has done. It is a gift from God, creating a new nature in those who receive Christ. They are born into the family of God.

Adeyemo, T. (2006). *Africa Bible commentary*. Nairobi, Kenya; Grand Rapids, MI: WordAlive Publishers; Zondervan.

Yet, tragically, the very world that he himself had made *did not recognize him* (**1:10**). While 'world' covers all creation in general, the primary focus is on men and women. Human systems and individuals did not respect Jesus. They treated him just like anyone else in Palestine.

But not only was Jesus not honoured, he was also rejected: *His own did not receive him* (**1:11**). 'His own' were the Jewish people. Though Joseph had no part in Jesus' conception and Jesus transcended human existence, he had been born into a Jewish home. His mother Mary and her husband Joseph were Jews. Yet when Jesus came to his own people, many of them wanted nothing to do with him. We should not be surprised by this negative attitude, for we ourselves are guilty of the same thing. He made us all, yet there are many among us who do not acknowledge him as God, the Creator and the God-Man who brings us salvation.

In God's good time (Gal 4:4), *the Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us* (**1:14**). He who is from eternity and who made all things took the status of a creature. The verb 'became' in the phrase 'became flesh' is the same verb used of his making all things in 1:3. This shows that while his status of deity (1:1) has no beginning, his status as human does. We are told about this movement from eternity to time in Matthew 1:18–25 and Luke 1:26–38. The eternal Word was conceived by the mortal Mary through the power of the Holy Spirit. The Word's 'dwelling among us' summarizes his entire earthly life, from his conception till his ascension. It was a temporary dwelling with a purpose, namely, to reveal God (1:18) and to die in the place of humankind (11:50–53).

What Jesus revealed about the Father is his *grace and truth*. This phrase is used twice (1:14 and 1:17), and grace is mentioned on its own in **1:16**. 'Grace' means that something totally undeserved is given freely, with no strings attached. All that the giver wants in response is gratitude. The gift Jesus gives is the right to become a member of the family of God (1:12), and the only response required is to be a grateful member of that family. There can be no question of repaying Jesus for a gift like this!

This belonging ushers one into and keeps one in a new life setting, one where truth prevails. 'Truth' is that which has been tested and found to be right. Here, it means the difference between right and wrong belief and behaviour, as determined by the standard of God.

The blessings of grace and truth are contrasted with the law of Moses (**1:17**). The contrast is not that the former replaces the latter, or even that the law of Moses lacked grace and truth. The point is that the grace and truth Jesus reveals fill up what was lacking in the law. The law was a shadow of the real thing that was to come, even though it was the will of God and was based on the grace of God. The fuller revelation of God through Jesus Christ reveals further grace. That is why John speaks of our receiving *one blessing after another* (1:16). The true thing foreshadowed in the law has now come.

Jesus' revelation of the Father is unique, for *no one has ever seen God, but God the One and Only, who is at the Father's side, has made him known* (**1:18**). Some in the past had seen a faint representation of God, which could be described as his shadow (for example, Moses—Exod 33:11; Num 12:8; Isaiah—Isa 6:5). But no one had seen him directly, for he had warned 'No one may see me and live' (Exod 33:20). But Jesus, who is God, lived among men. Those who saw him, saw not a shadow of God but God himself. He was truly the God-man, in whom one nature did not eliminate the other. He remained fully God while also becoming fully human.

There are many in Africa who deny the message of this passage. They may call themselves Jehovah's Witnesses or representatives of Christ, but unless their message proclaims that Jesus is God, the Creator of all things, and the only basis upon which any man or woman receives blessings

from God, they are to be condemned for their blasphemy. They are to be prayed for, but are also to be shunned. False p 1280 teaching finds ready soil in Africa due to the natural religiosity of African people. It is time, however, that we in Africa became a little more discerning, to distinguish truth from error. We must guard the truths taught in this passage with all our being if we are to be on the same side as God, whose word clearly tells us that Jesus is God.

1:19–28 John the Baptist Prepares the Way

People's speculation about whether John the Baptist was the Christ is implied in John 1:20 but explicitly stated in Luke 3:15. This led the Jews of Jerusalem to send priests and Levites to Bethany where he was baptizing (**1:28**), asking him to confirm or deny this rumour (**1:19**).

1:19–21 The questions of the Jewish leaders

The delegation that came to John the Baptist asked questions that focused on three possible identities for John: was he the Christ, Elijah or the prophet?

In asking whether he was *the Christ* (**1:20**), the Jews were expressing their belief that the Christ, or Messiah, would come at some time. For details about what this term means, see the Introduction. It was expected that the Christ would come either as a supernatural figure sent directly from heaven or that God would raise him up from among the people. John the Baptist emphatically stated that he was not the expected Christ.

In asking whether he was *Elijah* (**1:21a**), the Jews may have been thinking of Malachi's words about a messenger whom God would send to refine the nation in preparation for the coming of the Lord (Mal 3:1–3). The Lord had identified this messenger as the prophet Elijah (Mal 4:5). The Jews interpreted these passages as meaning that Elijah would come before the Messiah, to prepare people for the messianic age. If John the Baptist was not the Christ, then he might possibly be the prophet Elijah, sent to prepare the way for the Christ. But he denied this identity too.

The final question, *Are you the Prophet?* (**1:21b**) was asked with a particular prophet in mind, as is clear from the article 'the'. Moses had said that the Lord had told him, 'I will raise up for them (the Israelites) a prophet like you from among their brothers' (Deut 18:18b). In Acts, both Peter and Stephen identified this prophet as Jesus Christ (Acts 3:22; 7:37). The Jews, however, thought that this prophet would be someone distinct from the Messiah. John the Baptist insisted that he was not this prophet.

1:22–23 John the Baptist's self-identification

The questioners had run out of ideas, so they asked John the Baptist, *Who are you? Give us an answer to take back to those who sent us. What do you say about yourself?* (**1:22**). In light of what John the Baptist was doing and considering the crowds that were thronging to him (Luke 3:1–19), he must have been somebody important. But John chose to identify himself only as a voice: *I am the voice of the one calling in the desert, 'Make straight the way for the Lord'* (**1:23**, quoting Isa 40:3). John did not see himself as having an independent identity. He was a mere messenger, and his message was far more important than who he was. His message called people to prepare to receive the Lord's teaching and repent of their sins.

1:24–28 John the Baptist contrasts himself with the Christ

John the Baptist's identification of himself as nobody but a messenger (a 'voice') invited the question *Why then do you baptize if you are not the Christ, nor Elijah, nor the Prophet?*' (**1:25**). As far as the Pharisees were concerned, these were the only three who would baptize Jews. Normally, only proselytes who were converting to Judaism were baptized.

Instead of giving a direct answer to their question, John the Baptist pointed out that the issue was deeper than they thought. His words can be paraphrased as follows: *I baptize with water and you notice me and begin to wonder whether I am the Christ, Elijah or the Prophet. Let me tell you, there is the one who is really great. In fact he already stands among you!* (**1:26–27**).

The reference to Jesus as *the one who comes after me* (1:27a) is the same as in 1:15, where it means that historically Jesus comes after John the Baptist. But in the context of John the Baptist's role, the one who comes after John is the one for whom John is preparing the way, that is, the Lord and King. His importance is emphasized when John says, *I am not worthy to untie the thongs of his sandals* (1:27b). Untying sandals was the work of a slave. John the Baptist claimed he was not worthy to offer Jesus even the lowest level of service.

The general attitude in Africa is that when one holds an office, especially a political office, one should grab as much as one can, since the opportunity may never come again. Most of us have not learned to be satisfied with what the Lord has given us. The same attitude is reflected in the search for fame—the desire to be someone important. John the Baptist had an opportunity to be known as an important man, but he was content with the ministry he had been given by the Lord. He was fully satisfied to be less than a servant so that Jesus' glory could be seen.

1:29–36 Jesus, the Lamb and Son of God

In many African societies, any general calamity is traditionally interpreted as being caused by an offence against God, either directly or because something has offended the spirits who protect divine values. Some sacrifice is needed to appease God's anger, and in the past that sacrifice was often a young lamb. John the Baptist was thinking in similar terms when, on two successive days, he drew the attention of his disciples to Jesus and said, *Look, the Lamb of God* (**1:29a, 36**). The source or origin of this Lamb is God. When someone sinned, a lamb had to be sacrificed because God could not just ignore that sin. It had to be atoned for p 1281 (Lev 4:20, 26, 31, 35; 5:10, 13). Jesus comes as the Lamb given by God *who takes away the sin of the world* (**1:29b**). The 'sin' here is singular, not plural. It is a collective noun, focusing on the disobedience of Adam and Eve, from which all other sins spring. Jesus' function is to free the world (that is, humankind) from that sin.

John the Baptist was so aware of the contrast between himself and Jesus that he repeated his earlier statement: *He has surpassed me because he was before me* (**1:30**). The Baptist knew that Jesus was eternal while he himself had begun to exist only when he was conceived by his mother, Elizabeth. He stressed that his own ministry of baptism was only a means to an end and not an end in itself: *I came baptizing with water so that he might be revealed to Israel* (**1:31**). Now that this end had been attained (**1:34**), John the Baptist and his baptism were no longer significant.

Besides being the Lamb, Jesus is also the Son of God whose ministry is blessed by the Holy Spirit (**1:32**). He gives that Spirit to others whom he baptizes with the Holy Spirit (**1:33**). This baptism may

include many blessings, but the most basic one is that the Holy Spirit puts his stamp on us, giving us the assurance that we belong to God because Jesus has removed the sin in our lives (Eph 1:13).

1:37–42 Jesus Calls the First Disciples

I remember an occasion when a clay pot had been smashed and a curse pronounced: 'May you be broken like this!' Fearful of the effects of the curse, the people sent for someone to cleanse them. When the person arrived, he was an old man, leaning on a stick, with nothing in his hands. He was followed by a young boy, carrying a bag containing everything the old man needed to accomplish the cleansing. The young boy was the old man's disciple, and was there to do whatever his master asked him to do. What a vivid picture of the relationship between a teacher and his disciple!

In this passage in John, we see Jesus starting to build a team of men who would be his disciples and who would learn from him. It seems that he began with the informal contact described here before he issued the formal call recorded in Matthew 4:18–22 and Mark 1:14–20.

Andrew and the unnamed disciple (most likely, John the apostle) had been with John the Baptist for an unspecified period of time and counted themselves among his followers (**1:35, 40**). They would have heard John the Baptist speaking about Jesus (1:15, 26–27, 29, 32–34). So on the second day, when they heard him identify Jesus as the Lamb of God (**1:36**), they interpreted his meaning correctly and left him and *followed Jesus* (**1:37**).

Jesus' question *What do you want?* (**1:38a**) challenged them to evaluate what they were getting into before they even started. If they were only looking for a different teacher, that was not enough. If they were looking for a more comfortable life than they had with John (Matt 3:4), they would not get it. But they were clear about what they wanted. They wanted to know where Jesus was staying (**1:38b**), probably so that they could visit him later. Addressing Jesus as *Rabbi* (teacher) showed that they acknowledged him as someone from whom they could gain knowledge and wisdom.

Jesus' response was *Come … and you will see* (**1:39a**). There was a sense of urgency. Tomorrow might never come. They needed to visit Jesus that day—in fact, right at that moment. What they would see was more than the house or room he lived in—they would see and feel what it meant to be with Jesus.

The two disciples did as Jesus encouraged them to do. They went and saw where he was staying. More than that, *they spent that day with him* (**1:39b**). Jesus issued his invitation at about the tenth hour, that is, about 4 p.m. (The Jewish method of keeping time was from sunrise at 6 a.m. to sunset at 6 p.m.). By 4 p.m. not much of the day remained, but Jesus and the two disciples abandoned whatever other plans they may have had. Jesus was available to them as host, and they revelled in the experience and stayed as long as the day lasted.

These men acted in a truly African fashion. Their programme was flexible enough to accommodate Jesus' invitation to come now, rather than just making an appointment to see him later. Unfortunately, this is something we are losing rapidly, especially in our cities. A few years ago, I was preaching a series of messages that I was told should be twenty-five minutes long. For the first three Sundays, I managed to keep to this deadline. But the topic for my fourth message needed thirty-five minutes to present it adequately. After the service, I was shocked to be accosted by a lady from the choir: 'Your sermon was far too long! Now I am late, and I have visitors coming!' At first, I was not sure that I was hearing her right, until I remembered that the sons and daughters of Africa

have adopted the high-speed life and have allowed some good values to get lost in the process. Having time for one another, and above all for Jesus, is a priority we must strive to keep.

Andrew, having found out how pleasant it was to be with Jesus, wasted no time before sharing his experience with his brother Simon (**1:40**). In fact, John tells us that it was *the first thing [he] did* (**1:41a**). This serves well as our model in the call to 'go into the world and make disciples' (Matt 28:19). Andrew's words, *we have found the Messiah (that is, the Christ)* (**1:41b**), reflected his new personal knowledge of who Jesus was, as well as the message about Jesus that he had heard from John the Baptist (1:29–34). His next act was to bring his brother to Jesus (**1:42a**). He not only knew who Jesus was, but also acted on it. Too many believers in Africa enjoy being with Christ, but view the work of making Jesus known as the pastor's and not theirs. But everyone is called to be like Andrew and to advertise how sweet it is to be with Jesus.

Jesus looked at Andrew's brother and said, *You are Simon son of John. You will be called Cephas* (**1:42b**). Cephas is an p 1282 Aramaic name, translated into Greek as Peter, meaning 'a rock'. Like most African names, this was a name with a meaning. Jesus saw in Simon what he would become: someone who would be as firm as a rock in continuing the work of the kingdom once Jesus had departed. Simon is therefore awarded a new name. He will be prepared for the ministry that corresponds to his new name by a master teacher, one who knows the future perfectly, prepares each kingdom worker suitably, and fits each person into positions as he wills.

1:43–51 The Calling of Philip and Nathanael

The day after Andrew, the unnamed disciple, and Simon Peter had met Jesus, Philip, who like Andrew and Peter was from the town of Bethsaida, was also invited to follow him (**1:43–44**). Like Andrew, he found the discovery too sweet to keep to himself and therefore looked for Nathanael. When he found him, his message (paraphrased here) was, 'We have come into close contact with Jesus of Nazareth, the son of Joseph, and we have identified him as the fulfilment of what Moses and the prophets wrote about' (**1:45**). As *Jesus of Nazareth, the son of Joseph*, Jesus was like any other man living in Palestine. It is what Philip and others had discovered about him that made him different.

Nathanael was sceptical about this Jesus of Nazareth: He thought the Messiah should come from an important town like Jerusalem (the capital), or Bethlehem (the city of David), or even from his own town of Cana (21:2), not from such an unimportant place as Nazareth. Philip's response to Nathanael's scepticism was, *Come and see* (**1:46**), that is, 'Don't disagree before you have seen the evidence. Come and meet him yourself first before you decide.'

It took only two statements by Jesus to turn Nathanael from a sceptic into a believer. These statements showed that Jesus is all-knowing (omniscient) and all-seeing (an aspect of omnipresence). His first statement, as Nathanael approached, was *Here is a true Israelite, in whom there is nothing false* (**1:47**). Nathanael had been honest in expressing his doubts. Admitting that this was an accurate assessment of his character, Nathanael asked Jesus, *How do you know me?* (**1:48a**). Jesus replied, *I saw you while you were still under the fig tree before Philip called you* (**1:48b**). Whatever had taken place under the fig tree, it was Jesus' revelation that he knew of it that turned Nathanael's scepticism into faith.

Nathanael then made one of the key declarations about Jesus in the Gospel of John. He said, *Rabbi, you are the Son of God, you are the King of Israel* (**1:49**). This amounts to saying, 'You are the

Messiah. You are the one God has chosen to rule over Israel.' This is exactly what Nathanael had been sceptical about when he heard that Jesus came from Nazareth. But now he has experienced for himself that, in spite of his insignificant home town, Jesus is the greatest of all the men he has known. He has the qualities that only the Messiah could have.

Nathanael became a believer because of Jesus' ability to know what is in people's hearts and minds and to see into hidden places. But Jesus tells him that his belief needs more content. The Son of Man is far more than just a miracle worker; he is also the link between heaven and earth (**1:50–51**). Jesus presents a vivid picture of this as he speaks of Nathanael and others (the second 'you' in 1:51 is plural) seeing angels, who are God's servants or messengers, carrying messages back and forth between heaven and earth. The 'ladder' that makes this movement possible is the Son of Man. Jesus is hinting at his ministry as the mediator between heaven and earth, between God and man. Nathanael is being challenged to believe in more than just a miracle-performing Jesus. He also needs to believe in Jesus the Saviour.

By using his favourite title, *Son of Man*, Jesus focused on his mission here on earth, involving humble identification with humanity and suffering and death on the cross (Mark 10:45). But the title also relates to his reign as king subsequent to accomplishing his mission as Saviour (Matt 24:30; see also Dan 7:13–14).

Jesus' promise here was fulfilled when he died on the cross and rose from the grave, giving his disciples their central message that the crucified and risen Jesus is the only way of salvation.

Many African men believe that manhood means standing firm in one's convictions. However, there is a manhood that is accompanied by wisdom, and another that is foolishness. The wise man, or woman for that matter, is the one who stands by his or her conviction as long as it still seems right. However, once a conviction has been disapproved by evidence, it is foolish to hang on to it. Nathanael was humble enough to admit that his former scepticism was wrong and to worship Jesus. Sadly, some Africans have totally rejected the gospel of Christ because they want to appear to be tough people. Unfortunately, their toughness is also their foolishness. The evidence is too strong for anyone who is wise to ignore.

2:1–12:50 Jesus' Public Ministry

2:1–11 Jesus Miracle at the Wedding

In parts of Africa, it is not uncommon to see drunken people staggering along the road, despite the risk of being hit by passing vehicles. When told that drinking will ruin them, some quickly reply, 'Jesus made wine in Cana!' They are right, but the lesson Jesus was teaching was not that we should become drunkards. The lessons we should learn are about Mary's initiative in helping to solve someone else's problem and Jesus' ability to help.

Jesus was still in Galilee, where he had met Philip and Nathanael (1:43–45). It was now the third day (**2:1**) since he had left for Galilee in 1:43. He and his disciples were invited p 1283 to a wedding in Cana, a wedding that was also attended by Mary, his mother (**2:2**). At that time weddings lasted for seven days or more. The whole period was a time of rejoicing, eating and drinking. The bridegroom and his family were responsible for providing the food and drink, and running out of wine would be a serious embarrassment to them.

Mary became aware of a shortage of wine, and she knew where to go for a solution. She had known who Jesus was before any one else did, for the angel had told her, 'the holy one to be born will be called the Son of God' (Luke 1:35). So she went to Jesus and said to him, *they have no more wine* (**2:3**). Mary was speaking to him as her son. After all, even though she knew that he was special, he had lived with her as a son for thirty years.

In his response, Jesus addressed Mary as *dear woman* (**2:4a**). The word he uses is equivalent to 'lady' or 'madam' in today's English. He did not want to address her as 'mother' because he wanted her to realize that the stage of his life when he lived as her son had ended. It was now time for him to complete his ministry on earth.

His words *Why do you involve me? My time has not yet come* (**2:4b**) gently point out that Mary can no longer give him instructions and tell him when to act. His words are equivalent to 'Leave the matter to me and my timing. At the right time, I will act.' Mary abandoned her attempt to pressure her son into acting as she wanted, but still acknowledged that he could solve the problem if he wished. So she told the servants, *Do whatever he tells you* (**2:5**).

At the time he judged to be right, Jesus turned to the servants and told them to fill six large jars with water. Each of these jars would hold about 20 to 30 gallons (75 to 115 litres) of water to be used for washing hands as part of a Jewish purification ritual (**2:6–7**). Once his instruction had been obeyed, Jesus told the servants to *draw some out and take it to the master of the banquet* (**2:8**). When the master of the banquet tasted this 'water', he called the bridegroom aside and reprimanded him for not doing things in the right order. This wine was so good that it should have been served first (**2:9–10**).

The bride and groom's families must have been filled with gratitude that Jesus had saved them from great embarrassment—and they must also have been amazed both at the miracle and at the quality of the wine Jesus had produced. The picture we have here is not one of people staggering because they have had too much to drink, but of a people rejoicing that Jesus had met their need.

John presents this as Jesus' first miraculous sign. It had two results, according to **2:11:** Jesus *revealed his glory* and his disciples believed. Jesus is not just the son of Mary; he is also the object of faith.

2:12–22 Jesus Clears the Temple Courts

When I was a teenager, I used to catch birds, carefully setting my traps in the bushes. One day, my friends and I were summoned by the village elder and told that we had set our traps in the place the elders used for sacrifice and polluted it. We were reprimanded and warned never to do that again. The place of worship was sacred and was for worship only. Jesus took a similar view of the respect due to the place of worship when he cleansed the temple.

After the wedding in Cana, Jesus, his mother, brothers, and disciples had gone to Capernaum, about twenty miles (thirty-two kilometres) from Cana, for a few days (**2:12**). Then he travelled on to Jerusalem. It was now close to the time for the Jewish Passover (**2:13**), a seven-day mandatory annual feast that focuses on remembering God's deliverance of the Jews from Egypt. It falls roughly in our March or April.

This important feast had come to be treated as an opportunity for trade at the expense of worshippers. Every male over twenty years of age had to pay a half-shekel temple tax (Exod 30:13).

The authorities had ruled that payment had to be made with the exact amount, and they charged heavily for changing shekels to half-shekels. Those who only had foreign currency had to pay the equivalent of one penny for every half-shekel given as change. Since there were six pennies in a half-shekel and a labourer was paid only four pennies a day, this was an exceedingly high charge. The requirement that only flawless animals could be sacrificed (Lev 3:6; 4:23, 28, 32; 6:6) was also being used to take advantage of worshippers. The men who inspected the animals had an agreement not to pass animals bought from anyone except the group referred to as the 'sons of Annas' (Annas was the ex-high priest and the father-in-law of Caiaphas, the current high priest). These animals cost five or six times more than animals bought elsewhere. Rather than providing a helpful service to worshippers, the authorities were exploiting the worshippers.

Making money, and not the worship of God, had become the focus of the leadership. So when Jesus *found men selling cattle, sheep and doves and others sitting at tables exchanging money* he took strong action (**2:14–16**). He was driven by his zeal for the house of the Lord (**2:17**, quoting Ps 69:9).

Jesus was promptly challenged by people asking him what authority he had to act like this when the leaders, including the high priest, permitted this trade in the temple. They wanted proof of his authority in the form of a *miraculous sign* (**2:18**). So Jesus promised them a sign: *Destroy this temple, and I will raise it again in three days* (**2:19**). The Jews thought he was speaking of the magnificent temple that Herod had begun to build in 19 BC. Their incredulous response, *It has taken forty-six years to build this temple* (**2:20**), implies that this episode took place around AD 27.

Jesus did not bother to explain that he was speaking about his body (**2:21**), which the Jews would later destroy, and was predicting his resurrection. The Jews were not ready to receive him anyway. However, the disciples did not forget these words, even though they may not have known p 1284 how to interpret them until after Jesus' resurrection from the dead. Then they were amazed that what he had predicted had been fulfilled, and *they believed the Scripture and the words that Jesus had spoken* (**2:22**). They saw in Jesus the fulfilment of Scripture and realized again that the death of their master was not an accident but part of an eternal plan.

2:23–3:21 Jesus Meets with Nicodemus

The statements made in 2:23–25 provide important background to the meeting between Jesus and Nicodemus. Jesus is presented as a miracle worker who is the object of faith (**2:23**) and as one who knows everything about people (**2:24–25**).

These qualities were probably what attracted Nicodemus' attention. He was *a man of the Pharisees*; *a member of the Jewish ruling council,* or Sanhedrin; and an admirer of Jesus (**3:1–2**). He was also someone who would have understood the saying '*Muulinza si mjinga*' [Swahili—'one who asks is not stupid']. The humility to be willing to learn even simple things is a virtue and not a weakness. Though Nicodemus is often criticized for coming at night and for not knowing what it means to be born again, a truth which he should have been able to teach, we should admire his willingness to ask simple questions.

Nicodemus did not stand on his rank but came to visit Jesus, probably as a courtesy call. But Jesus responded to Nicodemus' admiring words with a blunt statement about Nicodemus himself and his need for new birth: *I tell you the truth, no one can see the Kingdom of God unless he is born again* (**3:3**). Being 'born again' means acknowledging that one is a sinner, repenting of sin, and

inviting Jesus into one's heart as Saviour. God responds by declaring that the one who does this is his child.

Nicodemus takes the words as applying to the physical realm: *How can a man be born when he is old?* (**3:4a**). His scepticism finds fuller expression in his second question, which could be translated, *One cannot enter one's mother's womb a second time, can one?* (**3:4b**). In response, Jesus states that this 'new birth' involves being *born of water and the Spirit* (**3:5–7**). There is some debate about what exactly this phrase means, but Jesus is probably referring to John the Baptist's water baptism and his own baptism with the Holy Spirit. John's baptism was a baptism of repentance. He called people to leave their old ways of life in preparation for the coming of Jesus (Luke 3:7–14). Jesus' baptism with the Holy Spirit (1:33) brings a newness of character and the energy to move on as a member of the family of God.

The new birth is like the wind (**3:8**). We can hear the sound the wind makes and see the wind's effects, but we cannot say where it has come from. In the same way, God mysteriously brings about the new birth. We do not know how he does it, but when it has taken place, we can see its effects.

Nicodemus, beginning to realize that Jesus was not talking of physical but of spiritual birth, asked the simple question *How can this be?* (**3:9**). Jesus' response stressed three essential elements in new birth, namely, the death of the Son of Man, the love of God the Father, and human responsibility (3:13–18).

The Son of Man was Jesus' favourite title for himself. Here he explicitly says that he has come from heaven (**3:13**; see also 1:1, 14). He also predicts his death: *Just as Moses lifted up the snake in the desert, so the Son of Man must be lifted up* (**3:14**). The only way the Israelites who had been bitten by venomous snakes could escape dying was to look at the bronze snake Moses had lifted up on a pole (Num 21:4–9). Jesus, too, would be lifted up so that everyone who believed in him might have eternal life (**3:15**).

The process of the new birth began in heaven, when God's love for humankind led him to send his only Son, Jesus Christ, into the world to die for the world (**3:16a**). Jesus did not come on a mission of condemnation, but on a mission of salvation (**3:17**). We can enter into the experience of new birth by simply exercising faith (**3:16b**), that is, by accepting that Jesus has been sent by God to give us the new birth and asking him to be our Saviour and leader.

Jesus finished his conversation with Nicodemus by pointing out that there are two spheres of existence: the sphere of light and the sphere of darkness (3:19–21). The sphere of light centres on Jesus who is the Light that *has come into the world* (**3:19a**; see also 1:4–5, 9). But in general, people *loved darkness instead of light because their deeds were evil* (**3:19b**). Jesus wanted Nicodemus to realize that the only way he could enter the sphere of light was to believe in the Light come from heaven.

3:22–36 John the Baptist Testifies about Jesus

I once asked a young African boy, 'What is your name?' He replied, 'Boy'. I knew that was a nickname, and so asked him, 'What is your other name?' He replied, 'That's what Daddy calls me.' So I asked, 'Who is your father?', to which he replied, 'Daddy'. Trying to get more useful information, I asked him, 'Who is your mother?' and he told me, 'Mummy'. I tried again: 'Who does Mummy belong to?', to which he responded, 'Daddy'. Clearly, he did not yet know his parents' names, and so

I tried a different approach. 'Who lives in the house closest to your house?' The reply: 'Daddy's friend'. This young man had no identity of his own separate from his 'Daddy'. John the Baptist was like this. He defined himself in terms of his relationship to God and Jesus.

Jesus was still in Judea, where he had initially gone for the Passover (2:13). He had, however, left Jerusalem after his conversation with Nicodemus and gone into the countryside (**3:22**). Meanwhile, John was baptizing at Aenon near Salim (**3:23**). The region of Samaria lay between Judea and Aenon. Jewish travellers often chose to detour around Samaria by crossing the Jordan River near where p 1285 Jesus and his disciples were baptizing and then recrossing it near Aenon (see comments on 4:4). It was probably someone who had followed this route who got into an argument with some of John the Baptist's disciples about the issue of ceremonial washing (**3:25**). During this argument, he seems to have mentioned that Jesus was baptizing lower down the Jordan. John the Baptist's disciples were disturbed by this news because it suggested that John's influence was waning (**3:26**).

When they told John the Baptist about their concern, he pointed out that this was what he had predicted would happen (**3:28**). God had given him his role as the forerunner, and he was quite content to accept what God had given (**3:27**). Then he used another image to explain his role: he was only the friend of the bridegroom (**3:29**). At a Jewish wedding, the friend's role was to serve the bridegroom. When things were going well for the bridegroom, the friend rejoiced because that meant he had done his job well. Jesus is the bridegroom, and thus Jesus' prosperity is John the Baptist's joy. It was appropriate that attention should be focused on the groom, and that was why *he must become greater, and I must become less* (**3:30**).

But Jesus was far more than an ordinary bridegroom. John the Baptist stresses that Jesus comes *from heaven* (**3:31**). As such, Jesus is above all mere mortals and can testify about his first-hand experience of heaven (**3:32a**). John the Baptist, by contrast, can only speak of what he has been told.

Yet despite Jesus' infinitely higher status, *no one accepts his testimony* (**3:32b**). Here 'no one' is not meant to be taken literally. It is a general term, meaning that most people do not accept it. Yet acceptance of Jesus' testimony is crucial, for to refuse it is to deny that it is God's nature to be truthful and to speak the truth (**3:33**). One of the truths that God proclaims is that he will give the blessing of eternal life to those who accept Jesus. This offer is guaranteed by God's truthfulness, as those who possess eternal life can testify.

Jesus has been sent by God and so *speaks the words of God* (**3:34**). To reject his testimony is thus to reject God's word. John the Baptist can testify that the Spirit was given to Jesus in full measure (3:34; see also 1:33). Because *the Father loves the Son* (**3:35a**), he notices who accepts or rejects him. In fact, so great is the Father's love for Jesus that he has placed everything, including everyone's destiny, in his hands (**3:35b**). Jesus has ultimate authority.

Each individual's response to Jesus has consequences. Those who believe in him possess *eternal life* (**3:36a**), that is, a life lived at peace with and in the presence of God both now and in eternity. But those who reject the Son are subject to the wrath of God (**3:36b**), meaning that they will never enjoy peace with or be in the presence of God.

4:1–42 Jesus and the Samaritan Woman

In some African cultures, women are not allowed to eat certain choice cuts of meat that are reserved for men only. The exclusion of women extends to other areas of life too. One begins to

suspect that some of these prohibitions have been imposed because they benefit men. Where all women are excluded from certain things, women who carry some kind of stigma fare even worse in terms of social isolation. This was the case of the woman we meet in this passage. Jesus' approach to her speaks loudly about areas of African culture that must change.

Jesus had spent some time in Judea. At Jerusalem he had, among other things (2:23), attended the Passover (2:13), cleansed the temple (2:14–22), and conversed with Nicodemus (3:1–21). In the Judean countryside, he and his disciples had baptized (3:22), although **4:2** stresses that Jesus himself did not baptize. His reason for not performing water baptisms himself, while permitting his disciples to do them, may be that he did not want to distract attention from his basic mission of baptizing people with the Holy Spirit.

Presumably Jesus did not want to attract too much attention at this stage of his ministry, and so when he learned that the Pharisees were taking note of him (**4:1**), he set out for Galilee, travelling by way of Samaria (**4:3–4**).

Many Jews refused to take this route from Judea to Galilee. Instead they took a route that was twice as long, crossing the Jordan somewhere in Judean territory, travelling up the eastern side of the Jordan, and then recrossing the river into Galilee. The hostility between Jews and Samaritans dated back to the time when the Assyrians had settled non-Jews in this area (2 Kgs 17:23–41). Intermarriage between these settlers and local Israelites contributed to the Jews' view that the Samaritans were second-class people who should be avoided for moral reasons. Numerous incidents had kept the ancient enmity fresh over the centuries.

The conversation between Jesus and the woman took place at Jacob's well, about half a mile from the Samaritan town of Sychar on some land that Jacob had bought and given to his son Joseph (**4:5–6**; Gen 33:18–19). It was about noon (the sixth hour—4:6) and a tired Jesus was resting at the well when a woman from the town came to draw water. Jesus, who knows people's hearts (2:25), recognized her true need. He used the physical water she had come to draw as a contact point, asking, *Will you give me a drink?* (**4:7**). She refused to do so because he was a Jew and she was a Samaritan (**4:9**).

Jesus responded that she was missing a great opportunity, because he could give her *living water* (**4:10**). Such spiritual water would be far superior to any that came from the well. While the well water was a gift from Jacob (4:12), the living water was the gift of God, available from the one who was speaking to her. Not only that, but the well water p 1286 would give only temporary relief from thirst (**4:13**), whereas the living water gives eternal life (**4:14**).

The Samaritan woman was thinking in terms of physical water (**4:11–12**), and had only a vague understanding of what Jesus meant. Nevertheless, she said, *Sir, give me this water so that I won't get thirsty and have to keep coming here to draw water* (**4:15**). She was ready to receive the living water, but needed to learn more about it.

Jesus thus turned to the topic of her personal life: *Go, call your husband and come back* (**4:16**). Jesus knew all about her past life and the fact that she had no husband (**4:17–18**), but he wanted to remind her of it. When she responded *I have no husband* (4:17), Jesus commended her for her honesty, but pointed out she was not telling the full truth.

Amazed that Jesus knew about her past, she decided that Jesus must be *a prophet* (**4:19**) and took the opportunity to consult him about an issue that was hotly debated by Jews and Samaritans:

Should God be worshipped on Mount Zion in Judea or on Mount Gerizim in Samaria? (**4:20**). Jesus responded by saying that the Jews know more about God than the Samaritans do (**4:22**), but that the question itself is no longer relevant. What is more important than where worship takes place is how it takes place. True worshippers focus on the Father (**4:21**) and worship him *in spirit,* that is, within their own souls, and *in truth,* that is, with sincerity, not formalism (**4:23–24**). The reason for this kind of worship is that the Father is not a person who is located in a particular place, but a spirit who communes with the human spirit.

The Samaritan woman showed growing recognition of who Jesus was. She began by viewing him as just another Jew, and then she thought he was a prophet. Finally, Jesus presented himself to her as the expected Messiah (**4:25–26**). Excited, she left her water jar and ran back to Sychar to tell the people, *Come, see a man who told me everything I ever did. Could this be the Christ?* (**4:28–29**).

Jesus had been alone because his disciples had gone into Sychar to buy food (4:8). When they returned, they found Jesus talking to the woman (**4:27**). Even after she left, he did not seem to be in a hurry to eat, and the disciples wondered whether he had some other source of food (**4:31–33**). Jesus' response was that doing the work of God was his food (**4:34**). Just as his conversation with the Samaritan woman reminds us that there is ordinary water and living water, so his response here reminds us that there is ordinary food and spiritual food. There is deep satisfaction in doing God's work (4:34).

Jesus saw the Samaritan town as a field ready for harvest, one where the planting and harvesting of the fruit of the good news would happen at the same time (**4:35–36**). As the disciples reaped the fruit of the ministry, however, they had to remember that others before them (probably John the Baptist and the OT prophets) had prepared the hearers to receive the message (**4:37–38**).

The people of Sychar acted on the woman's invitation to 'come and see' (4:29) and kept on coming to Jesus (**4:30**). Impressed by the woman's testimony, many believed (**4:39**). They asked Jesus to stay longer with them, and he agreed, staying for two days (**4:40**). When the harvest was plentiful, Jesus altered his programme to accommodate the harvesting. The Samaritans were now able to testify that their belief was no longer rooted only in what the woman had told them, but was now based on their own experience (**4:41–42a**). They were convinced that Jesus was truly the Saviour of the world (**4:42b**).

What would have happened had Jesus been like his disciples and thought it inappropriate for a rabbi to talk to a woman in public (**4:27**)? Or if he had asked the opinion of the people of Sychar, who would probably have said, 'Don't talk to that woman; her ways are evil'? Because Jesus treated this stigmatized woman as someone worth talking to, she became a witness to Jesus, and all of Sychar was brought to him. Who knows what potential could be found within the many women Africa dismisses? Maybe they are the instruments Jesus could use to bring all Africa to him. And how many women in our cities and towns have been labelled 'women of evil ways' and dismissed by the church, leaving them at the mercy of the pleasure-seeking men who are their only source of income. Many such women are doomed to die from AIDS. Unless we follow Jesus' example, we are not being good disciples.

4:43–54 Jesus Heals the Son of a Royal Official

We often hear rumours that prominent African people are in some kind of association with Satan, particularly when they are seeking promotions, wealth, election victories and the like. Many,

including even some believers, visit witchdoctors and consult the spirits in times of need. But the official in this story knew the right place to turn to for help and he faithfully kept his eyes fixed on it. At the right time, his prayer was answered.

This miracle took place during Jesus' second ministry in Galilee and is described by John as his second sign (**4:54a**). His first sign (the changing of water into wine—John 2; **4:46a**), had taken place during his first ministry there. On both occasions, Jesus had come to Galilee from Judea (**4:54b**), and at the end of each ministry he returned there (1:43; 5:1). The alternating of Judea-Galilee, Galilee-Judea is important for John, although we are not sure why. It is possible that John is making it clear that Jesus paid attention both to 'his own country' and to the capital. Judea, and especially its capital Jerusalem, was the home of Jesus' opponents, yet it was there that the church began. Galilee was Jesus' home territory, but as Jesus himself said, *a prophet has no honour in his own country* (**4:44**). Jesus taught and performed signs both in the place that was hostile to him and in the one that took him for granted. We in Africa p 1287 need to remember both the cities and the villages. To settle in the city and forget one's village—no matter how backward that village may seem—is to neglect one's foundation and the people who made one what one is today.

After mentioning Jesus' warm reception by the Galileans (**4:45**) John focuses on a certain official who was probably attached to the court of Herod Antipas. The official's son was sick in Capernaum, some twenty miles (thirty-two kilometres) away from Cana where the man met Jesus.

Jesus' initial response to the official's request that he come and heal his son sounds unsympathetic: *Unless you people see signs and wonders you simply will not believe* (**4:47–48**). The 'you' is plural, and Jesus is speaking of the official as a typical representative of the Galileans, and probably of the Jews in general. Jesus' first desire was to bring the official to the point where he would see Jesus as the Saviour of the soul and not simply one who could miraculously heal the body.

But the official stated his need with even greater urgency: *Sir, come down before my child dies* (**4:49**) and Jesus replied, *You may go. Your son will live* (**4:50**).

While the official was on his way home to Capernaum, he met his servants who were on their way to Cana with good news—his son was recovering (**4:51**). When he learned that his son had been healed instantly at 1 p.m. (the exact time when Jesus had spoken the healing words), he and his household believed (**4:52–53**).

5:1–16 A Healing at the Pool at Bethesda

We often see someone standing or sitting at the corner of a building or outside a shop, begging. Some of these people are blind, others lame or deaf, others have been crippled in vehicle accidents, and some may simply be lazy. The sight is so familiar that most of those passing by pay no more attention to the beggars than to a stone on the corner of the street. But the beggars still keep asking, trying to attract the attention of someone who looks prosperous enough to give them something. Most of those seeking help do not enjoy asking for it like this. And sensitive passers-by may also wish that the beggars were not there. Such passers-by are acutely aware that while some of the beggars may not genuinely be in need, there are others who are in desperate need—and we do not have the resources to help them all. The incident described here, which is the third sign John records, reminds us of the importance of helping even one person. We should not let the number of needy people overwhelm us so that we help none.

Jesus had gone to Jerusalem for *a feast of the Jews* (**5:1**). It may have been Passover, Pentecost, the Feast of Weeks, or the Feast of Tabernacles. Whichever it was, it would have meant that many people were in Jerusalem. While there, Jesus went to the pool of Bethesda, which is located *near the Sheep Gate* (**5:2**). Jerusalem was surrounded by a protective wall with gates. The sheep gate was on the northern side of the city and led directly into the temple. Through it the animals were brought for sacrifice.

One of the many who lay in the five colonnades that surrounded the pool of Bethesda, waiting for the water to move, was a man who had been an invalid for thirty-eight years but had not given up hope (**5:3–5**). Jesus approached him and asked, *Do you want to get well?* (**5:6**). The man's response acknowledged that healing was available (the water was stirred from time to time) and that he was anxious to make use of this means of healing (he did try to get into the pool), but he confessed that he could not do it on his own (**5:7**). Jesus met his need, saying, *Get up! Pick up your mat and walk* (**5:8**). And the man did just that! (**5:9**).

The Jewish authorities, who were so accustomed to seeing those needing help that they paid little attention to individuals, suddenly took notice of him. They did not share his rejoicing in being healed after so many years. Instead they accused him of breaking the law by carrying a mat on a Sabbath day (for, as John repeatedly reminds us, the healing had taken place on a Sabbath (**5:10**).

The fact that it was a Sabbath and that he was carrying a mat could not be disputed, so the healed man's defence rested on the authority of the one who had told him to carry his mat, *the man who made me well* (**5:11**). The Jews' attention was thus focused on Jesus (**5:12**). But the healed man did not know that it was Jesus who had healed him, because after the healing Jesus had slipped away (**5:13**).

Later, however, Jesus found the man at the temple and spoke to him, saying: *See, you are well again; stop sinning or something worse may happen to you* (**5:14**). The man then went and told the Jewish leaders that the person who had made him well was Jesus (**5:15**). It is quite possible that they had let the man go free on condition that he find out who it was who had told him to pick up his mat and report him to them. It seems that he was not heeding Jesus' warning in 5:14. He was now sinning again by collaborating with the Jewish authorities. Jesus must have known what the man was going to do, and that he would be an unwilling party to a plot against him. The man's fear drove him to act in a way that was inconsistent with the wonderful mercy he had received.

The Jews now began to persecute Jesus. His crime was that he *was doing these things on the Sabbath* (**5:16**). The Ten Commandments had declared that the Sabbath should be a day of rest (Exod 20:8). To ensure that the day was properly observed, the Jews had expanded on the commandments to specify what actions amounted to 'not resting'. Consequently healing was permitted on the Sabbath only when life was at stake. Someone who had been ill with a debilitating disease for thirty-eight years was in no danger of immediate death, and so healing him was regarded as breaking the law. p 1288

5:17–47 The Son Gives Life

I was once asked to settle a friendly argument about 'Which came first, the chicken or the egg?' Pulling out my Bible, I read Genesis 1:20–21, which speaks of God creating birds, not eggs. My answer seemed to satisfy the debaters, but I knew that it presupposed that creation took place in twenty-four-hour days and that other interpretations are possible. If the 'days' represent extended

periods of time, there would have been time for an egg to hatch. My answer was satisfactory, but there were still loopholes in it.

We face a similar challenge when trying to define the exact relationship between God the Father and God the Son. No explanation we can offer will ever be complete, with no loopholes. But there are some passages in Scripture, like this one, that can help us understand something about this relationship.

The Jews were persecuting Jesus because he had healed on the Sabbath (5:16). Jesus responded to this persecution with the statement *My father is always at his work to this very day, and I, too, am working* (**5:17**). Although the Father ended his work of creation on the seventh day, he never takes a break from his work of caring for the world that he has created. Even on the Sabbath, God still supports the world, and Jesus models his behaviour on God's behaviour. The Jewish leaders recognized that Jesus' words were equivalent to claiming to be equal with God, and so they became even more determined to kill him (**5:18**).

Ignoring their anger, Jesus told them more about himself and his relationship with the Father and with humanity. His relationship with the Father is an equal and intimate partnership (**5:19**) characterized by love (**5:20a**), transparency (**5:20b**), equality in power (**5:21**), trust in each other's judgment (**5:22**), and shared honour (**5:23**). His relationship to humanity determines the destiny of the living and the dead. If the living have faith in him, they will be given eternal life (**5:24–25**). In due time, the dead will acknowledge him as their judge (**5:28**, **29**). The Son is the source of life (**5:26**) and the judge of all (**5:27**).

Jesus then cited several witnesses who could support his claims (5:32), namely, John the Baptist (**5:32–35**); his own works (**5:36**); the Father himself (**5:37**); and the Scriptures (**5:39**).

The Jews who were listening to him were condemned because they were not willing to come to Jesus to have life (**5:40**), did not give honour to the Son (**5:41**), did not have the love of God in them (**5:42**), and refused the one sent by God but were prepared to receive those who came in their own authority (**5:43**) and were more interested in being honoured by one another and by the Jewish authorities than in being honoured by God (**5:44**). They may have had a high regard for the law given through Moses (see 5:16; 9:28), but rather than Moses being on their side in their dispute with Jesus, he is their accuser (**5:45**). He wrote about Jesus in passages like Deuteronomy 18:18–22, but since they did not believe what Moses wrote, and thus they did not really believe in Moses, no matter what they claimed (**5:46–47**). The situation was hopeless. If they rejected the words of Moses, a man they honoured, how would they ever believe what Jesus was telling them?

Faced with the claims of Jesus and the witnesses that supported these claims, the Jews reacted with blind stubbornness. They thought they were defending Yahweh's interests, but missed the point that the Son and the Father are so closely related that whatever one does to one of them, one also does to the other.

6:1–15 Jesus Feeds Thousands

Since rainfall in Africa is not always reliable, areas of the continent are frequently struck by famine. Appeals to wealthier nations for aid sometimes provoke dismissive comments such as 'Africans are always starving.' Africans have worked to store water during times of heavy rain, but what can they do when the rains fail and begging for food produces nothing but humiliation? This passage holds

one answer to this question. It records Jesus' feeding of many people with very little, a miracle that is the fourth sign John records.

This miracle took place at Bethsaida in Galilee (**6:1**; see Luke 9:10). People were following Jesus because they were seeing his miraculous signs (**6:2**). They were more interested in his physical ministry than in the spiritual truths he was teaching. Nevertheless, Jesus took the opportunity to show them who he was by meeting their physical needs.

Jesus also used this as an opportunity to test his disciples and find out how well they were grasping the lessons he was teaching about who he was and the power he commanded. So he asked Philip (who, like Peter and Andrew, was from Bethsaida—1:44; 12:21), *Where shall we buy bread for these people to eat?* (**6:5–6**). Jesus already knew how he was going to solve the problem, for he could see the boy with the five loaves and two fish—just as he had seen Nathanael under the fig tree (1:48), knew people's hearts (2:24–25), and knew the history of the Samaritan woman (4:18).

Philip's response shows that he was thinking only in terms of money and the marketplace, for he told Jesus that even if each of the people took only a small piece of bread, it would take more than two hundred denarii to feed them. A denarius was a day's wage for a labourer, and thus the NIV correctly translates the total as *eight months' wages* (**6:7**). A better answer would have been, 'There are a lot of people, but nothing is difficult for you, Lord.'

Andrew went further than Philip, for he started looking for practical solutions. However, he had little faith in the solution he found. There was no way he could see *five small barley loaves and two small fish* feeding such a large crowd (**6:8–9**).

p 1289 Jesus' instruction, *Make the people sit down* (**6:10**), was probably directed to all the disciples. John uses the generic word 'people' here, but he uses the specifically male term when referring to the five thousand men who sat. It seems that each of these men sat down with his family around him. This arrangement would have simplified the distribution of food to the women and children who were also present (Matt 14:21).

Jesus then *took the loaves, gave thanks and distributed to those who were seated … He did the same with the fish* (**6:11**). Jesus probably did the distribution through the disciples (Matt 14:19), but John focuses on Jesus as the initial distributor because he links this feeding to spiritual feeding in the discourse that follows (6:26–71). In the spiritual realm, each individual eats directly from Christ, the bread of life.

In spite of the large number of people and the limited resources, Jesus fed them all until each was satisfied. Not only that, but the twelve disciples could each fill a basket with food that was left over (**6:12–13**). Jesus was teaching them about who he was and about his power. John, however, focuses on the crowd's reaction to the miracle. They concluded that Jesus was the awaited Prophet and wanted to make him king (**6:14**; see also 1:21). He had given them all they needed without exhausting the resources at his disposal! No wonder they wanted to establish his physical kingdom there and then. What the crowd did not realize, however, was that his kingdom is a spiritual one and that he acts in accordance with the will and timing of his heavenly Father.

The same Jesus watches over the affairs of Africa and the world in general. First, he wants each of us to believe in him as the bread of life. Then, when circumstances are beyond our control, we can expect him to take care of our physical needs, as he sees best. Unlike other nations, he will not turn

his back on us in a crisis. We can trust him to provide in some way, for he is the Lord of all possibilities.

6:16–21 Jesus Walks on Stormy Water

It is said that on long journeys my great-grandfather would pull up bushes and find water where the bush had been. Some are impressed by such stories, while others are sceptical. But here we have an eyewitness account of an amazing incident that is the fifth sign that John records.

Jesus thwarted the crowd's plan to make him king by going into the mountains by himself (**6:15**). As darkness approached, the disciples set off towards Capernaum without him (**6:16–17**). It was a windy night *and the water grew rough* (**6:18**).

The disciples had covered about twenty or thirty stadia, which is equivalent to slightly more than three miles (about five kilometres) when they saw a figure approaching the boat (**6:19a**). They did not recognize Jesus, for although they had seen him heal people with a word and multiply food to feed more than five thousand people, they had never seen him walking on water. Not surprisingly, *they were terrified* (**6:19b**).

Jesus calmed them, saying, *It is I; don't be afraid* (**6:20**). They had no need to fear either the mysterious figure that was approaching the boat or drowning in the stormy sea.

Recognizing Jesus, the disciples were willing to take him into the boat (**6:21**). Jesus, however, had not come to get a ride but to assure his disciples that he was always with them. The boat reached the shore immediately after Jesus had appeared to them.

When the disciples reached the shore, they were no longer frightened. They had confidence in Jesus' presence. Like them, we can trust his words, 'do not be afraid'. He will be with us as we go through the storms of life—whether these storms involve a lack of money, or food, or health, or wars raging around us, or any other calamity.

6:22–59 Jesus the Bread of Life

Traditionally, Africans were very good teachers, whose stories often led smoothly to an appropriate moral. Jesus, the master teacher, uses a similar approach here as he builds on his feeding of five thousand people.

The audience was the same crowd that had followed him to Bethsaida. They had lingered there after he left (6:15), expecting him to return (**6:22**). But Jesus did not return, and his disciples had gone to the other side of the lake. When they recognized that it was unlikely that Jesus would be coming back, they got into some boats from Tiberias (**6:23**) and headed for Capernaum *in search of Jesus* (**6:24**). They found him in the synagogue at Capernaum (6:59).

Jesus' interaction with the crowd falls into at least six sections, each introduced by a question or an action by the crowd. Step by step, he makes the point that he is the bread of life.

6:25–27 The opening question and Jesus' response

The crowd were curious about how Jesus had evaded them, and so their first question was *Rabbi, when did you get here?* (**6:25**). By 'here', they mean Capernaum, where they had found him.

Jesus responded by questioning their motive for looking for him. It was not primarily because they had been impressed by the miracle (not, in itself, a very good motive), but because they had enjoyed the food. Their main concern was with their stomachs (**6:26**).

Jesus wanted them to have higher motives. He told them that they should *not work for food that spoils,* such as the food he had given them at Bethsaida, *but for food that endures to eternal life* (**6:27a**). A far more important type of food was the spiritual food that *the Son of Man will give you* (**6:27b**). The 'giving' is linked to the 'working for'. The Son of Man gives this food to those who work for it.

Jesus' authority to give them this spiritual food is based on the fact that he bore God the Father's *seal of approval* p 1290 (**6:27c**). He is the one authenticated to give the food that leads to eternal life.

The crowd zeroed in on the word 'work', and this prompted their next question.

6:28–29 What works are acceptable to God?

If Jesus wanted the crowd to work for the right things, they wanted a list of what these things were. Hence their question *What must we do to do the works God requires?* (**6:28**). What works would merit God's favour?

But where the crowd thought of 'works', Jesus talked of only one 'work': *The work of God is this: to believe in the one he has sent* (**6:29**). He was speaking of a way of life rather than a set of rules to observe. It is a life characterized by the continual exercise of faith in Jesus.

This reply surprised the crowd. It was a new teaching and led them to ask about his authority to make such a claim.

6:30–33 What sign can you give us?

The crowd asked Jesus to prove that what he said was true. Their thinking in **6:30–31** seems to be like this: 'Moses gave us a list of rules to obey in order to please God. Now you say that it's not a matter of lists but simply of believing in the one God sent. We cannot believe you instead of Moses unless you do a miracle to match the one that Moses did. Moses gave manna. What about you; what can you do?'

Jesus immediately corrected the crowd's perception (**6:32**). It was not Moses who had provided the bread but Jesus' Father (see Exod 16)—the same Father who now gives the true bread from heaven. In other words, there is no competition between Moses and Jesus. Both obtained bread from the same source. But there is a difference between the manna God gave to their ancestors in the wilderness and the bread he offers now. What he gave then served only a temporary purpose; what he is giving now is the true bread. Not only that, but the new bread is a person, *For the bread of God is he who comes down from heaven and gives life to the world* (**6:33**). This describes Jesus, who constantly refers to himself as 'sent by the Father'. God intends people to eat this bread and live.

6:34–40 Give us this bread

The crowd's request for this bread in **6:34** was based on a partial understanding of what Jesus had said (see also 4:15). They understood that the bread he was speaking of was superior to the manna their fathers ate, but they did not realize that it was not for their stomachs but for their souls.

Aware that the crowd was slow to understand him, Jesus spoke more explicitly: I am *the bread of life* (**6:35a**). He is the true life-giving bread. Later he describes himself as the living bread—the bread that has life in itself and shares it with others (6:51). This statement is the first of seven key 'I am' sayings in the Gospel of John. (The other six are I am the light of the world—8:12; 9:5; I am the gate for the sheep—10:7, 9; I am the good shepherd—10:11, 14; I am the resurrection and the life—11:25; I am the way and the truth and the life—14:6; I am the true vine—15:1, 5.)

The condition for receiving the life in this bread is that one must come to Jesus, which is the same as believing in him. If this condition is met, three things will follow:

- Someone who comes to Jesus or believes in him *will never go hungry* and *will never be thirsty* (**6:35b**). The *never* emphasizes that Jesus offers an unfailing opportunity for a spiritually satisfied life. The talk thus far has been of bread, but the subject of thirst is triggered by the fact that in the wilderness the Israelites were both fed manna and given water to drink (Exod 17:1–7). Everything that the Father miraculously provided for their ancestors in the wilderness, he is now providing in the person of Christ.
- Jesus will never *drive away* anyone who comes to him (**6:37b**), regardless of race, class or gender. Some may choose to continue in unbelief (**6:36**) but Jesus is convinced that *all that the Father gives me will come to me* (**6:37a**). The focus of this statement is not on the individual who is given, but on Jesus himself. Every one of those the Father gives to him will come, and none of them will fail to come. The same point is made again in 6:44, but there Jesus focuses on the individuals who have been drawn by the Father.
- Jesus will *lose none of all that the Father has given* to him (**6:39**). Whether alive or dead, they are secure in God's plan for them. The basis for this security is that a) Jesus submits to the will of the Father (**6:38**) and b) what he is promising is the will of the Father (**6:40**). He makes it clear that failure to believe in him amounts to not being a child of God.

Jesus recognized that the crowd were not convinced: *You have seen me and still do not believe* (6:36). They had been following Jesus for some time and had seen him in action. They had been fed at Bethsaida (6:1–15). But despite all this, they did not believe. Their failure to do so implies that they did not have life. They asked him for the bread of life (6:34), but how could he possibly give it to them if they did not believe?

6:41–51 Grumbling

The crowd now started to grumble about Jesus' claim that he *came down from heaven* (6:33, 38). How could he make such claims when they knew his home and his parents? (**6:41–42**).

Jesus told them to stop grumbling (**6:43**) and pointed out that they must be taught (drawn) of God before they could accept his claim to be the bread from heaven (**6:44**). The word translated 'draw' has the idea of attractive power. It is the same word Jesus uses later in 12:32. As the crowd looked at Jesus, they saw nothing to attract them. He was p 1291 an ordinary fellow whose parents

they knew. However, as God manifested himself through the Son, they would notice more of his glory, and Jesus would attract them more.

The link between being taught and being drawn becomes clear in Jesus' quotation from the prophets: *they will all be taught by God* (**6:45a**; see also Isa 54:13; Jer 31:33, 34). Jesus then adds, *everyone who listens to the Father and learns from him comes to me* (**6:45b**). The Father's interest is in glorifying the Son, through the works the Son does and the words the Son speaks.

Jesus also reminded the crowd that *no one has seen the Father except the one who is from God* (**6:46**). The fact that Jesus is the only one who has ever seen the Father gives his words about the Father and his plan of salvation authority over anyone else's.

He then went on to reiterate some of the key truths he had communicated already:

- The one who believes has everlasting life (**6:47**).
- He (Jesus) is the bread of life (**6:48**).
- The crowd's ancestors appreciated the manna in the wilderness because it was their main food for forty years (see Exod 16). Yet despite the fact that they were eating food that God had supplied, they eventually died (**6:49**). Nevertheless, the supply had been so memorable that it was still remembered as a miracle associated with Moses (6:31).
- The bread that Jesus gives is far better than manna, for anyone who eats the bread from heaven will never die (**6:50**). Refusing the offer of such bread is an illogical thing to do.

Finally, in **6:51** Jesus summarizes all that he has been saying. He stresses that a) he is the living bread come from heaven; b) the one who eats of this bread lives forever; and c) the bread he will give for the life of the world is his flesh. Translated literally, 6:51b reads, *And in fact the bread which I myself will give is the very flesh of mine—for the world's life*. Jesus emphasizes that the bread is his flesh and it is he who will give it. Within a short time, he will voluntarily give his flesh to be crucified on the cross. The purpose of it all will be so that the world (humankind) can obtain life.

6:52–59 An argument among themselves

Earlier the crowd had merely grumbled (6:41), but by now, they were actively arguing with each other about the question *How can this man give us his flesh to eat?* (**6:52**). Probably, some were beginning to understand what Jesus was saying, while others did not.

In his response, Jesus' main goal was to expand on the central idea that the living bread from heaven that gives life is his own flesh. So he stressed that one must eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink his blood to have life (**6:53**). Those in the crowd still thinking on a physical level must have been even more shocked by what Jesus said here, for God had forbidden the drinking of blood (Deut 12:16).

Those who obey the condition stated in 6:53 have eternal life and Jesus *will raise them up at the last day* (**6:54**). This is the third reference to the resurrection of believers in this discourse (see also 6:40 and 6:44). There can be no doubt that this will happen, for Jesus' flesh is real food and his blood is real drink (**6:55**). The word translated 'real' here focuses on true as opposed to false. There is nothing counterfeit about what he offers.

The word used for 'eating' in 6:54 is repeated again in **6:56, 57,** and **58.** It is a word that usually refers to eating fruit or vegetables with enjoyment. It is also in the present tense, which shows that the spiritual blessing of eternal life is enjoyed by those who have made it their habit to feed on Jesus' flesh with enjoyment and who continually drink his blood. This underscores the point that the one who eats and drinks remains in Jesus and Jesus remains in him (**6:56**). They are bound in an intimate relationship. In fact, they are part of a chain of life that runs from the living Father to the Son to anyone who feeds on the living Son (**6:57**).

Once again, Jesus contrasted what he was offering with the manna their ancestors had eaten. The manna only sustained life for a short time before those who ate it died (**6:58**), but the effect of this living bread (that is, Jesus' flesh) is eternal (**6:58**).

6:60–71 Jesus Deserted by Many Disciples

As Jesus spoke of his flesh being the bread of life, and of the need to eat it and drink his blood, those who heard him included the Twelve (6:67), other disciples (6:60, 61, 66), and a mixed crowd of newcomers (some of whom had joined the crowd as recently as the journey to Bethsaida). The disciples had probably kept quiet while Jesus taught the crowd and the crowd asked questions. Now, however, they spoke up.

This wider circle of Jesus' followers (possibly including the Twelve) said, *This is a hard saying, who can accept it?* (**6:60**). Translated literally, their question is, 'Who is able to hear it with appreciation?' They find it puzzling. How can one eat Jesus' flesh and drink his blood?

Jesus knew that the disciples were grumbling (**6:61**). In this Gospel, we are constantly reminded that Jesus is all-knowing (omniscient). The point is repeated in 6:64. So he responds to their question with a question of his own, that could be paraphrased as 'Since you are offended by my claim to be the bread come from heaven, and my statement that you must eat my flesh, what would happen if you were to see the Son of Man going back to his original state? Would you be able to appreciate that higher glory at all?' (**6:62**). The claim that he is the bread of life is a small one compared to the claims he can make from eternity.

He went on to remind the disciples that his words have a heavenly origin and must be understood in a heavenly context. If they think of eating his flesh and drinking his blood only in earthly terms, they are missing the point. Their type of human logic (*flesh*) counts for nothing; what is important p 1292 is the spiritual dimension of his words, which are spirit and life (**6:63**). This division between the spirit and the flesh is not new in John, for the same point is made in 3:6.

Jesus was well aware that some of his disciples did not like what he was saying and did not believe his claims (**6:64**). He reminded them that they needed the Father's help to come to him (**6:65**). The 'coming' of which he speaks here is more profound than the 'coming' in 6:45. Here the person comes with expectation, hoping to receive all that Jesus has to offer. Judas and some of the other disciples who did not believe had come to Jesus and were with him physically, but their hearts were elsewhere. Only God could turn those indifferent hearts and bring them to follow Jesus sincerely.

John tells us that *from this time* or *out of this* (the Greek could be translated either way, and both meanings apply) *many of his disciples turned back and no longer followed him* (**6:66**).

So far, the Twelve have not played a prominent role. They have probably been listening and observing quietly while their teacher and master taught very difficult material. They have also watched people they had thought were sincere followers of Jesus stop following him. Then Jesus turned to them, and asked, *You do not want to leave too, do you?* (**6:67**). Clearly, he expected their answer to be 'no'. He knew their hearts, and knew that all of them (except, of course, Judas Iscariot) were sincere. He thus expected more from them than from the outer circle of disciples, and they knew it.

Peter was the spokesman for the Twelve when he gave three reasons why they were determined to stay with Jesus:

- No one compares with Jesus (**6:68a**).
- Jesus has the words of eternal life (**6:68b**). Other teachers could utter learned words to their disciples, but Jesus' words are special. They give eternal life, a life of fellowship with God.
- Jesus is the Holy One of God (6:69). Peter and his eleven classmates had watched and heard, and had drawn the conclusion that Jesus is 'holy', that is, one who has been set apart or consecrated to God.

Jesus' response amounts to saying, 'That is a good answer, but do not forget this also—I myself (note emphasize) chose the twelve of you, but one of you is worse than an unbeliever. He is a devil.' He was speaking of Judas Iscariot (**6:70–71**). The word 'devil' means 'an accuser'. John uses it elsewhere for Satan (8:44; 13:2). While Satan remains the devil proper, those who accomplish his schemes, like Judas Iscariot, are devils because they are imitating or following Satan. As two Akamba (Kenya) proverbs say, *kaswii ka ngo katutasya ngo* ['the leopard's cub takes after its mother'] and *kaswii ka nzoka no nzoka* ['the young of a snake is a snake'].

7:1–13 Jesus Secretly Goes to the Feast of Tabernacles

Jesus continued his work in Galilee and did not go to Jerusalem for the Passover mentioned in 6:4. He was deliberately avoiding Judea, where the Jewish leaders were waiting for him, hoping to kill him (**7:1**). Six months later, however, Jesus' brothers (Matt 13:55; Mark 6:3) challenged him to go to Jerusalem for the Feast of Tabernacles, which was one of the three most important Jewish feasts (**7:2–4**). Their message was, 'You must not miss this great opportunity. There will be huge crowds there to see your miracles.' But there was more to their message than meets the eye. There is a saying, *itho ithuku iyula ngiti* (Akamba, Kenya—'a dog will always recognize a hostile eye', meaning that wise people can detect hidden ill feelings towards them). John lets us know that *even his own brothers did not believe in him* (**7:5**). Their real motive was to expose Jesus to the scrutiny of the renowned scholars in Jerusalem. He might be able to fool ignorant Galilean peasants, but in Jerusalem he would face a real test.

Jesus responded by contrasting himself and his brothers. He operated in accordance with his Father's timetable, which had a right and a wrong time for doing things. The brothers had no such restriction (**7:6**). Moreover, the brothers did not have to deal with the enmity of *the world* (**7:7**), that is, the system of unbelief that Jesus had constantly been challenging. In Jerusalem, he was hated because he healed on the Sabbath and claimed an intimate relationship with God (5:18). His brothers had not said or done anything that was opposed to the world, and so there was no reason for the world to treat them as enemies.

Jesus concluded by saying, *I am not yet going up to this Feast, because for me the right time has not yet come* (**7:8**). Some ancient Greek manuscripts include the word 'yet' in 7:8 and others do not, which is why there are different translations of this verse. But the bottom line is that Jesus refused to attend when the timing was dictated by his brothers. Similarly, he refused to allow his timing to be dictated by his mother at the wedding in Cana (2:4). His timetable was set by the Father.

Jesus stayed on in Galilee after his brothers had left, but later he did quietly go up to the Feast. Presumably, 'the right time' had then arrived (**7:9–10**). His departure from Galilee was in secret, and so was his stay near Jerusalem until the time came for him to make a public appearance (7:10, 14). But the fact that he was not visible did not mean that he was not talked about. The Jewish authorities were watching for him, wondering whether he would come (**7:11**). They remembered the miraculous healing of the man who had been sick for thirty-eight years and the controversy that had followed.

The ordinary people were also asking the same question and discussing Jesus. Some said, *he is a good man;* others said that he *deceives the people* (**7:12**). They conducted their p 1293 arguments in whispers *for fear of the Jews* (**7:13**), that is, of the Jewish authorities. No one was sure exactly what the leadership's position was, though it seemed likely that they were hostile, as they had attempted to kill him. One might get into trouble for saying openly that Jesus was a good man. But it was also possible that the leaders would change their minds, and so it was unwise to say too loudly that Jesus was a deceiver. Everyone preferred to wait until the leadership's stand was made public.

7:14–24 Jesus Teaches in Public at the Feast

After resisting his brothers' and the crowd's attempts to give him public exposure, Jesus finally stepped forward in such a way that there was no need for anyone to search for him. In the middle of the Feast, Jesus went up *to the temple courts and began to teach* (**7:14**). His teaching amazed his hearers: *How did this man get such learning without having studied?* (**7:15**). They saw him as a Galilean carpenter who had no formal education in theology. But what he was saying showed that he knew what he was talking about.

Jesus responded by pointing out that his doctrine came from God (**7:16**). Other teachers might cite human authorities as the basis for their opinions, but God himself was the source of Jesus' teaching. So instead of assessing Jesus' teaching in terms of what other traditional authorities had to say on the subject, people should consider how Jesus' teaching related to the will of God. If they really wanted to do God's will, they would be able to come to a correct judgment about what Jesus was teaching (**7:17**).

Jesus also suggested a test they could use to see whether teaching did or did not come from God. The test was whether the teacher was seeking his or her own glory or the glory of God (**7:18**) Jesus had consistently focused on the glory of God, and so his teaching could be judged to be true.

But while Jesus was true, the same could not be said for his opponents. They did not keep the law they claimed to uphold (**7:19**) Their wanting to kill Jesus was not in conformity with the commandment that states, *you shall not murder* (Exod 20:13).

The people responded defensively, denying the accusation and asserting that Jesus was crazy to make it (**7:20**). Jesus reminded them of the reason others were trying to kill him (5:18). He had caused offence by healing a man who had been sick for thirty-eight years on a Sabbath (ch. 5). He

then defended his action by comparing it to circumcision. The Jews were quite happy to circumcise a baby boy on the Sabbath (**7:22**). This act focused on only one part of the body, the boy's sexual organ. Jesus, however, had healed a whole man, in numerous parts of his body. If the Jews thought they were justified in attending to one part, then surely there was even more to be said for a still greater healing. So why did the Jews insist that their act was justified but Jesus' act deserved the death penalty? (**7:23**). No wonder Jesus told them, *stop judging by mere appearances, and make a right judgment* (**7:24**).

7:25–36 How Can the Christ Come from Galilee?

The people had good reason for their confusion about who Jesus was. They knew that the authorities had wanted to kill him (5:18). But why then were they not preventing him from teaching in the temple? Did this mean that the authorities might have concluded that Jesus really was the Christ (**7:25–26**)? But if they had, how could that be reconciled with the widespread belief that *when the Christ comes, no one will know where he is from* (**7:27**). They knew where Jesus came from: he had a home in Nazareth, his parents were Joseph and Mary, and he had brothers and sisters (Matt 13:55–56; Mark 6:3).

Jesus recognized their confusion and cried out that what they knew was true, but there was even more that they did not know (**7:28–29**). They knew his human parents, but they did not know God, who had sent Jesus into the world. Jesus, however, does know God because he is from God. As an ambassador of God who *is true*, he has a valid mission that everyone should listen to.

In spite of the antagonism of some of the people (7:27) and of their leaders' attempts to seize him (**7:30**), many in the crowd put their faith in Jesus (**7:31**). They believed that Jesus had done what the Messiah would do and that there was no way anyone else could *do more miraculous signs than this man*. On this basis, Jesus must be the Messiah.

The rulers' attempt *to seize him* failed because Jesus had a predestined course to follow and no one could interfere with it (7:30). But this did not stop them from launching another attempt, prompted by the people's positive attitude towards Jesus (**7:32**). Jesus responded by announcing that he would only be with them for a little longer and then he would return to the one who sent him (**7:33**). The time was indeed short, for this was said approximately six months before his crucifixion.

Jesus warned them that after his departure, they would look for him and would not be able find him (**7:34a**). They might try to arrest him now, but soon they would not even be able to find him to arrest him because his incarnate state would have ended. He would be in a place they could not reach. It is worth noting Jesus' exact words here. He says, *where I am you cannot come* (**7:34b**). The present tense, 'I am', emphasizes that Jesus is still present with the Father. He has been with him from eternity past, is present with him as he speaks, and will be with him in eternity future.

But while Jesus was speaking of his return to glory, the Jewish leaders thought that he was simply saying that he would go into hiding outside Palestine (**7:35–36**).

7:37–44 Jesus' Final Lesson in the Temple

On the last and greatest day of the feast (7:37), which could be the seventh (Lev 23:34; Deut 16:13, 15) or the eighth day p 1294 (Lev 23:36), Jesus made a declaration: *If anyone is thirsty, let him come*

to me and drink. Whoever believes in me, as the Scripture has said, streams of living water will flow from within him (**7:37–38**). This statement may have been prompted by the ceremony that celebrated the gift of water from the rock in the wilderness (Exod 17:1–7). The high priest would draw water from the fountain of Gihon, carry it back in a processions to the temple and pour it into a vessel at the altar until it overflowed to the ground Jesus picked up on the physical thirst that their ancestors must have experienced in the wilderness before God miraculously provided water. He offered to meet their spiritual thirst if they would come to him for the water that eternal life.

In the ceremony, the water overflowed its container, and Jesus promised that whoever drank from him (by believing in him) would also be filled to overflowing (7:38) He meant that believers would be filled with the Holy Spirit (**7:39**) and may have been thinking of passages such as Joel 2:28–29) (also quoted in Acts 2:16–21).

Jesus' words split the crowd into at least four groups (**7:43**):

- Those who said he was the Prophet who they thought would prepare the way for the Messiah (**7:40**; see also Deut 18:15).
- Those who said he was the Christ, the Messiah they had been waiting for (7:41; see also 7:31).
- Those who said that he could not be the Christ because he came from Nazareth and not from Bethlehem, the town of David (**7:41–42**). These people did not know the story of his birth.
- Those who said he was a bad man, as implied by the comment that *some wanted to seize him* (**7:44**).

7:45–52 Jewish Leaders Think Jesus Is a Deciever

The guards who had been sent to arrest Jesus (7:32) came back empty-handed, reporting only that *no one ever spoke the way this man does* (**7:45–46**). The Pharisees were not amused and challenged the guards by asking two questions. The first was, *Are you also deceived?* (**7:47**). As temple police officers, the guards were expected to protect the interests of the temple. In speaking well of Jesus, they were behaving just like the crowd. The second question was, *Has any of the rulers or of the Pharisees believed in him?* (**7:48**). The expected answer was, 'No'. That being the case, the guards were wrong—for the rulers and Pharisees were the ones who determined correct belief and practice. This attitude explains their contempt for the ordinary people who acknowledged that Jesus was the Christ (7:41). The Pharisees referred to them dismissively as *this mob that knows nothing of the law.* They regarded those who had not studied the details of the law as misled and thus cursed (**7:49**).

Nicodemus, who had gone to Jesus earlier (3:1–2), now asked his fellow-Pharisees, *Does our law condemn anyone without first hearing him to find out what he is doing?* (**7:50–51**). Once again, the expected answer was 'No'. Nicodemus could cite Scriptures such as Exodus 23:1 and Deuteronomy 1:16 to back up his request for a fair hearing before passing judgment.

Nicodemus' question was meant to prick the consciences of his fellow Pharisees, but they brushed it aside. They had already made up their minds. Rather than dealing with his question, they ridiculed him: *Are you from Galilee too?* (**7:52a**). They knew that Nicodemus was from Judea, but were implying that no Judean could possibly be taken in by Jesus. He was a Galilean and could only deceive Galileans. The Judeans were too bright to believe in him!

Their contempt for the Galileans was also expressed in the statement *Look into it, and you will find that a prophet does not come out of Galilee* (**7:52b**). The Pharisees were probably not denying that any prophet had ever come from Galilee. After all, Jonah came from Gath-hepher, which is only three miles (five kilometres) north of Nazareth. Their point was that the Galileans were not the type of people to produce prophets.

Either Nicodemus was not given an opportunity to respond or he decided to remain silent before his colleagues became suspicious of his continued opposition to their plans.

7:53–8:11 Jesus and the Woman Caught in Adultery

Though there is debate about whether this passage was originally part of John's Gospel, the incident rings true to what we know of Jesus' character. It happened in the temple after the Feast of Tabernacles (**8:1–2**). Bringing this woman to Jesus was part of the strategy of the teachers of the law (scribes) and Pharisees to discredit Jesus (**8:3–6a**). They thought that the only options Jesus had were either to say 'leave her alone' or 'stone her'. The first would suggest that he did not take her sin seriously enough, and the other (although required by the law—Lev 20:10; Deut 22:22) would lead people to doubt whether Jesus lived out his message of love and mercy.

Jesus responded by writing something on the ground (**8:6b**). We are not told what he wrote, but it may have been the sins of her accusers or Scriptures focusing on mercy and kindness. It must have been related in some way to his words *if any one of you is without sin, let him be the first to throw a stone at her* (**8:7**). By saying this, Jesus shifted the focus from himself and the woman to her accusers. He neither denied the validity of the law nor condemned the woman to death. The accusers left one by one, *the older ones first*—probably because of their longer experience of life and temptation (**8:9**). *Undu kikame kiambaa kite kikwatye tiwo kiambaa kyakwatwa* [Akamba, Kenya—'the bush baby makes a different cry when it is trapped']. When all her accusers were gone, Jesus told the woman, *Neither do I condemn you. Go now and leave your life of sin* (**8:10–11**). Jesus was not in the world to condemn it but to save it (3:17) and p 1295 those needing to be saved included this woman. He commanded her to begin a new life.

8:12–20 Jesus Defends His Testimony

Jesus then returned to teaching *the people*, that is, the crowd he was teaching when he was interrupted by the teachers of the law and the Pharisees. He declared, *I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will never walk in darkness, but will have the light of life* (**8:12**). He was speaking just after the Feast of Tabernacles, during which the whole city of Jerusalem had been illuminated by huge candles, and was claiming that he illuminates the whole world, and not just Jerusalem.

The Pharisees mocked his claim: *Here you are, appearing as your own witness; your testimony is not valid* (**8:13**). What one says about oneself is suspect because we tend to present ourselves in a favourable light. As the Akamba (Kenya) say, *mundu avulasya makaa elekelye ngali iyake* ['when people are warming themselves at the fire, each moves the burning charcoal towards himself']. Moreover, the Jewish legal system required two or three witnesses to support any assertion (**8:17**; see also Deut 17:6; 19:15). The Pharisees were saying that Jesus' testimony could not be relied upon in a court of law. Jesus had faced this kind of challenge before, and had responded by listing two or three other witnesses, independent of himself (5:31–47).

On this occasion, however, he did not humbly accept their argument but corrected their assumptions. He is different from other men and his witness is reliable. He can speak with authority because he has come from the Father and is going back to him (**8:14**). He is not just another man talking about himself. He is one with the Father and his testimony is in accordance with the will of the Father.

The Pharisees (and others) were judging by human standards that did not apply to Jesus (**8:15a**; see also 7:24). They thought that he was just the son of Mary and Joseph, whereas he had been with the Father long before his association with them.

When Jesus said that he judges no one (**8:15b**), he was speaking within the context of his mission on earth. He had come to save people, not to judge or condemn them (12:47; see also 3:17). But this did not mean that he would never pass judgment during his time on earth. And at his second coming, he will pass judgment on the basis of what people have done with his offer of salvation (5:27; see also 2 Tim 4:1).

When, out of necessity, Jesus did judge during his first mission, his judgments were right because the Father and the Son are united in judgment (**8:16**). Thus his evaluation of the Pharisees in 8:14 is accurate.

Returning to the original point, Jesus said that if his opponents insisted on having two witnesses, he could give them two—the Father and himself (**8:18**). Jesus had just defended his right to be the first witness, so the Pharisees now tackled him on the subject of the second witness, asking *Where is your Father?* (**8:19a**). They wanted to see Jesus' earthly father because they failed to recognize that Jesus was talking of his heavenly Father.

Jesus ended the debate by again using his prerogative as a judge. He told the Pharisees that a) they did not know him and b) they did not know his Father (**8:19b**). When they looked at Jesus, they saw the man from Nazareth. Their lack of true knowledge about him resulted in their not knowing his Father either. If they had realized that the Father he was speaking of was Yahweh, they would not have needed to ask where he was.

This debate took place in the part of the temple where there were thirteen chests into which people dropped the offerings that supported the various activities of the temple (**8:20**). It was thus an area where there was a constant flow of people.

8:21–30 Jesus, the Way Out of Death

Jesus now returned to a topic he had dealt with earlier: *I am going away, and you will look for me, and you will die in your sins. Where I go, you cannot come* (**8:21**; 7:33). As before, the Jews were puzzled by his words. Earlier, they had thought that he might be going to hide among the Jews living outside Israel (7:33–35). This time, they considered the possibility of suicide (**8:22**). They believed that those who committed suicide went to hell. So if Jesus committed suicide, they would not go where he was going, for they were quite sure that they were going to heaven.

Once again, Jesus had to emphasize the contrast between himself and the Jews. They had come from two different places (**8:23**). Everyone in the crowd had been born and lived on Earth. Jesus, however, had come to earth from somewhere else. As a consequence of their different origins, they were governed by different principles. They operated as people who were part of an evil system; Jesus was not part of that system—he had come to destroy it.

Jesus' response could be paraphrased like this: 'You live completely in this world and have no hope of gaining the world above except through me, because I have come from that world. However, your refusal to accept this fact means that you cannot be helped. You are living in your sins and you will die there' (**8:24**).

The Jewish leaders understood that Jesus was saying that he was quite different from them, and so they asked him directly about his identity (**8:25**). What was his authority? Who was he in God's programme?

Jesus reminded the crowd of what he had been saying before when he was teaching them (8:28). In the discourses recorded in chapters 6 and 7 and in 8:1–24, they had heard him claim to be the bread of life, the light of the world, the one sent from above, and many other things. He then highlighted four things about himself:

p 1296 • **I am your judge** (**8:26a**). He has already stated his judgment that they will die in their sins.

- **I was sent by the one who is reliable** (**8:26b**). The theme of Jesus' being sent by the Father comes up again and again (see 4:34; 8:16; 16:5; 17:3; 20:21).
- **I speak the things I have heard from the Father** (**8:26c**). What Jesus taught is the truth.
- **I am God's workmate** (**8:29**). He and his Father work in total harmony.

Some Jews would only realize the truth of these claims after they had killed Jesus (**8:28**). That evil deed would lead to even greater things that would convince them that Jesus' claims were true.

Although Jesus had predicted they would die in their sins, the way of faith was still open to all. *Even as he spoke,* many chose the path of life and *put their faith in him* (**8:30**).

8:31–38 Jesus, the True Liberator

Many countries in Africa celebrate the day when they ceased to be colonies and became free nations. But not everyone enjoys the fruit of freedom. Many in Africa are still in bondage, suffering evils such as nepotism, corruption, self-centredness, murder and the like. The liberation spoken of in this passage makes it possible for each resident of a free nation to reap the benefits of political independence.

The passage takes the form of a dialogue between Jesus and Jews who had accepted his message at a mental level only. To them, Jesus says, *If you hold my teaching, you are really my disciples. Then you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free* (**8:31–32**). The 'holding' here involves hearing, accepting and obeying his teaching. It is not enough for them simply to give mental assent to what he says. If they want to be in a real relationship with him, they have to set out to live according to his teaching. As they open their hearts and minds to learn from him, they will experience true freedom.

The Jews, however, felt that they were free already: *we are Abraham's descendants and have never been slaves of anyone* (**8:33**). Some people believed in a tradition that their descent from Abraham gave them royal status, and that although they might be subject to Rome politically, their souls remained free under their only ruler, Yahweh.

Jesus pointed out that the freedom that matters most is moral or spiritual freedom. *Everyone who sins is a slave to sin* (**8:34**). Thus all of them, as sinners, are also slaves. He, however, is not a slave to sin (see 8:46) but the Son in God's family, and as such has the right to free slaves, liberating them from the chains that bind them (**8:35–36**). He does this for those who ask for it in faith. Those who seek to kill him, instead of coming to him for liberation, are clearly enemies of his Father and consequently belong to another father (**8:37–38**).

8:39–47 Jesus, the Basis for Legitimacy in God's Family

The Jews were indignant at Jesus' suggestion that they did not have the same father as his. They insisted that Abraham was their Father (**8:39a**). So Jesus pointed out that sonship to Abraham and a desire to kill Jesus were in contradiction. Abraham, a friend of God who is the Father of Jesus, would not do that. Their actions showed that they could not claim Abraham as their father (**8:39b–41**).

The Jews objected even more strenuously, *We are not illegitimate children.* They were asserting that they were true descendants of Abraham and had only one ultimate Father, *God himself* (8:41). However, as the Akamba say, *mauta ma kwivaka mainoasya* ['oil applied on the body does not make one fat'].

Jesus exposed the falsity of their argument by pointing out that because he had been sent by God, his opponents had only two alternatives: either they accepted his teaching, thus showing that they belonged to God, or they rejected it, showing that they did not belong to him (**8:42, 47**). These Jews had chosen the second option, and thus they must have another father, one who was opposed to God. This father, who had previously been referred to as *your father* (8:38) or *your own father* (8:41) is now identified by name as the devil (8:44). Their plan to kill Jesus, who was not guilty of any crime, and their refusal to believe the truth that he proclaimed were exactly the types of behaviour that would be expected from the devil, for he has always been a murderer and he neither follows nor speaks the truth (**8:43–46**).

One's attitude towards Jesus is what makes the difference between having true descent from Abraham or not—between being a legitimate member of God's family or not a member at all. One's membership in that family is not affected by one's claims (as in 8:41b), but by one's relationship with Jesus.

8:48–59 Jesus Makes Claims About Himself

The group Jesus was speaking to here were earlier referred to as having 'believed him' (8:31). They had accepted some of what he said. However, Jesus' challenge to their false security as Abraham's descendants made them increasingly hostile. After all, Jesus had told them that their conduct did not match Abraham's (8:39, 40), that God was not their Father (8:42), and that their true father was the devil (8:44).

So now they expressed their opinion of Jesus. They no longer referred to him as the son of Joseph and Mary, as they did before (6:42). Now they labelled him *a Samaritan and demon-possessed* (**8:48**). The Samaritans had some Jewish blood but were viewed as impure in their belief and practice. They were looked down on and were not accepted as teachers of the law. And anyone who was 'demon-possessed' could not be teaching the will of God, but only the will of the devil under whose governance demons operate.

p 1297 Jesus denied the second of these accusations. Rather than being under demonic influence, he sought to honour the Father (**8:49**). The Father, who is the judge in these matters, wants the Jews to honour Jesus (**8:50**). In other words, failure to glorify Jesus is equivalent to disobeying God.

Jesus extended his invitation, saying, *I tell you the truth, if anyone keeps my word, he will never see death* (**8:51**). Jesus was interested in far more than just answering accusations or insults. He wanted to bring his audience to the place where they accepted his word, which gives eternal life.

The Jews, however, thought that Jesus was speaking in terms of physical life, and took this appeal as confirmation that he was mad, or *demon-possessed* (**8:52**). After all, Abraham, their greatest ancestor, had died. So had the prophets, who were God's appointed messengers (8:52). Jesus could be greater than Abraham and he would also die (**8:53**). So how could he dare to say that those who keep his word will not die?

Jesus reminded them again that it is the Father (whom the Jews say is their God) who glorifies him (**8:54**). Thus their insults to Jesus were insults to God. If Jesus were to deny that he knows the Father in a special way, he would be telling a lie (**8:55**). Moreover, Abraham has given total approval to Jesus' ministry. One who gives joy to Abraham cannot be demon possessed (**8:56**).

This claim provoked even more scorn: *You are not yet fifty years old and you have seen Abraham!* (**8:57**). Abraham had lived hundreds of years earlier. Jesus responded by insisting that he was even older than Abraham (**8:58**). The Jews were thinking only in terms of his human existence, which began in Bethlehem in 4 BC, but Jesus was referring to his eternal existence.

The Jews took Jesus' words as an insult to Abraham, their greatest ancestor. Not only did Jesus present himself as equal to Abraham, but he claimed to be older than Abraham! Such an insult should be punished by death (**8:59**). But Jesus slipped away from them, for it was not yet time for him to die.

9:1–41 Jesus Heals a Man Blind from Birth

9:1–12 The healing

Jesus did not go into hiding after the Jews' attempt to stone him (8:59). He went about his business in Jerusalem, and as he *went along* he encountered a man who had been blind since birth (**9:1**).

The Jews believed that every form of suffering was due to sin. So the disciples asked Jesus, *Rabbi, who sinned, this man or his parents, that he was born blind?* (**9:2**). Were his parents being punished for some sin by having a blind son? Or was the man himself being punished for some sin he had committed before he was even born, while still in his mother's womb or maybe in some pre-existent state before his soul joined his body?

Jesus rejected both options: *This happened so that the work of God might be displayed in his life* (**9:3**). After reminding them that he was the light of the world and that there was still work to be done (**9:4–5**; see also 8:12), he proceeded to heal the blind man by spitting on the ground, making some mud with the saliva, putting mud on the man's eyes, and instructing him to go and wash in the pool of Siloam. The man obeyed and received his sight (**9:6–7**). Jesus combined both a miraculous act and a therapeutic touch. The healing required both Jesus' instructions and the man's obedience,

for it was not the washing in the pool of Siloam but Jesus who healed the man, yet if he had refused to wash, he would not have been healed.

The man's neighbours and others who knew him were puzzled. Was this really the same man who used to sit and beg? (**9:8**). The change was so great that some doubted his identity. But he *insisted, 'I am the man*' (**9:9**). So they wanted to know, *How then were your eyes opened?* (**9:10**).

The man described what Jesus had said and done. He had only been able to feel what Jesus did, not see it, which is likely why he did not mention the spitting. He had felt Jesus put mud on his eyes. He had heard his voice telling him to go to the pool of Siloam. He had found that he could see after he obeyed Jesus' words. The man simply reported what he had experienced (**9:11**).

Not surprisingly, the neighbours wanted to meet the one responsible for this remarkable healing and asked, *Where is this man*? (**9:12**). But the healed man could not tell them, for after instructing him to go and wash in the pool of Siloam, Jesus did not stand around to wait for him. He went on with his business.

9:13–34 The Pharisees interrogate the healed man

Instead of rejoicing with the healed man, the neighbours focused on the fact that this healing had taken place on a Sabbath (**9:14**). Because they did not have authority to act in regard to this, they took the man to the Pharisees (**9:13**). Although the Pharisees had probably heard the whole story from the man's neighbours, they wanted to hear it for themselves too. They asked him how he had been healed, and he told them (**9:15**).

After hearing his testimony, the Pharisees were divided about how to react. Some focused on the issue of the Sabbath and argued that Jesus could not have come from God because if he had, he would keep the Sabbath. Others focused on the miraculous sign and argued that the healing itself was an indication that he came from God. God would not give a sinner the power to do something like this (**9:16**).

After arguing for some time, they decided to ask the blind man's opinion. Their question to him may have been an honest request for his opinion or it may have been a trap to find out what he thought so that they could deal with him p 1298 later. The man had no hesitation in declaring, *He is a prophet* (**9:17**), that is, someone who delivers God's message.

In order to eliminate any possibility of mistaken identity, the parents were brought in (**9:18–19**). They were asked to confirm that there had genuinely been a healing and state how it took place. They could confirm that the man was indeed their son and that he had been born blind (**9:20**). As to how he could now see, they simply said, *We don't know* (**9:21**). John tells us that the parents were lying (**9:23**). Their son must have told them that Jesus had healed him, but they were afraid because they knew that Jesus was unpopular with the authorities (**9:22**). They did not want to be put out of the synagogue, the place of worship and the only place, they thought, where one could receive God's blessings.

Seeing that they were getting nowhere with the parents, the Pharisees again asked the man what he had to say about Jesus. The first time they had asked him this question, they had used an open question that gave him the freedom to express his own opinion (9:17). But this time they simply made a statement: *Give God the glory, we know this man is a sinner* (**9:24**). They were implying that the only position that gave God the glory was the one they had taken. Giving Jesus

credit for the healing would be equivalent to approving of his breaking of the Sabbath law. Thus the man must be wrong in saying that Jesus was a prophet (9:17).

The man did not know all the theological arguments about the Sabbath and about whether or not it was a sin to heal on the Sabbath. So he replied, *Whether he is a sinner or not, I don't know* (**9:25a**). He would have known that it was a sin to violate a Sabbath regulation for any reason not specifically approved by the Sanhedrin (such as the need to circumcise a boy on the eighth day after his birth, even if this was a Sabbath). But whether God would cooperate with a sinner to bring healing on the Sabbath was an unanswered question. There was, however, one thing that he was sure of, the thing that mattered most to him: *I was blind but now I see* (**9:25b**). He had no doubt whatever about that.

The Pharisees, probably sensing that the man was being evasive and not simply agreeing with them, asked him their last and deciding question: *What did he do to you? How did he open your eyes?* (**9:26**). They probably wanted to extract a list of the exact things Jesus had done that violated the Sabbath law.

The man refused to repeat himself because clearly they were not willing to accept his evidence. He would, however, be prepared to do so if they had a good reason for asking, such as wanting to become Jesus' disciples. But it is clear from the way he phrased his question in **9:27** that he expected their answer to be 'no'.

The man was not only sure of himself but also a threat to the Pharisees' authority. How dared he joke about them becoming disciples of Jesus! They decided to put him firmly in his place. He might be a disciple of *this fellow* (Jesus), but they were Moses' disciples (**9:28**). They implied that the man was not a proper Jew and was separated from God. This point emerges even more clearly in their next words: *We know that God spoke to Moses, but for this fellow, we don't even know where he comes from* (**9:29**). Moses was the great prophet God had appointed to speak for him. Jesus was an unknown.

The man responded to this attack with a carefully reasoned argument. Jesus had opened his eyes (**9:30**). That was a miracle. No one had ever heard of anything like it. One who could do this could not be a 'nobody'. Then he stated the universal Jewish belief: *We know that God does not listen to sinners. He listens to the godly man who does his will* (**9:31–32**). This demolished their argument that Jesus was a sinner. Finally, the man drew the logical conclusion: *If this man were not from God, he could do nothing* (**9:33**). In other words, since the power to do miracles is derived from God, this man, like Moses, must come from God.

The man's logic could not be faulted, and the Pharisees knew it. But logic would not convince them. Instead they reacted with self-righteous anger: *You were steeped in sin at birth; how dare you lecture us*? (**9:34a**). Like the disciples (see 9:1)**,** the Pharisees believed that either this man's own sin or his parents' sin dated from before his birth, since he had been born blind. The Pharisees had no such physical disabilities. The fact that their eyes and their bodies were healthy was proof, they thought, that God approved of them. So was the fact that they took pains to keep the Sabbath and to obey all the other regulations of the law. How dared this sinner try to teach them anything!

They covered up the weakness of their argument with a show of authority, throwing the man out (**9:34b**). In other words, they excommunicated him from the synagogue and in so doing separated him from God, at least in their own minds. But as the Akamba (Kenya) say, *kiumo kya*

nguku kiikwataa mbolosya ['the hen's curse does not affect the hawk']. Their excommunication did not remove this man from God's presence, as the next section shows.

9:35–41 Blindness of the spirit

When Jesus heard what had happened to the man (**9:35a**), he went out of his way to find him. This man not only needed encouragement in the present but also establishment in the faith already at work in his life.

Jesus asked the man, *Do you believe in the Son of Man*? (**9:35b**). He had already confidently asserted that Jesus was from God. He now needed to go beyond believing in the facts to believe in the person, that is, the Son of Man.

The man replied with a question, W*ho is he sir? Tell me so that I may believe in him* (**9:36**). He may have heard of Jesus or heard his voice, but he had been blind when they first met and could not recognize him when he saw him. So Jesus identified himself (**9:37**). The man now had no hesitation in answering Jesus' question, saying, *Lord, I believe* (**9:38a**). p 1299 In 9:36, he had addressed Jesus as 'Lord', using the title as a term of respect, which is why the NIV translates it as 'sir'. Now he again uses the same Greek word, but this time with a sense of worship. Jesus is not just someone to be respected but someone to be worshipped (**9:38b**). The man had been thrown out of the synagogue, the place of worship, but now he is face to face with the object of worship himself.

Some Pharisees were watching what happened (**9:40a**). They may not have been from the group that interrogated the man, but may have been others who were curious about Jesus. Jesus said in their hearing and for their benefit, *For judgment I have come into this world, so that the blind will see and those who see will become blind* (**9:39**). In saying this, Jesus was relating the physical healing to the spiritual realm. The man who had been physically blind had become a believer, for his spiritual eyes had also been opened. On the other hand, the Pharisees could see physically but were spiritually blind. They could not recognize that Jesus the man was also the unique Saviour, Jesus Christ.

The Pharisees were shocked at Jesus' words. Their question, *What? Are we blind too*? (**9:40b**) anticipated the answer 'no'. They were convinced that they were not blind. They knew the Scriptures. They knew God. They belonged to the chosen nation. How could they be described as blind?

Jesus responded, *If you were blind, you would not be guilty of sin; but since now that you claim you can see, your guilt remains* (**9:41**). They were not blind, or rather, they did not recognize their own blindness. If they had recognized it, they would have seen the need to believe in Jesus, the light of the world (8:12). Believing in him would have rendered them *not guilty of sin*. However, their claim to see kept them from coming to Jesus, and so they were still living in sin.

While the guilt of which Jesus speaks here applies to sin in general, in the case of these Pharisees it applied particularly to their sin of wanting to kill Jesus. They were not following Jesus because they loved him but because he was a threat to their own security. Though divided among themselves, the Pharisees in general were looking for some specific charge that they could use to justify killing him.

10:1–21 Jesus, the Good Shepherd, and His Flock

Here Jesus is still talking to the same group of Pharisees as at the end of chapter nine. Using images from everyday life, he talks about his being the gate for the sheep (10:1–9) and the Good Shepherd (10:10–21)

The use of a gate was what differentiated a shepherd from a thief. If someone was greeted by the watchman at the gate as he went into the sheepfold, people would know that he was the shepherd or owner of some sheep within that fold. But someone trying to avoid being seen by climbing in over the fence would be recognized as a thief (**10:1–3a**).

The behaviour of the sheep at the gate would also make it clear whether they were being cared for by a shepherd or stolen by an enemy. If the sheep came out peacefully following a shepherd, they were his flock and familiar with his voice. But if the sheep were frightened and running away from the person trying to lead them, he was a stranger and probably a thief (**10:3b–5**).

Jesus now utters his second 'I am' statement (**10:7**, 9—the first was in 6:35). He describes himself as *the gate for the sheep,* protecting the sheep from the thieves and robbers (self-claimed messiahs) who were before him (**10:8**). By describing himself as the gate, he is promising his hearers three things:

- **Salvation.** Anyone entering into God's presence through him *will be saved* (**10:9a**).
- **Safety.** The shepherd would protect the sheep as they grazed and as they returned to the fold (**10:9b**). In the same way, those who enter God's presence through Jesus will come in and go out with God as their protector wherever they are.
- **Satisfaction.** Jesus had earlier told the Samaritan woman of the satisfaction provided by the water he gives (4:14). He had also spoken of the satisfying bread he provides (6:35). Here he promises that those who enter through him will find pasture (10:9b), that is, food that satisfies their every spiritual need.

He asks his hearers to contrast the life he offers with that offered by the thieves and robbers mentioned in 10:8. Their only motive was theft (**10:10**). Robbers may kill an animal so that they can remove it more easily, and willingly leave young ones without their mother.

In speaking of himself as the gate, Jesus has already spoken of himself as having some of the shepherd's responsibilities, and so it is no surprise when he makes his third 'I am' claim, *I am the good shepherd* (**10:11a; 10:14a**). As the shepherd, he contrasts himself not just with robbers but with hired hands.

A hired hand may have slightly more concern for the sheep than a thief does, but his concern comes nowhere near that of a shepherd. Sheep in Palestine were vulnerable to attack by hyenas, jackals, wolves and bears. Of these, the wolf was the most dangerous. Thus when a hired hand sees a wolf coming, he *abandons the sheep and runs away* to preserve his own skin (**10:12**). The sheep are not his, and no matter how much he knows about them, he will not have the same commitment to them that the shepherd (owner) has. He will not suffer personal loss if some sheep are killed.

By contrast, Jesus is 'the good shepherd'. He is not just one good shepherd among a host of others, he is *the* good shepherd. The Greek word here translated 'good' also suggests that he is both effective and gracious. He cares for the sheep with love, and knows them well. He can say, *I know my sheep and my sheep know me* (**10:14**). As the good shepherd he knows the needs and nature of each sheep in his flock. Each sheep, likewise, can recognize that he is its shepherd. Jesus knows the

hearts of all men and women p 1300 and is able to address the needs of each of them, and his sheep recognize him as the one sent from above.

Jesus speaks of two specific actions he will take for his sheep. The first is that as the good shepherd he *lays down his life for the sheep* (**10:11b**; **10:15**). Though Jesus' death was still in the future when he said these words, it was so certain that he spoke of it in the present tense. Moreover, his entire life, from his incarnation to his death, was in fact a laying down of his life for others.

Jesus' second action is to bring in the *other sheep* so that *there shall be one flock* (**10:16**). His mission went beyond the Jews to include the Gentiles. This part of his mission was continued by his disciples, who began their ministry in Jerusalem (Acts 2), then went to preach in Samaria (Acts 8; see also John 4), then reached Gentiles in Caesarea (Acts 10) before reaching what, in Jewish terms, was the ends of the earth, Rome (Acts 28). They preached the message of Christ crucified and Christ raised from the dead and achieved Jesus' goal of bringing Jews, Samaritans and Gentiles into one flock under one Shepherd.

Jesus stressed that he is not alone in his mission of being the good shepherd. The Father is involved in it from start to finish. In fact the intimate relationship between Jesus and the Father is the pattern for the relationship between the shepherd and his sheep (10:15). This relationship is characterized by love (**10:17**) and obedience (**10:18b**).

Jesus' mission will end in death, but that does not mean that his opponents will have won. He willingly lays down his life and has the *authority to lay it down and authority to take it up again* (**10:18a**). He knew about Judas Iscariot's scheming. The Jews who shouted 'crucify him' to Pilate were not really in control, nor were the Romans. Jesus allowed himself to endure humiliation in obedience to the Father. He laid down his life in the place of his sheep and took it up again to live for ever as the sheep's good shepherd.

Jesus' words again sparked division (**10:19**). Some were contemptuous, saying Jesus was demon possessed (**10:20**), while others were inclined to believe him because of the healings he had done (**10:21**).

10:22–42 Jesus, a Safe Shelter for the Sheep

Solomon's Colonnade was located in the court of the Gentiles and frequented by many people. John tells us that as Jesus was walking there, the Jews gathered around him saying, *How long will you keep us in suspense? If you are the Christ, tell us plainly* (**10:23–24**).

Jesus responded to this impatient request by insisting that he had already answered their question many times, but that they were not prepared to listen to his answer. They had heard him teach but they remained unbelieving (**10:25**). This proved that they were not among his sheep (**10:26**). These sheep are defined as those who *listen to my voice,* so that Jesus can say, *I know them, and they follow me* (**10:27**). 'Listening' here includes both hearing with one's ears and responding in obedience from one's heart.

Those who are his sheep benefit by having him as their safe shelter. They experience absolute security, as Jesus gives them *eternal life.* They all experience this eternal life as soon as they believe. It is something they have now, not something they hope for in the future. Thus even though they may go through hard times, and even die, *they shall never perish*. Thieves, hyenas, wolves, jackals

and bears may attempt to snatch the sheep Jesus is shepherding, but *no one can snatch them out of my hand* (**10:28**). Trials of all kinds may come, but there is victory when the believer is in Jesus' protection.

Jesus can guarantee this security because *My Father, who has given them to me is greater than all* (**10:29**). To snatch the sheep from Jesus, one would also need to snatch them from the Father, which is impossible because he is above all. More than that, the Father has 'given' the sheep to Jesus (see also 6:37, 44) and he and Jesus *are one* (**10:30**). The Father and Jesus are one in purpose and operation.

The Jews recognized that when Jesus talked of his oneness with the Father, he was claiming equality with him (10:33). Consequently they attempted to stone him (**10:31**), just as they had attempted to do when he claimed seniority to Abraham (8:58–59).

Jesus' question, *I showed you many good works from the Father; for which of them are you stoning me?* (**10:32**), does not show that he failed to understand why they were stoning him. He knows what is in people's hearts (see 2:25). Rather, he was trying to get them to evaluate fairly what he had done and to remember that in Jerusalem itself, where they now were, those he had healed included a man who had been sick for thirty-eight years (ch. 5) and a man who had been blind since birth (ch. 9).

The Jews' response, *We are not stoning you for any of these, but for blasphemy, because you, a mere man, claim to be God* (**10:33**), reveals that they still viewed Jesus as the carpenter's son from Nazareth.

Jesus responded with an argument that we find puzzling. When we read it, we need to remember that these words are part of a particular argument, and are not his final statement about who he is. He pointed out that the Jews were not being fair in their judgment and that his works backed his claims. He also pointed out that in Psalm 82:6, God himself referred to judges as 'gods' because they were supposed to be his representatives to administer justice here on earth (even though the psalm shows that some of them were unjust) (**10:34**). Jesus knew the Jews were not angry with God for calling the judges 'gods' but accepted the statement because it was in Scripture (**10:35**). Jesus, however, is greater than the judges, for he is *the one the Father set apart as his very own and sent into the world* (**10:36**). Should he not be entitled to claim that he is *God's Son?* Accusing Jesus (who is greater than the judges) of p 1301 blasphemy for claiming to be 'God's Son' when the judges were called 'gods' was unfair.

Jesus wanted the Jews to understand his intimate relationship with the Father and to accept him and be saved. He realized that his words alone might not be enough to convince them, but should because his words were backed up by his miracles (**10:37–38**). His hearers recognized that Jesus' deeds were beyond what a mere human being could do (see 9:16, 32; 10:21) and their questioning of the man born blind (9:15, 17, 24–25) should have convinced them that he was not a fraud.

The Jews did not listen to Jesus' arguments. Again they attempted to seize him, and again he *eluded their grasp* (**10:39**; see also 7:44; 8:59). He then left Jerusalem and went *beyond the Jordan,* returning to the place *where John was first baptizing* (**10:40**), probably the place where he himself was baptized (see 1:28; Matt 3:5–17; Mark 1:9–11). Jesus may have chosen to end his public ministry at the very place he started it. While there, *many came to him* (**10:41**) and *many believed* (**10:42**). It is quite possible that these were people who had wanted to believe all along, but who had been afraid to do so in Jerusalem because of the unbelieving leaders.

Adeyemo, T. (2006). *Africa Bible commentary*. Nairobi, Kenya; Grand Rapids, MI: WordAlive Publishers; Zondervan.

11:1–44 Jesus Raises Lazarus From the Dead

While Jesus was across the Jordan, a man called Lazarus who lived about eighteen miles (thirty kilometres) away in Bethany near Jerusalem became sick (**11:1**). Lazarus' sisters, Martha and Mary, sent a message to Jesus: *Lord, the one you love is sick* (**11:3**). This message was a polite request for him to come and heal Lazarus. The sisters must have known about the healings Jesus had done in Jerusalem, which was less than three kilometres from Bethany (**11:18**) and in Galilee. They were confident that he would come, for they knew him well and *Jesus loved Martha and her sister and Lazarus* (**11:5**). Later, Jesus refers to Lazarus as *our friend* (11:11). (The famous incident mentioned in 11:2, however, took place later, and is recorded in 12:3.)

Jesus recognized that this sickness would *not end in death* but would bring glory to God and to his Son (**11:4**). But this glory would only be achieved if Lazarus actually died, not if he was simply another sick man whom Jesus healed. So Jesus stayed where he was for two days after receiving the message (**11:6**). Then he told his disciples that he was returning to Judea (**11:7**).

The disciples thought that this would be too risky, for the Jews there had tried to stone Jesus (**11:8**; see also 10:31). Jesus reminded his disciples that his time for his death had not yet come. It was still daylight, and he could walk safely (**11:9–10**). The timetable of his life was not in the hands of his enemies.

Jesus then told the disciples why they had to go to Judea: *Our friend Lazarus has fallen asleep; but I am going there to wake him up* (**11:11**). Jesus here talks of death as sleep because resurrection was on the way. The rest of the NT uses the same image for those who die in Christ. Their death is only a sleep (see 1 Cor 15:6, 18; 1 Thess 4:13, 15; 2 Pet 3:4).

The disciples misunderstood Jesus and thought that Lazarus had fallen into a healing, natural sleep and so they argued against the journey (**11:12–13**). So Jesus told them plainly, *Lazarus is dead,* and explained that what was about to happen would teach them more about who Jesus was (**11:14–15**).

One of the disciples arguing with Jesus here was Thomas. Like the others, he expected the worst, but he urged his fellow disciples to stick with Jesus (**11:16**).

By the time they arrived in Bethany, *Lazarus had already been in the tomb for four days* (**11:17**). There was a common belief that the soul remained near the body for three days after death, hoping for an opportunity to return. But after that it left for good, leaving the person irrevocably dead. Lazarus would have been known by all to be truly dead.

On his arrival, Jesus was met by Martha, whose first words were, *Lord, if you had been here, my brother would not have died* (**11:20–21**). These were exactly the same words spoken by Mary later (11:32). The statement probably echoes words the sisters had said to each other again and again, first as they waited for Jesus to come and then as they mourned their brother's death.

Martha's faith had not been shaken, for she also said, *I know that even now God will give you whatever you ask* (**11:22**). The 'whatever' in her statement does not seem to have included the resurrection of Lazarus. She was likely thinking in terms of everyday life, not of a movement from death to life. So when Jesus assured Martha that her brother would rise again (**11:23**), she replied*, I know he will rise again in the resurrection at the last day* (**11:24**).

Jesus then made his fourth 'I am' saying in John (see also 6:35; 10:7; 10:11): *I am the resurrection and the life. He who believes in me will live, even though he dies; and whoever lives and believes in me will never die* (**11:25–26**). He then asked Martha, *Do you believe this?* (11:26b), and she replied, *Yes, Lord. I believe that you are the Christ, the Son of God who was to come into the world* (**11:27**). Her answer was a good one, but she did not fully recognize what Jesus had just said. He was not asking Martha who he was, but what she believed about his ability to deal with her situation. He was stating that he had authority over life and over death.

Martha then took a message to Mary, *The Teacher is here and is asking for you* (**11:28**). Mary's interaction with Jesus was similar to Martha, except that this time there were more people present. The people who had been comforting Mary had followed her, thinking she was going to the tomb to mourn (**11:29–31**).

Mary was weeping. So were the Jews who followed her. Seeing their grief, Jesus was *deeply moved in spirit and troubled* (**11:33**) and he, too, wept (11:35). He did not weep p 1302 because the situation was hopeless, for he knew that he would raise Lazarus from the dead. He did so because he shares the emotions of those he loves.

The mourners accompanying Mary noted Jesus' love for Lazarus (**11:36**). Like the sisters, they also remembered the healing of the man born blind and wondered why Jesus had not healed Lazarus (**11:37**).

Jesus had met the sisters outside the village (11:20, 30) and now he asked to be taken to the tomb (**11:34–35**). Everyone assumed that this was just a gesture of respect for the dead man. But when he came to the tomb, Jesus instructed them, *Take away the stone* (11:39). This was easy to do, since the tomb was simply a cave with a stone rolled across the entrance (**11:38**). However, there was an obstacle, and Martha expressed it: *But, Lord, by this time there is a bad odour, for he has been there four days* (**11:39**).

Jesus gently reminded Martha, *Did I not tell you that if you believed, you would see the glory of God?* (**11:40**). We have no record of his saying these exact words to Martha before, but they do summarize what Jesus had said in 11:25. Believing that Jesus is the resurrection and the life and acting accordingly will lead to actions that bring glory to God. With this reminder, Martha stands aside and allows the grave to be opened (**11:41a**).

Jesus now turned from talking to the sisters and the Jews to talking to the Father. He started by thanking God for hearing his prayer (**11:41b**). Though Lazarus had not yet been raised, his resurrection was so certain that Jesus treated it as already done. He had confidence that his Father would always hear him, because he never asked for anything outside the will of the Father (**11:42a**). Their will was one. Jesus was certain that God wanted him to raise Lazarus. He then stated the purpose for this public prayer: *for the benefit of the people standing here, that they may believe that you sent me* (**11:42b**). Jesus could have raised Lazarus without more ado, but he wanted those watching to realize that he did not operate independently. The Jews were divided over Jesus' origin and his relationship with the Father (see, for example, 9:16; 10:19–21). So he wanted Lazarus' resurrection to show the whole crowd that he was sent from the Father. They had heard Jesus' words; now they needed to be drawn into his sheepfold by believing in him.

After his prayer, Jesus shouted, *Lazarus, come out!* (**11:43**). The shout was not for Lazarus' benefit. He was dead and could hear nothing. Jesus could have raised him with a whisper. But Jesus wanted the living ones standing there to hear the resurrection words and the call to move from the

sphere of death into the sphere of life. John, who was there, remembers that *the dead man came out* and Jesus told them to *take off the grave clothes and let him go* (**11:44**). Lazarus was alive and free from the sickness that had killed him. We meet him again in 12:2. Truly, Jesus is the resurrection and the life.

11:45–57 Jesus under Threat of Death

Though many of the Jews who witnessed Lazarus' resurrection put their faith in Jesus (**11:45**), others went to the Pharisees and told them what Jesus had done (**11:46**). This led to the Pharisees calling an urgent meeting of the Sanhedrin at which the main topic of discussion was *What are we accomplishing?* (**11:47**). The NIV translation presents the Pharisees as blaming themselves for allowing Jesus to continue to move about freely. However, the phrase can also be translated as meaning, 'What shall we do because this man is continually doing miraculous signs?' In other words, 'How can we stop him?' This translation emphasizes their perplexity. They knew that they should do something, but they did not know what.

They had already tried to capture Jesus. During the Feast of Tabernacles they had unsuccessfully sent guards to arrest him (7:32). They had tried to trick him with the woman caught in adultery, but he had been too clever for them (7:53–8:11). Their representatives had tried to stone Jesus, but he had slipped away from them (8:59). The same thing had happened when the Jews tried to seize Jesus (10:39).

Jesus' growing popularity with the common people also made it difficult for the Sanhedrin to arrest him (see 7:44; Matt 21:46; Luke 20:19). The more Jesus' popularity grew, the more that of the Jewish leaders declined. Jesus had the potential to have everyone believing in him (**11:48a**). Soon the Romans might start to think that the Sanhedrin had lost control, and then they *will come and take away both our place and our nation* (**11:48b**). By this they meant their position of leadership and the nation (Judea) that they led. At this time, Tiberius (AD 14–37) was emperor and Pontius Pilate (AD 26–36) was the procurator over Judea. So long as order was maintained, the Sanhedrin was allowed to control Jewish domestic affairs. Its function was to examine matters in the light of Jewish religious law. Anxious to avoid any threat to their position, they felt that they needed more vigorous action.

Caiaphas (AD 19–37) was the high priest and chairman of the Sanhedrin, though his father-in-law, Annas, from whom he had taken over the office, was still very powerful (**11:49**). Caiaphas advised the council: *It is better for you that one man die for the people than that our nation perish* (**11:50**). His advice focused on the interests of the council members. If the nation perished, the council would have no one to exercise authority over. But Jesus was only one man. They could handle whatever crisis his death might bring. For the sake of self-interest, the innocence of Jesus and true justice were thrown out the window. Caiaphas' motion was seconded, voted on and passed: *So from that day on they plotted to take his life* (11:53).

Though Caiaphas was speaking only in terms of his own political self-interest, God used him to express one of the p 1303 central truths about the death of Christ. Jesus would indeed 'die for the people' (11:50), and not only for the Jewish people *but also for the scattered children of God, to bring them together and make them one* (**11:51–53**). Christ died in the place of and for the benefit of sinners. By his death and on the basis of their faith in him, he brought all the scattered and lost sheep into one fold.

Jesus had faced such plots before. Until the right time came, the Sanhedrin's plots would fail. In the past he had strategically slipped away (8:59; 10:39) or stayed away from the region of greatest danger (4:2; 10:40), and he did the same now, *withdrawing to a region near the desert, to a village called Ephraim, where he stayed with his disciples* (**11:54**). If this village is the one mentioned in 2 Chronicles 13:19, it was located in the mountainous country some fourteen miles (twenty-two kilometres) north of Jerusalem. Here it would be more difficult, humanly speaking, for the authorities to seize him and so Jesus remained there with his disciples until his own appointed time (11:54).

The Jewish Passover was approaching (**11:55**) and many people would go from the country to Jerusalem for a week of ceremonial cleansing before the Passover. During this week, many of them were hoping to see Jesus, who had become an important public figure. As they stood around the temple area, they were discussing whether Jesus was likely to attend this feast (**11:56**). On the one hand, they would be happy to see or hear him, and they knew that Jesus loved teaching such crowds. On the other hand, they knew the authorities' attitude to him and that he was a hunted man. Would he be brave enough to come to the feast?

The chief priests and Pharisees were also working on a strategy to arrest Jesus. They knew that he would probably come to Jerusalem for the Passover or would be somewhere in the vicinity. They, therefore, ordered that *if anyone found out where Jesus was, he should report it so that they might arrest him* (**11:57**). This was not merely a request for assistance; it was an order from the supreme court of the day. They hoped that such total mobilization of the people would work. However, it was not their strategy but God's timing that mattered.

12:1–11 Jesus Anointed by Mary

Six days before the Passover, Jesus returned to Bethany where he had raised Lazarus (**12:1**). It was less than two miles (three kilometres) from Jerusalem and so was in the danger zone for Jesus. A dinner was given in Jesus' honour, at which Martha served and Lazarus and others ate with Jesus (**12:2**). It must have been a wonderful time of fellowship. But Mary had a unique contribution to make.

The last time Jesus was at Bethany, Mary had fallen at his feet and cried, *Lord, if you had been here, my brother would not have died* (11:32). Even then she had honoured him as her Lord. Now she expressed her love and gratitude by taking *about a pint* (500 millimetres) *of pure nard* (an expensive perfume), pouring it on Jesus' feet and wiping his feet with her hair (**12:3**). The oil she used was worth almost *a year's wages*, for Judas valued it at three hundred denarii, and one denarius was a day's wage for a labourer (12:5b). Her use of it showed how precious her Lord was to her. The fact that she poured it on Jesus' feet to clean them showed what humble service she was willing to offer. In Jewish practice, it was slaves, never disciples, who washed guests' feet with water. Finally, her use of her hair to wipe Jesus' feet showed that she did not care what others thought of her so long as she was serving her Lord. Many of those present would have been shocked that a respectable woman would let her hair hang loose in public!

Judas Iscariot objected to her actions, *Why wasn't this perfume sold and the money given to the poor?* (**12:4–5**). John tells us that Judas was not particularly concerned for the poor. He was, however, the treasurer for the disciples and used to help himself to the money given to them. In other words, he was a thief (**12:6**). As the Akamba say, *itho yikatonyeka yambiiaa kuia mana tene*

[‘an eye that will go blind starts shedding involuntary tears long before’]. Judas was already showing his true colours.

Jesus told him to leave Mary alone, and then added, *It was intended that she should save this perfume for the day of my burial* (**12:7**). That day had come. He was heading for Jerusalem and death. Mary’s act was, from her perspective, simply a way of telling her Lord how much she appreciated him. From God’s perspective, however, her act marked the start of Jesus’ passion. This was why Jesus said, *You always have the poor among you, but you will not always have me* (**12:8**). If Mary had not done the service then, she would never have had another opportunity. Jesus was on his way to the cross.

Jesus’ presence at Bethany became widely known and many Jews came there (**12:9–10**). They wanted to see and hear Jesus and to see Lazarus whom he had raised from the dead. Someone who could do such a thing must be very important and powerful. Lazarus, too, had become a celebrity because of his resurrection.

The Sanhedrin had already resolved to kill Jesus (11:53), but now the chief priests planned to kill Lazarus as well (12:10). It is interesting to note that only the chief priests are mentioned here. They were from the Sadduccees’ party, which did not believe in the resurrection, and the fact that Lazarus was alive contradicted their beliefs. But their primary motive for getting rid of Jesus was that *many of the Jews were going over to Jesus and putting their faith in him* (**12:11**). Lazarus was attracting others to Jesus.

12:12–19 Jesus’ Triumphal Entry to Jerusalem

It was now five days before the Passover. Jesus had arrived at Bethany six days before the Passover and this event took place in Jerusalem the next day (**12:12**). It would not have p 1304 taken long for news of his presence to cover the two miles (three kilometres) to Jerusalem.

As Jesus travelled toward Jerusalem, he was acknowledged by a crowd who greeted him with both deeds and words. The fact that they carried *palm branches* (**12:13a**) as they celebrated his arrival was significant, for there were only two contexts within which the Jews carried palm branches: at the Feast of Tabernacles (Lev 23:40) and at the celebration of the rededication of the temple in 164 BC after its pollution by Antiochus Epiphanes (1 Macc 13:50–51). Ever since that time, the palm seems to have been a symbol of Judea—equivalent to a national flag. Palm branches played no role in the Passover, so it seems likely that the people were thinking of the events in 164 BC, when the Maccabees’ victory over the Syrians had been celebrated by waving branches of palm trees. Jesus was being welcomed as another liberator, one who would free them from the Romans. His raising of Lazarus had convinced them that he was powerful enough to lead them to victory against Rome. Thus they greeted him with palms and with shouts of *Hosanna,* which means ‘save us, we beseech you’ or ‘give us salvation now’ or ‘give us victory now’ (**12:13b**).

The crowd also shouted, *Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord!* (**12:13c**). They were acknowledging what Jesus had been claiming all along, namely, that he was sent from the Father. They certainly did not understand that he had been sent as a man to die in the place of humankind, but at least they recognized that the authority with which he taught and acted came from God.

Their final cry, *Blessed is the King of Israel* (**12:13d**), underscores their view that Jesus' mission was to rule Israel and that his immediate task was to win victory over the Romans. They were ready to follow him into battle.

The Jesus we have met in John so far does not take orders from other people (not from his mother—John 2:4, his brothers—John 7:6–8, or his friends—John 11:6–15). The Galileans had wanted to make him king (6:15) but he had slipped away from them. Now the people in Jerusalem (including Galileans who had come for the Feast) were again trying to declare him king, but he was not under their orders.

Had Jesus wanted to lead a *coup d'état*, he would have come riding into Jerusalem on a horse, a symbol of war. Instead, he entered Jerusalem riding a young donkey (**12:14**). He had come to die under the Romans, not to conquer them. His mission was mysterious: he showed himself to be a man of great power, but at the same time he submitted to insults, mistreatment and even death at the hands of unbelieving Jews and the representatives of Rome.

Jesus' entrance on a donkey was no accident but a fulfilment of Scripture (**12:15**; see Zech 9:9). After his glorification, the disciples realized that when they helped Jesus get the donkey (see Mark 11:2–7) they were participants in fulfilling Scripture written about 550 years before (**12:16**).

Meanwhile, those who had seen Jesus raise Lazarus continued to talk about it, and those who heard them longed to see Jesus. Hearing that he was coming to Jerusalem, they *went out to meet him* (**12:17–18**). As the news spread, more and more came to meet Jesus and his popularity grew. Clearly, the people were ignoring the order that anyone who found where Jesus was should tell the chief priests and Pharisees so they could arrest him (11:57). Instead, the people were hailing Jesus as their Messiah. No wonder the Pharisees said to one another, *See, this is getting us nowhere.* Their latest plan had failed, and the people were all for Jesus (**12:19**).

It was probably at this point that the Pharisees came up with the idea of using one of Jesus' disciples to help them arrest Jesus, for as the Akamba (Kenya) say, *muthianwa ni mutui ndavitaa* ['one spied on by a neighbour cannot get away']. The Pharisees could not arrest him on their own, for Jesus always slipped away. Relying on the people was not working either, because the people were for Jesus. Their best option might be to bribe one of the twelve men closest to him.

12:20–26 Some Greeks Seek Jesus

The Greeks referred to here were Gentile proselytes, who had come to Jerusalem *to worship at the Feast* (**12:20**). They had seen the welcome Jesus had received, and were interested in seeing this popular figure who was rumoured to have even raised the dead. Meanwhile, Jesus was with a crowd of Jews who had witnessed or heard of Lazarus' resurrection (12:17).

The Greeks approached Philip, who was from Bethsaida in Galilee (12:21). They may have chosen to speak to him because of his Greek name, Philip, which means 'lover of horses'. They said that they *would like to see Jesus* (**12:21**), meaning 'catch sight of him', without necessarily implying anything more than that.

Philip was uncertain about what to do about their request, and so he consulted Andrew, a fellow disciple. In their experience, Jesus had ministered only to Jews or their near relatives, the Samaritans. What would he think of the Greeks? Was their request sufficiently important to justify interrupting his teaching to the Jewish crowd? These were probably the sorts of issues that Philip

was unsure about. Andrew seems to have advised Philip that it was best to let Jesus himself decide, and so *Andrew and Philip in turn told Jesus* (**12:22**).

While we are not told exactly how Jesus responded to the Greeks' request, we can assume that the words that follow were prompted by it. Their request gave Jesus an opportunity to teach his disciples, the Jews who were with him (12:17, 34) and probably the listening Greeks as well.

Jesus tells the crowd that his *hour has come* at last (**12:23**). At the beginning of his ministry, Jesus had told his mother, *my hour has not yet come* (2:4), referring to the time p 1305 to publicly display his power. That hour came a little later, and for about three years Jesus did many miraculous signs. During those years all attempts to hurt or kill him were unsuccessful because his public ministry was not yet complete (see, for example, 8:20; 10:31, 39; 11:53, 57). Now, the hour for his passion has come. The remaining journey is to the cross.

The hour that has come will involve the glorification of the Son of Man (12:23). The Jews thought that this glorification would involve great earthly victories, particularly over the Romans. But Jesus knew that his glorification would come through death. To explain what he meant, he used the illustration of a grain of wheat. No matter how healthy that grain is, its glory lies in its death, for only as it dies will it produces a new plant with many seeds (**12:24**). If Christ does not die, there will be no Christ-like people. Salvation will only be possible by way of his death.

He goes on to contrast two people. One of them loves his or her life, and the other hates it, at least as far as this world is concerned (**12:25**). The one who chooses to cling to life inevitably loses it, but the one who hates his or her life gains eternal life. This is the opposite of what we would expect. We would assume that someone who loves life would protect it by having a good security system, eating a balanced diet, exercising regularly and taking other measures in order to stay healthy and secure. On the other hand, we would assume that someone who hates life will be careless about their personal security, what they eat and other dangers. Why do Jesus' words go contrary to common sense? It is because he is the life. Those who love their lives and so refuse to die with him will not see life proper. On the other hand, those who hate their lives and choose to die with Christ (that is, to die to self so that Christ can reign in them) gain eternal life. Even when they sleep in death, they await a resurrection, for their eternal life cannot be interrupted by death.

The ultimate reward for service is for those who follow Jesus and serve him. They will enjoy Jesus' presence and receive honour from the Father (**12:26**). Jesus makes it clear that the possibility of receiving the reward is open to anyone, including the very Greeks whose request to see Jesus prompted these words. Jews, Samaritans and Greeks are all welcome.

The only condition for receiving the reward is that one must be Jesus' servant, and such servanthood involves following Jesus. Merely seeing Jesus, as the Greeks requested, is not enough. One needs to deny oneself and earthly preoccupations (which is equivalent to hating life—12:25) and follow Jesus. This 'following' is expressed in the present tense to indicate that it must be a habit. The following cannot be limited to special occasions such as the Feast of the Passover, but must take place all the time.

The two rewards (being with and being honoured by the Father) are expressed in the future tense. This is not because they will only happen in the next world, but because they will only happen after one has obeyed the call to follow and serve Jesus.

Jesus will appear, from a human perspective, to have been rejected, for death on the cross was for someone who had been cursed. Similarly, the one who is Jesus' servant will not receive honour from the world. However, just as the Father will honour the Son by raising him from the dead and giving him a name above all names (Phil 2:9), so also Jesus' servant will enjoy the praise of God. Mockery and even death will be opportunities for the Father to glorify Jesus' servants.

12:27–36 The Son of Man Must Be Lifted Up

Jesus was fully human, and as such he was afraid of the suffering and death that lay ahead in the 'hour' he had now entered. He did not hide this fact, but said, *Now, my heart is troubled* (**12:27a**) and pondered whether he should pray for salvation from the hour. While such salvation was what he wanted emotionally, he knew that he would be wrong to request it, for *it was for this very reason I came to this hour* (**12:27b**). Jesus' life had been lived in accordance with a divine timetable. There had been the hour when he became human, the hour when he began his public ministry, and now he faced the hour of his passion.

Surrendering himself to the divine timetable, Jesus prayed, *Father, glorify your name* (**11:27c**). What mattered most was not how he felt physically but what would glorify the Father's name. Was it death? If so, let it come.

The Father responded by speaking from heaven, *I have glorified it, and will glorify it again* (**12:28**). The glorifying that had already been done was everything the Son had submissively done since he took upon himself the role of becoming human in order to save men and women. In a sense, the Father is praising the Son for a job well done. The Father will also answer the Son's current prayer in which he has committed himself into the Father's hands. He will direct events in such a way that his name will be glorified yet again.

Jesus had been surrounded by a crowd ever since he left Bethany (12:17). They had given him a triumphal entry into the city as a nationalistic Messiah and they anticipated extraordinary happenings—although all along they failed to grasp Jesus' relationship with God. When the voice came from heaven, some mistook it for thunder and others said that an angel had spoken (**12:29**). Thunder might have been taken as extraordinary if there were no indications of stormy weather. And an angel speaking would be a mark that Jesus was the Messiah they expected. Whatever the case, the crowd probably took the sound as a sign of God's approval of Jesus leading them against the Romans.

Jesus, however, tells them *This voice was for your benefit, not mine* (**12:30**). As far as he is concerned this is not possibility of a retreat. The awful death on the cross has to p 1306 be faced, for this is the eternal plan The crowd, however, has not yet grasped that Jesus is the eternal Son of God, who is sent from above. The Father's words to Jesus should have helped them realize this, but instead they attribute it to thunder or an angel.

Jesus now speaks more about what the hour means and *the kind of death he was going to die* (**12:33**). The approaching hour (that is, the hour of his death) means judgment on this world, that is, on the system that is opposed to Jesus, and ultimately to the Father who sent him. The judgment means that *the prince of this world will be driven out* (**12:31**). While Satan's complete removal will only take place in the future (Rev 20:10), his expulsion was begun on the cross where a limit was set to the time of his involvement in history. There Jesus opened the door of escape from the sphere in

which Satan rules. What appear to be Satan's victories now (and many examples can be cited on the African continent and elsewhere) are only his struggles to survive. His final destiny is fixed.

The hour will end with Jesus being lifted up from the earth—first on a cross, and then in his resurrection—and then drawing all men to himself as a consequence of his resurrection (**12:32**).

The crowd welcomed Jesus as the Christ (that is, the Messiah). But now he is confusing them by talking about someone called 'the Son of Man', who it seems will die (12:23–24). He also interchanges the title 'son of Man' and the pronoun 'I'. The crowd has been taught that the Christ will live forever, so if Jesus is the Christ, as they believe, he will not die. Confused, they ask, *Who is the Son of Man*? (**12:34**).

Jesus does not answer their question. Instead he tells them to act by walking while they still have light and by putting their trust in the light while they have it. He warns them that the light will soon be gone (**12:35–36**). In only a few days, he will be arrested. It is time for them to respond to his teaching that brings light into their lives.

Jesus then left the crowd and *hid himself from them* (12:36). He did not do this because this crowd wanted to stone him, as earlier crowds had (see 8:59, 10:31) but rather because, like the Galileans in 6:15, they wanted Jesus to become their king and lead them against the Romans. This had been their hope when they flocked to see him at Bethany (12:9) and gave him a triumphal entry into Jerusalem. This crowd had not understood his talk of his death and its implication. So it was time for him to move on and complete his journey to the cross.

12:37–50 Jesus Finishes His Public Ministry

12:37–43 A summary of Jesus' public ministry

Jesus is about to end his public ministry and focus on his final instructions to his twelve disciples. Before he does so, John presents a brief report on the state of Jesus' mission.

The Jews had seen or heard of the many signs that Jesus had done in Judea and Galilee. John has not recorded all of these signs (see 20:30; also 2:23), but he has given details of seven of them: the changing of water into wine, the healing of a royal official's son, the healing of a man who had been sick for thirty-eight years, the feeding of more than five thousand people, the walking on water, the healing of the man who was born blind and the raising of Lazarus. Yet despite all these signs, the Jews as a group in general *still would not believe in him* (**12:37**)**.** Their leaders and those who followed them rejected Jesus in spite of what they had heard and seen. Even those who admired Jesus and wanted him to be their nationalistic Messiah were not prepared to believe his message of a dying Son of Man.

This unbelief was not due to a lack of evidence but was a fulfilment of Isaiah's prophecy (**12:38**). John quotes from Isaiah 53:1, *Lord, who has believed our message and to whom has the arm of the Lord been revealed?* The answer to this rhetorical question is clearly meant to be 'no one', or at least very few. The Servant of Isaiah 53 suffered at the hands of men who should have known better, but who chose not to believe and rejected the Servant. Why did they do this? John gives the answer in words from Isaiah 6:10: *He has blinded their eyes and deadened their hearts, so that they can neither see with their eyes, nor understand with their hearts, nor turn—and I would heal them* (**12:39–40**). But what do these words mean?

Isaiah 6 contains the Lord's commission to Isaiah to 'go and tell this people' (Isa 6:9). The message he was to deliver was 'Be ever hearing, but never understanding; be ever seeing, but never perceiving.' The people to whom he was to speak were God's people, specifically those in the southern kingdom of Judah. They had become untrue to the Lord, and as a result were condemned (see Isa 1:4). God no longer referred to them as 'my people (as he had in Exod 3:7; Lev 26:12; Jer 11:4; 30:2). Instead he called them 'this people (Isa 6:9; see also Isa 9:16; 29:13). The Lord distanced himself from them because of their stubbornness.

The Lord told Isaiah what the result of his ministry would be: 'Make the heart of this people calloused, make their ears dull, and close their eyes.' Why? Lest they 'see with their eyes, hear with their ears, understand with their hearts and turn and be healed' (Isa 6:10). Isaiah's ministry would bring about a further hardening of people's hearts and greater insensitivity to the word of the Lord. John relates this pattern of ministry to what was happening in Jesus' time: *Isaiah said this because he saw Jesus' glory and spoke about him* (**12:41**).

Like the people of Judah to whom Isaiah ministered, the Jews of Jesus' time were the chosen people of God; they too had heard the Lord's message but had hardened their hearts—deliberately choosing not to believe. Just as Isaiah's ministry was to continue until the Lord brought the deserved judgment for the people's hardness of heart, so p 1307 it was for Jesus. The Jews had persistently rejected Jesus' claims, ignored the evidence of his miraculous signs and even plotted to kill him. They faced judgment, and were at the stage where the divine ministry they were receiving blinded their eyes and deadened their hearts.

Yet even in the midst of the general unbelief, *many even among the leaders believed in him* (**12:42a**). But they *would not confess their faith for fear they would be put out of the synagogue* by the Pharisees (**12:42b**). To them, such excommunication implied being cut off from fellowship with God and with their fellow Jews. But they were wrong to think so. Believing in Jesus would mean believing in and receiving praise from the one who sent Jesus (that is, God). They were wrong to have preferred to remain in the Pharisees' good books rather than in God's (**12:43**).

12:44–50 Jesus' final plea to the Jews

Jesus' desire that no one should perish (2 Pet 3:9) seems to have led him to return briefly to make a final appeal to the crowd following his departure in 12:36. There he once again stressed that he and the one who sent him are one. Believing in Jesus is also believing in God who sent him (**12:44–45**). Seeing Jesus is the same as seeing the Father. It follows that rejection of Jesus is also rejection of God.

The reason Jesus had come was to be the light of the world (**12:46**; see also 8:12). Those who do not know him as Saviour live in darkness (3:20), separate from God who is himself light (Ps 27:1; 1 John 1:5). Jesus' mission was to provide everyone with a way out of darkness and into light. His prime concern was to save, not to judge (**12:47**). He will be our judge in the future, but the goal of his earthly ministry was to bring salvation, not judgment.

But Jesus' teaching about the salvation he offers in submission to the Father will inevitably be evidence against those who reject it (**12:48**). His words will judge the hearers on the *last day* when God will end human governments and will issue rewards and punishment. At that time no one will be left to do as he or she chooses (as the Jews had chosen to reject Jesus).

Jesus finished his public ministry with a reminder that he faithfully reports what the Father commanded him to say (**12:49–50**). Both his words and his actions were directed by the Father. What Jesus has said is the Father's message, without distortion. Rejection of Jesus' message is rejection of the Father's message. The goal of all his words and deeds has been to offer eternal life. A rejection of his message is thus a rejection of eternal life.

13:1–17:26 Jesus' Final Ministry to the Twelve

Chapters 13 to 16 present Jesus' final words to his twelve disciples before his crucifixion, and chapter 17 contains his prayer to the Father in their hearing. His disciples have been with him since he turned water into wine in Cana (ch. 2). They have seen his miracles and have listened to his teaching, and thus have a very good background for understanding what Jesus will now be saying to them. 'However, they still need to learn more'. But time would be short; Jesus' final ministry to the Twelve, his time of prayer and his subsequent trial, crucifixion, and burial took place within less than twenty-four hours. The events began on Thursday evening and ended during Friday afternoon.

13:1–20 Jesus Washes The Disciples' Feet

John does not tell us where Jesus washed his disciples' feet, but it is likely that it was in the upper room talked about in Mark 14:14–15 and Luke 22:10–12. He does tell us that it takes place *just before the Passover Feast* (**13:1a**). During this Passover, it was not only the Passover lamb that would die but also the eternal Lamb of God. Jesus knew that this was the hour of his death (**13:1b**). Around him were twelve men whom he had loved with special love, one of whom was going to betray him (**13:2**).

In light of his impending death, Jesus wanted to demonstrate *the full extent of his love* for these men (**13:1c**). He did this in a most dramatic way while the evening meal (his last supper) was being served. While fully aware of the greatness of his origins, his power and his destiny (**13:3**) Jesus humbly took on the role of a servant. He got up from the meal (**13:4a**) and took off his outer clothing (**13:4b**). Jewish men usually wore an inner tunic, an outer tunic or robe, and an outer garment or cloak. They normally removed the cloak when indoors, but kept the outer tunic on. What Jesus did was remove his outer tunic and strip down to his inner tunic. Then he wrapped a towel around his waist (**13:4c**). Dressed in this way, Jesus looked exactly like a slave, for this was standard dress for a slave.

Jesus then poured water into a basin (**13:5a**) and began to wash his disciples' feet and dry them with the towel that was wrapped around him (**13:5b**). Not only was he dressed like a slave, but he was doing the work of a slave. Washing feet was such a menial job that no teacher would expect his disciples to do it.

John focuses on what happened when Jesus came to Peter. Characteristically, Simon Peter went from one extreme (*you shall never wash my feet*—**13:8**) to the other (*not just my feet but my hands and my head as well*—**13:9**). At first he was telling Jesus, 'You are my master; I will never allow you to serve me as if you were my slave'. Then his meaning changed to, 'I want to be fully associated with you in every possible way.' Peter meant well, but the lesson Jesus was teaching here only required that he wash everyone's feet.

After Jesus had finished washing the disciples' feet*, he put on his clothes* and asked the disciples, '*Do you understand what I have done for you?* (**13:12**). They were right to call Jesus their Lord and Teacher (**13:13**). But as such, he p 1308 should have received service from them. Instead, however, he had served them, doing the most humble of tasks.

He then gave a command that we all need to listen to again and again: *You also should wash one another's feet* (**13:14**). Such an act involves acknowledging that one is a slave or servant of the one whose feet are being washed. But no one person is to take the servant's role. They are to wash 'one another', indicating that everyone washes everyone else's feet. Jesus stresses that this is an obligation the disciples owe to each other, and his use of the present tense implies that it is an ongoing obligation, something to be done continually, not just once. And to forestall objections, he points out that he himself has already done this: *I have set you an example that you should do as I have done for you* (**13:15**). No one could logically argue that they would lose status if they washed others' feet if Jesus, their Master and Lord, had done the same (**13:16**). As servants, they were expected to imitate their Master. As disciples of Jesus, each of them would be both master and servant at the same time. Each would receive service and render it.

The concept of service to all, especially to those who are socially beneath one, is foreign to Africa. A chief serving his subjects would be unheard of. Yet that is what Jesus is asking us to do here. If our leaders in Africa would learn this lesson, it would take away more than half of the pain the African continent experiences from day to day.

The command to serve does not come without rewards: *You are blessed if you do these things* (**13:17**). God is the source of blessings. As we receive his blessings, we are happy because we are at peace with God and with ourselves, and this happiness affects our relationships with others.

But not all of those present with Jesus would enjoy this blessing, for one of them would refuse to serve or to acknowledge Jesus as Master and Lord. Jesus was referring to Judas Iscariot, without mentioning his name, when he said, *I am not referring to all of you; I know those I have chosen* (**13:18a**). Judas Iscariot was one of those Jesus had chosen (see Matt 10:1–4; Luke 6:12–16). Jesus knew the heart and motives of each of the twelve men he chose, and he knew that Judas would fulfil the Scripture *He who shares my bread has lifted up his heel against me* (**13:18b**), an expression that describes brutal violence. Jesus was quoting Psalm 41:9, where David spoke of a time when even his intimate friend abandoned him but the Lord delivered him.

Eating with someone, sharing their bread, was a sign of friendship. Judas Iscariot had travelled and eaten with Jesus for three years. He had heard his ministry and shared fellowship with friends such as Mary, Martha and Lazarus. But his heart had not been in it (see, for example, 12:5–6).

Judas was chosen in order to fulfil the Scripture that Jesus would be treated brutally by a group that included his own disciple. We may wonder where God's will ends and Judas' evil begins. In dealing with this issue, the first thing we need to remember is that John's primary point is that Jesus' death was not an accident. This point is stressed in **13:19**. God's divine plan not only included Jesus' leaving heaven and dying as the God-man here on earth, but also the hour and manner in which he would die. Judas Iscariot was in God's programme. Yet it was not God who directed his actions, but Satan (13:2; see also Luke 22:3).

Judas is held accountable for betraying Jesus (see Matt 26:24; Mark 14:21; Luke 22:22). It seems that it is in the context of God's directive will that Judas was chosen to be a disciple and remained one for three years. However he betrayed Jesus within the context of God's permissive will, which

allows evil but does not dictate it. Judas could have acted differently. He could have chosen to remain loyal to Jesus rather than obeying the prompting of the devil.

God knows what is going to happen, from beginning to end. Judas was chosen as one of the team of twelve to do exactly what he did—but not because God made him do it. He acted by his own choice, but God had known what that choice would be from all eternity.

Jesus had washed the disciples' feet, and they in turn will wash 'one another's' feet (13:14) and also the feet of those who will listen to their proclamation of the gospel and accept Jesus. Jesus will send the disciples to the nations. Whoever accepts them and allows them to wash his or her feet will be accepting Jesus who sends them (see 13:8). And whoever accepts Jesus accepts God who sent Jesus (**13:20**). A chain of service is thus set up, from God to Jesus to Jesus' disciples to those who will listen to their message and in turn proclaim it to others. No wonder Jesus told his disciples that they would enjoy God's blessing when they served one another (**13:17**).

13:21–29 Jesus Predicts That Judas Will Betray Him

After he had said this (**13:21**), meaning his warning that one of his disciples was not clean and had not accepted him as his Lord*, Jesus was troubled in spirit*. When he explained the cause of his unhappiness to the disciples, they were shocked (see **13:22**). How could he be betrayed by one who had known his kindness and love for three years?

Trying to resolve the tension between this unimaginable thing and the certainty with which Jesus said it, Peter asked the beloved disciple (believed to be John) to ask Jesus who he was talking about (**13:23–24**). Jesus' replied, *the one to whom I will give this piece of bread when I have dipped it in the dish* (**13:26a**). Even with this clear statement and Jesus' giving Judas the dipped bread (**13:26b**), no one at the table except Jesus and Judas understood all that was happening (**13:28**). When Jesus told Judas *what you are about to do, do quickly,* Judas knew exactly what he meant.

When John says that *as soon as Judas took the bread, Satan entered into him* (**13:27**), he is describing the course of events, not implying that taking the bread caused Satan to enter him. He is simply saying that not much time elapsed p 1309 between his taking the bread and his coming under the control of Satan.

13:30–38 Jesus Predicts That Peter Will Deny Him

When Judas left (**13:30**) Jesus knew where he was going and what he was going to do. So he spoke of his imminent suffering and death as the glorification of the Son of Man, and through this, the glorification of God (**13:31–32**). Jesus then talked of his departure (**13:33**), the need for the disciples to fill the gap by loving one another in a new way—a way of service, and the witness that such love is to the world (**13:34–35**).

The talk of departure captured Peter's attention and so he asked, *Lord, where are you going*? (**13:36**). Jesus' reply again mentioned the impossibility of the disciples going there now (see also 13:33), but added the important information that *you will follow later*. Peter was not satisfied with waiting till later, and so he committed himself, *I will lay down my life for you* (**13:37**), only to have Jesus tell him *before the rooster crows, you will disown me three times!* (**13:38**). The emphasis here is not on Peter's weakness. In fact, the Lord does not discourage him from laying down his life for him. The focus is on the hardships of the route.

14:1–4 Jesus, the Source of Comfort

Jesus now reassured the disciples that they need not be troubled (**14:1**)—as they clearly already were. Satan would be happy to add to this troubling of the disciples' hearts once Jesus was out of the picture. He would bring doubts that could only be overcome by obedience: *trust in God, trust also in me* (14:1b). Their faith was to be based on what God was ready to do for them and on what Jesus had and was going to promise. Jesus' promise here is most comforting to troubled hearts: *In my Father's house are many rooms; if it were not so, I would have told you. I am going there to prepare a place for you* (**14:2**). Given the reliability of the owner of the house (the Father) and of the one preparing the rooms (Jesus), the disciples could be confident that there would be a place for each of them.

However, it is possible to have a room waiting for one but to fail to reach it because of the dangers on the way. Jesus assures his disciples that they do not need to worry about this, as he will come again and will himself escort them to their destination (**14:3**). To crown it all, Jesus and his disciples will again be together. Their present parting is only a temporary separation.

As Jesus reflects on Peter's question 'Where are you going? (13:36), he tells the disciples, *You know the way to the place where I am going* (**14:4**). Though they have not been there and they will not go there now (see 13:36), the way to the place is familiar.

14:5–14 Jesus the Way, Truth and Life

Thomas, however, was not convinced by Jesus' statement in 14:4 and protested, *Lord, we don't know where you are going, so how can we know the way?* (**14:5**). In reply, Jesus spoke of the destination of the journey and specified how to get there: *No one comes to the Father except through me* (**14:6b**). Here he makes specific what had only been implied in 13:36 and 14:2: the journey is to the Father. That is where Jesus is going, and that is where the disciples will follow later.

Jesus then tells them the way to reach the Father: *I am the way and the truth and the life* (**14:6a**). They will reach the Father by believing in Jesus. This is Jesus' sixth major *I am* saying (the earlier ones are in 6:35 and 6:51; 8:12 and 9:5; 10:7 and 9; 10:11 and 14; and 11:25). Jesus' words here make it very clear that all roads do not lead to Rome, no matter how often we are assured that this is the case. Not all roads lead to possession of eternal life. Jesus is the God-appointed way.

This statement raises the question of the destiny of our African ancestors who died before Christ was presented to them. When pondering this question, we need to remember that there is room in God's judgment plan for judging cases on the basis of people's response to general revelation (Rom 2:12–16). But it is also clear that no cases will be considered outside of Christ. He is God's Anointed and each individual's response to him, whether in the context of the general revelation in creation or the special revelation in Scripture, will be central to the judgment. Those who have tried to please God, despite not having heard of Christ, will be accepted, for Jesus has been sent by God, and the one who pleases the Father has already passed the test of obeying the message of the Son.

Yet for most of us, the question of how God will judge those who have never heard the gospel does not arise. The issue for us is, What will we do with the Christ we have heard about? Will we choose life or death? Our decision about Jesus Christ will determine our fate.

Jesus finishes answering Thomas by pointing out that knowledge of Jesus amounts to knowledge of the Father (**14:7**). Philip, reflecting on what Jesus had just told them, asks, *Lord, show us the Father and that will be enough for us* (**14:8**). The word translated 'show' also means 'point out'. Philip wants Jesus to be specific. If he is, the disciples will stop asking questions and will not be troubled anymore.

In answering Philip's question, Jesus makes a key statement: *anyone who has seen me has seen the Father* (14:9). Philip has been with Jesus for three years now, and so Jesus asks him, *Don't you know me, Philip, even after I have been among you for such a long time? How can you say, 'Show us the Father?'* (**14:9**). Since Jesus has been with the disciples for such a long time, they should have no need to ask to be shown the Father. If they believe that Jesus is in the Father and the Father is in Jesus (**14:10**), then their need to see p 1310 the Father has already been met. Having seen Jesus, they have seen the Father. Jesus' questions are not meant to make Philip feel bad, but to open his eyes to the implications of what he believes.

Jesus goes on to remind Philip and the other disciples of the two witnesses to his relationship with the Father, namely, his words and deeds (**14:11–12**). While it may seem more appropriate to believe in Jesus' words, because this shows faith in Jesus as a person, it is clear that miracles also have their place, especially in initially establishing that faith.

A consequence of Jesus and the Father being one is that whatever is asked of the Father is also asked of Jesus. The Father ultimately owns all things. Jesus, as Son, submits to him, but at the same time, he and the Father act as one. Anything asked from or given by the Father is also asked from or given by Jesus. Jesus thus becomes both the one to be asked for blessing (*ask me*) and the go-between who makes it easier to have requests granted (*in my name*) (**14:13b–14a**).

After Jesus has gone to the Father, those who have faith in him will be able to ask for anything from Jesus and in his name. Not only will believers receive whatever they ask for, they will also be able to do the same or even greater things than Jesus does, so that the Father will be glorified by what believers do. But we should note that our privilege of asking for anything is limited by the twice-repeated qualification, 'in my name' (14:13b, 14a). Asking for something in another person's name assumes that there is a close relationship between the one asking and the one in whose name it is asked. It also assumes that the thing asked for will be used to further the interests of the one whose name is used to get it. Jesus' words *I will do it* (**14:13a**, **14b**) are a promise that believers will receive whatever they ask in this way.

Just as Jesus' deeds showed the Father at work (14:10), so the deeds of believers will show Jesus at work. The believers are, however, directly involved in that they must ask. Jesus does not act in a vacuum. He works through believers, those people who are concerned to please him.

Believers will not only be able to do the same things Jesus has been doing but *even greater things than these* (**14:12**). For example, Peter's message on the day of Pentecost (Acts 2:41) led more people to faith than Jesus' preaching did. Jesus had twelve students, but today many Bible teachers teach far bigger classes. The resurrected Jesus will show himself with even greater power than the incarnate Jesus, and he will do this through believers who submit to him.

The purpose for which prayers are answered and power is displayed is the glory of the Father (14:13b). This goal, too, serves to limit what a believer can ask for with confidence that Jesus will grant the prayer. Jesus is telling Philip that the Father will be shown by the works Philip and the

other disciples will do as they continue to grow in faith. The disciples will not just be people who have seen the Father but will be benefactors, showing the Father to others.

14:15–31 Jesus Promises the Holy Spirit

Jesus has been speaking of asking for things, and now he speaks of something that he himself will ask the Father to give to believers, namely, the Holy Spirit (**14:16–17**). Here two titles are used for the Spirit. He is the Spirit of truth, and he is the *parakletos,* a Greek word that means counsellor, advocate or comforter. Jesus has been all these things to the disciples but he is going away. While he will return to them briefly after his resurrection (**14:18**; Acts 1:3) they will need *another Counsellor* to fill their need for divine presence for ever.

The ministry of the Holy Spirit will be to *teach you all things and … remind you of everything I have said to you (***14:26**). The words, 'all things' and 'everything' both translate the same Greek word, which is used twice. What they will be taught is all-inclusive, excluding nothing, while what they will be reminded of is limited to what Jesus has said in their hearing.

Some people have used this verse as the basis for claiming that the Holy Spirit has taught them all kinds of things. Thus we have to consider whether there are any limitations on what is likely to be taught. The first point to remember is that the Holy Spirit will be sent in Jesus' name (14:26), which means that his will and that of Jesus are one. Thus he will never contradict what Jesus has said. Instead he will continue where Jesus left off. The Trinity are interested in teaching a particular curriculum. Jesus had been the disciples' teacher for three years, and had spoken what the Father gave him to say (see 7:16; 8:26, 40, 47). But three years was too little for the disciples to learn everything they would need to know. There was much more to learn—as is clear from the fact that the disciples have just been asking one question after another about the mystery of salvation (see 13:36; 13:37; 14:5, 8, 22). This is the context in which Jesus promises the teaching of the Holy Spirit. Thus the *all things* must tie in directly with God's plan of salvation and the blessings it brings. Jesus had taught them a good deal about this, and the Holy Spirit will remind them of what he had taught. The rest, he would teach them himself.

Reassured that God has a wonderful plan in place, the disciples can be at peace (**14:27**) and can rejoice that Jesus is being promoted—for his departure is a promotion, as he is returning to the Father (**14:28**). His death may, for a time, appear to represent his defeat by Satan, but it will ultimately teach them that Jesus and the Father are indeed one in purpose (**14:30–31**)

15:1–17 Jesus, the True Vine

Jesus ended his speech to the disciples with *Come now; let us leave* (14:31b), but it seems that he decided to remain in p 1311 the upper room a little longer in order to help the disciples understand more by giving them the revision lesson found in chapters 15 to 16.

He starts by making the seventh and last of his key 'I am' sayings: *I am the true vine* (**15:1;** the others are in 6:35, 51; 8:12; 10:7, 9; 10:11, 14; 11:25 and 14:6). The word translated 'true' focuses on dependability. Jesus was not saying that he is the true vine and that all others are false, but rather that he is the dependable vine. Others (including African traditional religions) may have much to offer, but they are not dependable. He is God's appointed way of approaching God.

If Jesus is a vine, then the Father is the gardener in the vineyard and the disciples are the branches on the vine (**15:1**, 5). The Father's role is, firstly, to cut *off every branch in me that bears no fruit* (**15:2a**). The 'fruit' referred to here is both holiness in the disciples' own lives and their continuing service of Jesus. One disciple who had not borne fruit was Judas Iscariot, who had ceased to serve Jesus and had left to betray him. The remaining eleven disciples were sincere in their love for Jesus, but they could not afford to become careless. They must continue to *remain in* Jesus (15:4). Failure to do so could lead them along the same route as Judas.

Those branches that were not cut off could expect to be pruned to make them *even more fruitful* (**15:2b**). In **15:3** Jesus told his remaining eleven disciples, *You are already clean because of the word I have spoken to you.* He had used the same word earlier, where he had described all but one of them as clean (13:10–11). But despite their cleanness, the disciples could expect that the Father would allow them to go through unpleasant experiences so as to establish them in their faith and Christian ministry (see also 1 Pet 4:14). We know something of the pruning some of the disciples endured. Peter, for example, passed through the 'pruning' of denying Jesus and the restoration that followed (18:17, 25, 27; 21:15–19), mockery (Acts 2:13) and imprisonment (Acts 5:18; 12:1–19). Each pruning experience gave him more energy to move on.

As the true vine, Jesus will enable the branches to bear fruit (15:4–5). He uses the biological fact that a branch not attached to a plant will neither benefit from the sap nor bear any fruit to illustrate a spiritual truth (**15:4**). The exhortation *remain in me* reminds the disciples that they must develop the habit of remembering to draw their energy from Jesus. Abiding in Jesus goes with his abiding in the disciples. The disciples are being exhorted to maintain their side of the arrangement.

It needs to be noted that the focus of this passage is not on a believer losing salvation or being eternally secure, but on those who have believed bearing fruit. The one who was 'cut off' was Judas Iscariot, who cannot be equated with a believer.

The same thought is repeated in **15:5**: *I am the vine; you are the branches*. *If a man remains in me and I in him, he will bear much fruit; apart from me you can do nothing.* Without Jesus, there would be no fruit at all (**15:16**); but with him, the disciples would not only bear some fruit, they would bear much fruit. Over the years he was with them, Jesus had prepared them for fruit production. They would be the ones who would establish the church—born on the day of Pentecost on the basis of the apostles' preaching. They would work with other men such as Matthias, who replaced Judas Iscariot (Acts 1:26); Paul, who was dramatically appointed as an apostle by the risen Jesus (Acts 9:1–30; see also Gal 1:11–24) and evangelists like Stephen (Acts 6:5–8:1a) and Philip (Acts 8:4–40). All of these men formed one team, proclaiming the message of Jesus. The reason for their appointment was 'to go and bear much fruit'.

We, too, are called to do this, and if we fail to bear fruit, we fail in our assignment. Not only that, we are to go on from bearing *more* fruit (15:2), to bearing *much* fruit (**15:5**), to bearing *fruit that will last* (15:16). The progression here shows that bearing fruit is a process and that our ability to bear fruit increases as we mature.

In our personal lives, this means that we will not develop just one virtue out of the nine in Galatians 5:22–23 but will work to cultivate all of them. In our evangelism, it means that we will not be content to save just one person, but will work to save an entire village. In terms of our effectiveness, it means that we will not just be a good influence in our local church but throughout

the entire nation and the world! Much fruit is the promise. Much fruit should be the goal. Abiding in Jesus and Jesus abiding in us is the key to reaching that goal.

Coupled with the promise of power in bearing fruit is a promise of power in prayer: *If you remain in me and my words remain in you, ask whatever you wish, and it will be given you* (**15:7**; see also 16b). There are no limits so long as the condition of abiding in Jesus is met. Nothing would be denied when it was asked for while they were abiding in Jesus and working for the promotion of the Abiding-in-Jesus Movement!

By bearing fruit, the disciples will both glorify God the Father and prove their discipleship (**15:8**). Jesus' only aim during his three-year ministry had been to glorify the Father. This was also to be the goal of the eleven, in every word they uttered and every deed they performed. Also, because they are connected to Jesus who is the vine, their fruit must be Jesus-like. It cannot be otherwise if they claim to be Jesus' disciples.

As branches (15:2, 4, 5, 6, 16) the disciples have other specific responsibilities besides bearing fruit. They are also to love one another (a point Jesus had already made in 13:34–35). In **15:12**, he tells them to *Love each other* and the same instruction is repeated in **15:17**. While he calls p 1312 this a *command*, Jesus reminds them that he is exhorting them as his friends, not issuing them commands as slaves (**15:14–15**). Slaves obey because they fear their master; friends obey because they love their friends. Jesus loved his disciples and the disciples were to respond to that love by obeying him (**15:10**). The fact that the disciples had been specifically chosen (**15:16**) should also be an encouragement for them as they face the daunting responsibilities that will soon be theirs.

Love is to be the disciples' way of life. They are to love everyone, at all times. The type of love that Jesus is commanding is the same type of love that the Father has for Jesus (**15:9**), and that Jesus has for his disciples (15:12–13). The Father's relationship with the Son is one of love from eternity, and Jesus, relationship with his disciples is one of love from the time he called them until the time of speaking. Jesus followed the Father's example and loved his disciples as the Father loved him. The disciples were now to follow Jesus' example and love each other in the same way.

The highest level of love is expressed when someone is prepared to die for the sake of a friend (**15:13**). Jesus not only gave his life so that his friends would benefit from his death, but actually took their place (see 2 Cor 5:21; Gal 3:13; 1 Tim 2:6; 1 Pet 3:18). He is telling them to have a love that is not marred by selfish ambitions or ill-will of any kind. Selfish ambition is to be replaced by self-sacrifice and service. They are to wish each other well and work for what is best for one another.

15:18–16:4 Jesus' Disciples Hated by the World

While his disciples are to love each other, they would be hated and treated as enemies by *the world* (**15:18**). The 'world' is that evil system whose head is Satan and whose agents are in opposition to Jesus and his cause.

Three reasons are given for the hostility of the world: the disciples don't belong to the world (15:19), the world hated and persecuted Jesus their master (15:18) and the world lacked knowledge of the Father and of Jesus (15:21).

The disciples had previously belonged to the world, but Jesus had chosen them *out of the world* (**15:19**). The act of choosing gave the disciples a new status. They no longer belonged to the world but to Jesus. Since the world loves only its own, it cannot love the disciples. Instead, it hates them.

The world's hatred of Jesus and rejection of his teaching had been openly expressed in persecution. There had been persistent attempts to kill him (5:18), to seize him (7:30) and to stone him (8:59; 10:31). The world's hatred would soon be crowned by the shouting of 'Crucify! Crucify!' (19:6, 15). Since this was the way the world treated Jesus, it would treat his disciples in the same way (**15:20**).

The world's hostility to the disciples would be entirely due to the fact that they had identified themselves with Jesus. Such persecution shows that those who do it do not know God, no matter how religious they appear (**15:21**).

As if someone had asked Jesus how he could claim that the world was so guilty, he next marshalled his evidence, pointing out that his words (**15:22**), his deeds (**15:24**), the Holy Spirit (15:26) and the disciples (15:27) all combined to show that the world was indeed guilty.

Jesus 'words' were everything he had said to the crowds—including his clear statement of his relationship to the Father and his claims to be the bread of life; the light of the world; the good shepherd; the way, the truth and the life. His deeds backed up his words (15:24; see also 14:11). Yet despite his extraordinary miracles, the Jews remained hard-hearted. However, the world's hatred of Jesus was not unexpected, for it had been predicted in the OT (**15:25**—quoting Ps 35:19; 69:4; 109:3). Hatred of God led naturally to hatred of Jesus and hatred of his disciples.

The Holy Spirit, who speaks nothing but the truth (14:17), will testify for Jesus against those who persecute him (**15:26**). His evidence will support Jesus' claims. Finally, the disciples themselves will support Jesus' claims *And you also must testify, for you have been with me from the beginning* (**15:27**). In this verse, Jesus is not ordering them to testify, he is simply stating what would, in fact, happen. What they had done and what they had become already stood as a witness against the world.

In a Jewish court of law, two or three witnesses were required to establish a case. Here we have four witnesses (Jesus' words, his deeds, the Holy Spirit and the disciples). The world stands convicted. Yes, it may currently enjoy the upper hand as it persecutes both Jesus and his disciples, but it will pay for its sin when God pronounces his verdict.

The world's hatred of Jesus' followers would result in their being put out of the synagogue (**16:2a**). This would mean that they were excluded from the only place in which God communed with his people, the Jews, and would be separated from God's people. However, the persecution of the disciples would go well beyond exclusion from synagogues. Killing them would be seen as honouring God (**16:2b**). Eliminating them would be viewed as removing elements that did not glorify God (as in the incidents recorded in Numbers 25:1–9, Joshua 7 and Judges 19 and 20). This great mistake would happen because of a lack of knowledge of the relationship between the Father and Jesus (**16:3**). Not realizing that Jesus was the One sent by God, people's ignorance would lead them to kill Jesus' servants rather than honouring them and recognizing their link with God.

Jesus twice reminded his disciples that he was not telling them these things in order to increase their fear but for a positive purpose. When persecution came, the disciples' knowledge that this was to be expected would be the first weapon to help them stand firm and not be scattered p 1313 (**16:1**). The disciples' faith in Jesus would be strengthened as they related Jesus' words to later events (**16:4**).

Jesus had not told them about the coming danger before because they had not needed to know about it while he was still with them (16:4b). But now that he was departing, they needed to be prepared to handle danger well.

16:5–15 Jesus' Successor, the Holy Spirit

Jesus had already spoken about the Counsellor who would succeed him and would be with the disciples for ever (14:16; 14:26). This Counsellor would come only after Jesus' departure (**16:7a**) and would be sent by Jesus (**16:7b**; see also 14:16). Elsewhere, it is said that the Father will send the Holy Spirit in Jesus' name (14:26). But there are no contradictions here concerning the respective roles of the Father and the Son. What the Father does, Jesus is doing, and whatever Jesus does, the Father is doing. This oneness in purpose is a theme that runs throughout the Gospel of John.

The Counsellor will minister to both the world (16:8–11) and the disciples (16:12–13). He will *convict the world of guilt in regard to sin and righteousness and judgment* (**16:8**). These three represent different targets for conviction. The world would be convicted about sin because by rejecting Jesus it had remained in sin (**16:9**), about righteousness in that it was not on the side of God who is all-righteous (**16:10**) and about judgment because by rejecting Jesus it stood with the devil who is already condemned (**16:11**).

The Holy Spirit's ministry to the disciples would be quite different from his ministry to the world. To the disciples, he would be a reliable guide *into all truth (***16:13a**). His guidance can be trusted because he will not speak on his own, but *will speak only what he hears* (**16:13b**). The content of his message centres on the future—*what is yet to come* (**16:13c**). The Holy Spirit's guidance stretches from the very first things that happened after Jesus' departure to include everything that will happen at the end of time. It is primarily concerned with God's programme for his church and only secondarily with God's plan for each individual disciple. Individual disciples are not guided independently of the church, but within the context of the church.

This work of the Holy Spirit is to be viewed in the context of teamwork between the Father, Jesus and the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit will speak 'what he hears' from the Father (see 16:13). Jesus, however, describes this in **16:14** as *taking from what is mine and making it known to you.* The Holy Spirit's message is thus both Father-given and Jesus-owned. As Jesus says in **16:15**, *All that belongs to the Father is mine. That is why I said the Spirit will take from what is mine and make it known to you.* The Father's message is Jesus' message, and the Holy Spirit can pass on Jesus' message as his own. Yet because the Holy Spirit succeeds Jesus, his focus is on bringing glory to Jesus (16:14). He does not operate in a vacuum but builds on the redemptive work of Jesus. His role is to apply that work directly to our lives.

16:16–33 Jesus' Departure

It was only a matter of hours before Judas Iscariot and his crew would arrest Jesus, and so he reminded his disciples, *In a little while you will see me no more, and then after a little while you will see me* (**16:16**). This was not the first time Jesus had spoken of his death and resurrection in these terms (see, for example 13:33). However, in all the earlier references he had highlighted his departure and only implied the resurrection. In the present statement, he gives equal emphasis to both.

The dumbfounded disciples (16:5) at last found words to speak. Some of them asked each other, *What does he mean by saying, 'In a little while you will see me no more, and then after a little while you will see me', and 'Because I am going to the Father'?* (**16:17**). It is clear that they did not know exactly what Jesus meant (**16:18**). Recognizing this, Jesus took time to explain what he was saying (**16:19–20**).

He started by pointing out that they could expect their emotional response to his departure to be quite different before and after his resurrection. He introduced this statement with the Hebrew words *Amen, amen* (translated 'Truly, truly' by the NASB and 'I tell you the truth' in the NIV), emphasizing the certainty of what he was predicting. At the time of his suffering and death, they would weep because their master had been taken away and made to suffer (16:20). But their pain would be like the pain of childbirth (16:21)—intense but soon replaced with joy in the birth of a child. After the resurrection, the disciples would be filled with joy that Jesus had returned to life (**16:21–22**) and with a wonderful sense of satisfaction as the Father met their every need (**16:23–24**).

Jesus' departure would have three specific results for his disciples: two positive (16:25–30) and one negative (16:32). The positive results would be a fuller understanding of God and his ways as things are taught plainly, not figuratively (**16:25**), and direct access to the Father, whereas before they had only had access to Jesus (**16:26–27**). The negative result would be the scattering of the disciples (**16:32**). For Jesus himself, his departure would mean a return to his original home and a celebration of work well done. His statement that *I came from the Father and entered the world; now I am leaving the world and going back to the Father* (**16:28**) summarized his origin, his time on earth and his destination. His past existence was eternal; his stay on earth was temporary; and his future existence with the Father would be eternal.

Finally, Jesus repeated the reason why he was telling them these things: *I have told you these things,* he said, *so that in me you may have peace* (**16:33a**). The purpose of his long discourse was not to create anxiety but to give them p 1314 peace as they trusted in him. Outside of Jesus, there is no peace. That is why he added, *In this world you will have trouble* (16:33b). The world was their enemy. It would not treat them well. However, there was hope, for Jesus finished with the words, *But take heart! I have overcome the world* (**16:33b**). They were not expected to take heart on the basis of favourable circumstances, but on the basis of a historical fact, namely, Jesus' victory.

UNITY OF BELIEVERS

Unity may be defined as the condition in which something forms an organic whole. Although different elements are involved, the whole is characterized by agreement and internal coherence. This definition also applies to the unity of believers to the extent that they share a common foundation of faith and practice. While the word 'unity' may be rarely used in the Bible, the idea of unity is often found.

In the OT, the unity of the people of Israel was based on the fear of God and family ties. However, despite having one father, Abraham, Israel was divided into tribes and later into different kingdoms. Even though they had the law of Moses and the warnings of the prophets, the people of Israel were not able to obey God and live as he desired. Consequently they did not achieve real unity.

In the nations and villages of Africa, unity is also strongly dependent on family ties, on the use of a common language, or on the fact of living in the same geographical region. This unity is vulnerable because anyone who comes from another area or who does not speak the same language is perceived as an outsider, or even an enemy. Hence, there is no unity involving all the nations of the region.

In Israel, as in Africa, unity could only be partial, limited to one nation or one close-knit community. But in the NT, there is an unlimited, universal dimension to the unity of believers. This unity knows no geographic, administrative or cultural limits. It is based in Jesus. By his death and resurrection, Jesus opened the way to new alliances for all peoples, who had formerly been without grace and were enemies of God (Eph 2:12–13). Through faith in Jesus, the believer is part of a new nation, reconciled to God and capable of living in genuine fellowship, a visible unity.

This unity is fostered and maintained by the work of the Holy Spirit, the agent of the new birth, the source of life in the believer, and the giver of the gifts and fruit of the Spirit (John 3:5; Eph 4:4). The Holy Spirit transforms believers into brothers and sisters in Christ and also into brothers and sisters to each other. In other words, it is the work of the Holy Spirit that makes believers united in Jesus and among themselves.

This unity should be most evident in the local church. It is because of this unity that the local church is also called the body of Christ or the bride of Christ (1 Cor 6:17; Eph 5:30). Every believer is a living member of this body. In the local church, unity is expressed primarily by collectively listening to the word, by submission to the authority of this word, and by the celebration of baptism and communion.

But the local church is only one link in the unity of the universal church. The unity that God brings extends to all believers of all nations, denominations and times. Tribalism, ethnicity and denominationalism are hindrances to the unity of God's people and must be resisted. Of course, each ethnic group or tribe has its place in the church, but only as links in a long chain. There is no place for ideologies that consider one ethnic group or tribe superior to another. Similarly, individual churches belong to different denominations, but this division must not be allowed to be an obstacle to unity back and be defended on the basis of protecting church doctrine or by arguing that separation from others is the will of God.

Unity was one of the main things that Jesus prayed for in his high priestly prayer. He knew that unity lends credibility to the message of the church and is part of its mission (John17:21).

Unfortunately, the unity that is presented in God's word has not yet been fully realized. Believers must be disciplined and built up by the word in order to come to maturity and arrive at visible unity. They must also support and maintain this unity through united efforts in such areas as mission and evangelism.

17:1–26 Jesus' Last Prayer Before His Arrest

Jesus ended his discourse in the upper room with a prayer to the Father. It was now time to talk to the Father on behalf of himself, his disciples and all believers before he departed.

17:1–5 Jesus' prayer for himself

Jesus' prayer for himself focused on his glorification. He pleaded with the Father, *Glorify your Son* (**17:1a**). He saw his death and resurrection in terms of promotion and committed them into the hands of the Father so that the Son would emerge highly exalted. He specified that the glory he was asking for was *the glory I had with you before the world began* (**17:5**) and that its purpose was *that your Son may glorify you* (**17:1b**). Jesus would be glorified by being resurrected, and the glorified Jesus would attribute his resurrection to the Father.

The basis on which Jesus made this request was that he had completed the work assigned to him by the Father (**17:4b**). He highlights two aspects of this work—giving eternal life to all those whom the Father had given him (**17:2**) and glorifying the Father (**17:4a**). p 1315

17:6–19 Jesus' prayer for his disciples

After praying for himself, Jesus went on to pray at length for his disciples. As though reasoning with the Father, Jesus explains why he is moved to this specific prayer for them. He mentions the fact that the disciples belonged to the Father and had obeyed him (**17:6, 9**), their true knowledge of the Father and of Jesus (**17:7–8**), the fact that their actions had enhanced Jesus' glory (**17:10**) and the fact that they would soon be left alone (**17:12**).

The first thing he requested for his disciples was protection by the Father's power—not so much protection of their physical bodies as of their unity (**17:11**; see also 15:12). The need for Jesus' prayer has been illustrated again and again in Africa. In tribal clashes, believers have betrayed their brothers and sisters in the Lord for fear of being killed by their own tribespeople. Jesus stressed the importance of the unity of believers; however, he did not guarantee that they would be able to maintain this unity without sacrificing their own lives.

Once Jesus was no longer with them as a unifying factor (17:12), the disciples would be exposed to the hatred of the world and to the attacks of Satan, who is referred to as *the evil one* to emphasize his wickedness (**17:14–15**; see 15:18–21).

The second thing Jesus prayed for was the disciples' sanctification (**17:17**). He stresses that this sanctification will be brought about by the truth, that is, by their increasing knowledge and understanding of God's word. The disciples would need such sanctification because they would be living in a world that did not value it but was opposed to God's will (**17:18**). They did, however, have a pattern to follow: Jesus himself, who submitted totally to the will of God (**17:19**).

17:20–25 Jesus' prayer for all believers

Jesus had prayed for unity for his disciples (17:11), and now he prays for it for all believers (**17:20**). Their unity is to be patterned on the unity of the Father and the Son (**17:21a**, 22). But not only is this to be the model for their unity, they are also to share in this relationship (**17:21b**, **23a**). Like the Father and the Son, believers are to be united in working towards their goal of bringing the world to believe in the Father and the Son (**17:21c**, **23b**).

The second thing he prays for all believers is that they will be reunited with him and able to see Jesus' full glory that he did not show during his earthly ministry (**17:24**). All those whom the Father has given to Jesus will participate in this reunion. Jesus has shared his glory with these believers (**17:22**), but he wants them to share it even more fully.

Jesus concludes his prayer with a restatement of his submission to the Father's will, which will result in the believers being brought into still closer unity with and submission to the Father and to Jesus (**17:25–26**).

18:1–20:9 Jesus' Arrest, Crucifixion and Burial

18:1–27 Jesus' Arrest and Jewish Trial

Upon completion of the priestly prayer, Jesus left the upper room and went to the olive grove where he was arrested (**18:1**). The arresting team was guided to him by Judas Iscariot. They carried torches and lanterns for light and also weapons in case there would be resistance (**18:2–3**). However, they needed no weapons, for Jesus was not hiding in the olive grove. He knew the hour for his arrest had come, and so he went out to meet them and calmly identified himself as Jesus of Nazareth (**18:4–5**). His words *I am he* (18:6) were, however, so powerful that they caused the arresting team to draw back and fall to the ground, not in worship but as if they had been overpowered by Jesus' simple statement (18:6). After getting the arresting team to be very clear about who exactly they were to arrest by having them repeat the name of their target (**18:5**, **7**), Jesus told them, *if you are looking for me, then let these men go* (**18:8**). His aim was to protect his disciples from harm.

Peter started to fight for Jesus, and in the process cut off the right ear of Malchus, a servant (**18:10**). But Jesus quickly calmed the situation by healing the ear. He reminded Peter and the rest of the disciples what this was all about: *Shall I not drink the cup the Father has given me?* (**18:11**). He then allowed himself to be arrested, bound and taken for trial.

The main participants in the Jewish trial were Annas, Caiaphas and the Sanhedrin. Annas, the father-in-law of Caiaphas, had been the high priest from AD 6 to 15 and still retained enormous influence. Caiaphas, the high priest from AD 18 to 36, would have had to sign the Sanhedrin's verdict, but Annas' opinion would have weighed heavily on the decision.

While Jesus was being tried by the Jewish authorities, Peter was being tried by the crowd. On three occasions he was identified as possibly one of Jesus' followers (**18:17**, **25a–26a**), and on each occasion he strongly denied it. Jesus had predicted that this would happen (13:38), as Peter remembered with shame when he heard the cock's crow.

The Jewish trial focused on Jesus' *disciples and his teaching* (**18:19**). Jesus' responses, however, focused only on his teaching. He pointed out that he had taught in public and those who had heard

him could testify about it (**18:20–21**). Jesus was challenging Annas for his refusal to listen to his teaching and also stating a fact. He had taught in the synagogues and in the temple. It should have been easy to find witnesses if there was any crime of which he could legitimately be accused.

Because Jesus' answer was not the one wanted, an official struck him in the face (**18:22**). Annas seems to have ignored this abuse of the prisoner, but Jesus demanded to know what he had done that justified striking him (**18:23**). p 1316 Of course, no answer was given. He had done no wrong. On a human level, the officials were simply acting to defend their leadership by removing someone who threatened it.

The Jewish leaders' hostility to Jesus was nothing new. He had first been accused of breaking the Sabbath laws (5:16). To this had been added accusations of blasphemy (5:18; 10:33). But neither charge would have impressed the Roman governor, so when the authorities handed Jesus over to him, they had to produce new charges.

18:28–19:16a Jesus' Roman Trial

Jesus' trial before Pilate and his appearance before Herod Antipas (tetrarch of Galilee from 4 BC to AD 39, who happened to be in Jerusalem at this time) together form the Roman trial of Jesus. His appearance before Herod is recorded only in Luke 23:6–12. It interrupted Jesus' trial by Pilate, who sent him to Herod after learning that Jesus was a Galilean. Jesus did not answer Herod's questions, and Herod and his soldiers simply mocked him and then sent him back to Pilate. Pilate was, therefore, the key player in this trial. He was the governor of Judea from AD 26 to AD 35, appointed to this position by Tiberius, who was the Roman emperor from AD 14 to AD 37.

It seems that the Jewish authorities had difficulty in finding a crime they could accuse Jesus of committing. Annas' interrogation seems to have found nothing, and no convincing witnesses had appeared before Caiaphas and the Sanhedrin. So when Pilate asked about the charge against the prisoner, they replied vaguely that he was *a criminal* who should be executed (**18:29–30**). It is clear that Jesus' accusers were not looking for a fair trial that followed the proper legal process. They wanted the Roman governor to rubber-stamp the sentence that they had already passed.

Recognizing that the lack of charges meant this was not a case he should judge, Pilate told the Jewish leaders to take Jesus and judge him by their own law. They responded that there was no point in doing this. They had already decided that Jesus should be executed, but were powerless to carry out the sentence, since Roman law did not permit them to carry out executions (**18:31**). Further evidence of the lack of interest in a fair trial is the fact that after Jesus' first session with Pilate, the chief priests and their officials did not ask Pilate what his verdict was, but told him what verdict they wanted (19:6a).

Pilate's question to Jesus, *Are you the king of the Jews?* (**18:33**), suggests he had been told that Jesus was the leader of a rebellion against Roman authority, a charge that was important enough to force Pilate to take the case seriously. This charge was supported by twisting Jesus' words and actions. The Jewish leaders probably reminded Pilate of Jesus' triumphal entry into Jerusalem as the Messianic king (see 12:12–15) and emphasized their own loyalty to Caesar (see 19:12). They did not mention the fact that when the people had wanted to make Jesus king (6:15), he had refused and withdrawn from them. Jesus had accepted the people's royal welcome to Jerusalem, but had kept his focus clear. His kingdom was not an earthly one, for his desire was to reign in the hearts of men and women.

It seems that Pilate was not particularly concerned about Jesus being described as a king, provided the qualifier 'of the Jews' was emphasized (see 19:19). The Jews had authority over their own religious affairs, and it did not matter much to Pilate whether they called their leader a king or a high priest, so long as he did not overstep the authority given to him and paid due honour and respect to Caesar and to himself as governor. The tone of his questions suggests that he was not so much looking for evidence of a crime as trying to find out who Jesus actually was. He must have heard about some of the miracles Jesus had performed.

Jesus' response to Pilate's question was, *Is that your own idea, or did others talk to you about me?* (**18:34**). He was encouraging Pilate to reflect on what he had just said. Did Pilate believe that Jesus was the king of the Jews? If he did, he was on the right track. But Pilate waved away the question (**18:35a**). Since he was not a Jew, he was under no obligation to make any decision on the matter of Jesus' kingship. As far as he was concerned, the whole question was merely about a point of Jewish religious belief, in which he was not interested. Thus he distanced himself from what was happening by labelling it a religious matter.

Pilate makes it quite clear that he as governor would have had no objection to Jesus being the king of the Jews. It was the Jewish people (and more specifically the chief priests) who had taken offence at this claim and had handed Jesus over to him for trial (**18:35b**). So Pilate wanted to find out from Jesus what he had done to arouse such hostility. The question *What is it you have done?* (**18:35c**) indicates what a strange trial this was. The accused was supposed to say what he had done, instead of his accusers pressing charges against him! Of course, as we saw from 18:19, 30, his accusers had no clear-cut charges.

In his response, Jesus emphasized that his kingdom was *not of this world. If it were,* he said, *my servants [disciples] would fight to prevent my arrest by the Jews* (**18:36a**). (Peter's cutting off of Malchus' ear does not disprove this statement. It was not done with Jesus' approval.) Rather, his kingdom was *from another place* (**18:36b**). His rule was not over any earthly domain. He was king because he had been appointed such by the Father in heaven.

Pilate wanted to make sure that he had understood what Jesus was saying about his kingship in 18:36 and so he asked a further question. The NIV translates 18:37a as a statement, but in the Greek it is in the form of a question and could be literally translated, *You are a king, aren't you?* In replying to Pilate in the rest of **18:37**, Jesus pointed out that Pilate was right to state that Jesus was a king, and p 1317 that his role as king was *to testify to the truth*. Everyone who was on the side of truth would listen to him.

In Pilate's experience, kingship involved having power over people. Jesus, however, spoke of kingship as being associated with truth, which then drew people to his side. What was all this about? So Pilate asked, *What is truth?* (**18:38a**). Unfortunately for Pilate, he did not wait to hear Jesus' answer to his question. John tells us, *With this he went out again to the Jews.* Pilate missed the opportunity to hear the telling of the good news to its end. His interest was in judicial, not religious, matters.

The reason Pilate went back to the Jewish leaders was to tell them, *I find no basis for a charge against him* (**18:38b**). But the trial was not over yet, and Pilate did not stand by what he knew to be the truth about Jesus.

Having found Jesus innocent, Pilate suggested that he release Jesus, as it was the custom for a prisoner to be released at Passover time (**18:39**). But the Jewish leaders would have none of this, and shouted back, *No, not him! Give us Barabbas!* (**18:40**).

Despite the fact that he thought Jesus was innocent, Pilate ordered him flogged (**19:1**). He was probably hoping that this punishment would be enough to satisfy Jesus' accusers.

At this stage we meet another group who participated in Jesus' trial: the soldiers. They had probably heard his responses to Pilate's question, and mocked his claim to kingship by putting a crown on his head. A crown is usually a sign of power, and is designed to fit comfortably on the head of its powerful wearer. But Jesus' crown was made out of thorns *twisted together* (**19:2a**). It would have been extremely painful, particularly if, as some suggest, it was made out of palm leaves. The long spines at the ends of these leaves can be up to twelve inches long.

They also clothed Jesus in a purple robe (**19:2b**). Purple was the official colour of royalty and a marker of authority and wealth (Exod 28:2, 5, 6; Luke 16:19; Rev 17:4; 18:16). As Jesus was a king, it was the appropriate colour for him to wear. The soldiers, however, were not genuinely acknowledging Jesus' kingship; they were mocking him.

As the soldiers sarcastically honoured him, pretending to salute him and saying, *Hail, king of the Jews!* (**19:3a**), they were addressing him correctly! He was the king of the Jews, and should neither have been wearing a crown of thorns nor standing as a prisoner before Pilate. However, God allowed this to happen (19:11a) so that through Jesus' suffering, those who believed in him would be healed (Isa 53:5).

The soldiers expressed their contempt for Jesus by striking *him in the face* (**19:3c**). Little did they know that the one they had struck was more powerful than Pilate, or even Tiberius Caesar. Soon these soldiers (or others like them) would be surprised when their service as guards at Jesus' tomb turned into a nightmare!

Pilate then presented the bleeding and abused Jesus to the Jewish leaders and made an even more emphatic declaration of Jesus' innocence (**19:4**). But the only response of the chief priests and their officials was to shout, *Crucify! Crucify!* (**19:6a**). Frustrated, he told them to take Jesus and crucify him themselves (**19:6b**). Of course, Pilate knew that the leaders were unable to do this (18:31b), but he was sending them a message that he did not want to be associated with their injustice. Again, he reminded them that he found Jesus innocent (19:6b).

Recognizing that Pilate was wavering and likely to acquit Jesus, the Jewish leaders brought out their number one charge, namely, that Jesus *claimed to be the Son of God* (**19:7**). On hearing this, Pilate became even more reluctant to handle the case, and asked Jesus another question: *Where do you come from?* (**19:9a**). Up to this point, Pilate had been handling the matter in light of Roman law, for the Jewish leaders had refused his offer to allow them to deal with Jesus according to Jewish law (18:31). But now the Jewish leaders had told Pilate that even if Roman law saw no fault in Jesus, their law viewed him as a criminal deserving capital punishment. At this point, Pilate may have wanted to reconcile his conviction that Jesus was innocent with the Jewish leaders' demands by transferring the case to someone else.

Luke tells us that after Pilate had established that Jesus was innocent, he found out that he was from Galilee and sent him to Herod Antipas, who was in Jerusalem at that time (Luke 23:4–7). John, too, makes it clear that Pilate would have been happy to free himself from handling Jesus' case. He

wanted to avoid the conflict between what was right in terms of Roman law and the demands of the Jewish leaders.

Jesus did not reply to Pilate's question (**19:9b**). Why? Was he being impolite? No. He was exercising good judgment. He already knew why Pilate wanted to free himself from judging this case, and he also knew that was not going to happen. Jesus had to die on the cross because of human sinfulness and the unchanging holiness of God (Eph 2:16; Col 2:13–14). He also had to die at Passover as the lamb that would redeem people from the Egypt of sin. Passover time had come. A much more immediate reason for his silence, however, was the complexity of any answer to Pilate's question. Pilate would have been happy to hear Jesus say, 'I am from Nazareth', but that answer would have been incorrect because Nazareth was only a stop on his route through this world as he travelled from eternity past to eternity future. If Jesus had given the correct answer, 'I am from heaven', Pilate would not have understood what he meant. If Jesus' divine origin was incomprehensible to the best minds among the Jewish leaders (who knew the Scriptures inside out), how would Pilate, a pagan, understand it? The question could not be answered simply on a purely p 1318 intellectual level. Only faith in Jesus' claim would make it comprehensible, and Pilate was not following the route of faith. He was merely interested in the legal and political aspects of the matter.

Pilate was annoyed when Jesus did not answer his question about his origin: *Do you refuse to speak to me?* (**19:10a**). In the Greek, the 'me' (referring to Pilate) is placed first for emphasis, contrasting with the less important 'you' (Jesus). The idea behind Pilate's question was 'You do not realize who I am. I am Pilate, the governor, and you are a prisoner at my mercy.' Pilate had interpreted Jesus' silence as rudeness, but that did not bother Jesus. Within a few days, when Pilate would realize who Jesus really was, he would know that it should have been the other way round, with Jesus interrogating him rather than him interrogating Jesus!

Pilate's question about Jesus' silence was immediately followed by a last and more specific question concerning his authority: *Don't you realize that I have power either to free you or to crucify you?* (**19:10b**). In other words, 'Don't you realize that you are totally at my mercy?' Pilate was not exaggerating his power as governor. Tiberius Caesar would not concern himself with what was going on in Jerusalem, so long as there was peace. Which prisoner was freed and which was crucified was of no interest to Rome. The matter was totally in the hands of Pilate, who knew this and asked Jesus if he knew it too.

Jesus' response to Pilate's honest but somewhat proud and mistaken estimate of himself should have kept Pilate pondering for a long time: *You would have no power over me if it were not given to you from above* (**19:11a**). Pilate's power over Jesus was on loan from God, and would last only for as long as and to the degree that the giver determined. Pilate was in no position to boast about his power in his dealings with Jesus. In fact, Pilate was guilty of sin, although *the one who handed me over to you is guilty of a greater sin* (**19:11b**). Pilate's guilt was limited. He was presiding over the unjust trial of an innocent man. However, as an official of the ruling power, he had been forced into this position. Moreover, he himself had not set out to arrest Jesus. Jesus had been brought to him by a person—the singular is used here—meaning either Judas Iscariot or Caiaphas, who had delivered Jesus to Pilate. If Jesus was referring to Judas, he was thinking of the fact that for three years Judas Iscariot had heard Jesus' teaching and experienced his great love, but he had repaid Jesus' goodness by betraying him. If he was referring to Caiaphas, his point was that Caiaphas, as a Jew and the high priest, should have known better than Pilate. The Scriptures of which Caiaphas was the custodian condemned the injustice and untruthfulness that had characterized Jesus' trial.

Pilate became even more anxious to free Jesus, but he was confronted by the Jewish leaders who kept on shouting, reminding Pilate that his loyalty to Tiberius Caesar would be questioned if he released Jesus: *Anyone who claims to be a king opposes Caesar* (**19:12**).

Yielding to the pressure from the Jewish authorities, Pilate finally took up his formal seat as judge and presented the scourged Jesus to the crowd with the assertion *Here is your king* (**19:13–14**). It is not clear what Pilate meant by calling Jesus a 'king' here. He was probably thinking purely in religious terms. But the chief priests responded to Pilate's declaration with *We have no king but Caesar* (**19:15**).

Recognizing the Jewish leaders' implacable hostility to Jesus and the threat to his own position, Pilate abandoned his attempt at a just trial and handed Jesus over to them for crucifixion (**19:16a**).

19:16b–30 Jesus' Crucifixion

With the way now set for the cross, *the soldiers took charge of Jesus* (19:16b). Matthew and Mark tell us that the soldiers first took Jesus into the Praetorium, the palace where Pilate was staying (Matt 27:27; Mark 15:16), and after mocking him they stripped him of the purple robe 'and put his own clothes on him' (Matt 27:31; Mark 15:20). Wearing his own clothes, but still with the crown of thorns on his head, Jesus' journey to the place of crucifixion began.

It was a journey that produced both physical and emotional pain. The physical agony included the weight of the cross he had to carry (**19:17**), the crucifixion itself, and his thirst (**19:28**). There was also the emotional pain of seeing the crowd choose Barabbas for release and not him (18:40), of seeing all his disciples desert him (Matt 26:56), of being crucified between two criminals (**19:18**), of seeing his grieving mother (**19:25**) and of being scorned by one of the criminals at his side (Luke 23:39).

Despite all the suffering and the soldiers and authorities seeming to be the ones in control, the passage makes it clear that everything that was happening was under the control of God. The soldiers did not break Jesus' legs (19:32–33), maintaining his fitness as the Passover Lamb (Exod 12:46; Num 9:12) and fulfilling what had been predicted (Ps 34:19–20). The soldier, though he knew Jesus was dead, pierced Jesus' side, and blood and water flowed out (19:34–37). Blood cleanses from sin (1 John 1:7) and water provides spiritual refreshment (7:38).

In spite of his failure to enforce justice in the handling of Jesus' case and the complaints of the Jews (**19:21**) Pilate's inscription on Jesus' cross was a significant proclamation of who Jesus really was. It was read by many because it was written in the three main languages of the time—Aramaic, Latin and Greek (**19:19–20**).

It is remarkable that, in the midst of all his suffering, Jesus was still concerned about his mother. He committed her to the care of the Apostle John (**19:26–27**) who was with Jesus even at this time.

p 1319 The outcome of his pain was glorious. When Jesus uttered his sixth word from the cross in **19:30** and said, *it is finished*, he meant that the work of saving humankind was completed. Clearly pain and God's providence are not contradictory. Jesus' suffering, despite his having done no wrong, became the most glorious provision to all humankind—a fitting sacrifice for the sins of all peoples of all generations. Times of pain such as we experience in Africa should not make us give up. Instead we should press forward expecting God to produce some glorious outcome. The innocent sufferer may not see this outcome, but his or her children will.

19:31–42 Jesus' Death and Burial

Jesus' body needed to be buried, and time was of the essence because Jesus was crucified on the *day of Preparation* for a *special Sabbath*, which was due to begin at sunset (**19:31**). Just that morning Jesus had been handed over to the Jews for crucifixion at the 'sixth hour' (6 a.m.—19:14). Note that John reckoned time the Roman way, counting the day as beginning at midnight. The writers of the Synoptic gospels, however, reported time the Jewish way. Jesus was crucified at 9 a.m. (Mark 15:25: 'third hour'—with Mark designating daytime as beginning at sunrise). The next three hours passed like those of any other day on which a criminal was crucified. But at noon (Mark 15:33: 'sixth hour'—see also, Matt 27:45 and Luke 23:44) something strange happened, as it became dark, a darkness that lasted for three hours (Luke 23:44). Then at 3 p.m. Jesus had spoken his final words, the last of his short utterances on the cross. He had said, 'It is finished,' and then he had bowed his head and given up his spirit (**19:30**).

Meanwhile, in the temple, the Jews had been having their lambs slaughtered for the Passover meal, for at 6 p.m. the Passover week would begin. Jesus was still on the cross, but the Jews did not want him to remain there, as their law said that a dead body should not be left hanging on a tree overnight (**19:31**; see also Deut 21:22–23). Jesus' disciples were nowhere to be found. If no one claimed Jesus' body for burial, it would be thrown into the Valley of Hinnom, where all the garbage of Jerusalem was dumped.

Joseph of Arimathea and Nicodemus undertook to bury Jesus (**19:38–39a**). They were both secret disciples (19:38; see also 3:1–21; 12:42–43) and members of the Sanhedrin (Mark 15:43, John 7:50–52). Because it was the highest Jewish authority recognized by the Romans, those who belonged to it were powerful members of society.

By asking for Jesus' body (Matt 27:58; Mark 15:43; Luke 23:52) these men risked the enmity of their fellow Jewish leaders who had brought about Jesus' death. Unfortunately, today we seldom see a similar attitude of service to Christ in those who have become important, whether as government ministers, members of parliament or civil servants. What Joseph and Nicodemus were doing was equivalent to members of parliament or judges of the high court taking upon themselves the mundane duty of seeing that a body is properly disposed of. Otherwise it might have been given to the vultures, as the Romans generally had done with the bodies of those crucified.

In our day, we may not have Jesus' body to bury, but we have Jesus' cause to defend. This duty is not imposed only on pastors or bishops, but on every believer in Christ, no matter what his or her position. Joseph and Nicodemus summon us to wake up and defend the cause of Christ. What excuses do we give for not doing this? We may say, 'Our constitution separates the church from the state', or 'I am meant to represent all and not to take a religious stand on issues'—but often these are only excuses. Joseph and Nicodemus risked their political careers to perform a humble service for Jesus. We, too, should do the same if our conviction about who Christ really is goes deep enough. Look around and see what you can do, in your own country, for Christ's cause!

Not only did these two men risk their positions for Jesus' cause, they also gave material goods to it. The spices that Nicodemus brought for use on Jesus' body were not cheap, and the quantity he supplied was far more than would have been needed just for anointing the body (**19:39b**). The tomb in which they buried Jesus was Joseph's own tomb (**19:41**; Matt 27:60). These are men who gave generously.

Why is it that in Africa our theological institutions and Christian projects are so dependent on Western donors that we begin to wonder, 'Isn't there money in Africa?' There is definitely money in Africa. We can see it in the 'palaces' some African presidents have built for themselves, in the chains of rental houses owned by some of our members of parliament, and in the fleets of vehicles owned by the rich. But what is missing is the attitude we see in Joseph and Nicodemus, who gave abundantly and at a cost to themselves. Where are the palaces, the estates, the fleet of vehicles and the rest, for Jesus? These two men who were secret disciples of Jesus, put us to shame—even as we openly claim to be his disciples.

When Joseph and Nicodemus risked their popularity among their peers and gave as they did, they did not see beyond providing an honourable burial for Jesus. If they were prepared to do so much for a dead Jesus, how much more should we, who know him as our risen Saviour, do for him? African believers need to get into action!

20:1–9 Jesus' Resurrection

Jesus stayed in the tomb for all that remained of the day on Friday and then Friday night, all of Saturday, and Saturday night. On the morning of *the first day of the week,* the day on which we now celebrate the resurrection, Mary Magdalene went to the tomb intending to anoint Jesus' body. Approaching p 1320 the tomb, she *saw that the stone had been removed from the entrance* (**20:1**). Realizing that the tomb was empty, she rushed back to Simon Peter and the disciple Jesus loved (John the Apostle) and said, *They have taken the Lord out of the tomb, and we don't know where they have put him* (**20:2**). Her use of 'we' implies that Mary had not been alone but was speaking as a representative of others (see also Mark 16:1). The 'they' may have referred to the soldiers who crucified Jesus or the Jewish authorities, particularly the Sanhedrin.

John tells us that Peter and the beloved disciple hurried off to the tomb. The *other disciple outran Peter and reached the tomb first* (**20:3–4**). However, he did not go into the tomb. Instead, *he bent over and looked in* from the outside. He could see *strips of linen lying there* (**20:5**). When Peter arrived, he went into the tomb. He *saw the strips of linen lying there, as well as the burial cloth that had been around Jesus' head* (**20:6–7**). Finally, the other disciple followed Peter inside. He *saw and believed* (**20:8**). What he believed was that Jesus' body was no longer there (**20:9**). Soon, they would learn the glorious truth that Jesus had risen, that he had overcome death (20:19).

20:10–21:25 The Risen Lord

20:10–29 Jesus—Alive, Well and Glorious

After telling Peter and the beloved disciple that Jesus' body had been taken from the tomb, Mary Magdalene (and possibly other women) followed the two men as they ran to the garden. Peter and the other disciple, having realized that Jesus' body really was not in the tomb, *went back to their homes* (**20:10**). Here, 'their homes' simply stands for the place where they were staying in Jerusalem. Mary Magdalene, however, *stood outside the tomb crying* (**20:11**). As she wept, she bent over *and saw two angels in white, seated where Jesus' body had been, one at the head and the other at the foot* (**20:12**). The two angels asked Mary why she was crying and she replied, quite honestly from her perspective, *They have taken my Lord away, and I don't know where they have put him* (**20:13**). Having said this, *she turned around and saw Jesus standing there, but she did not realize*

that it was Jesus (**20:14**). Jesus asked her the same question the angels had asked, *Woman, why are you crying? Who is it you are looking for?* (**20:15a**). Thinking that she was speaking to the one in charge of the garden, she replied, *Sir, if you have carried him away, tell me where you have put him, and I will get him* (**20:15b**). At this point, Jesus spoke her name, *Mary* (**20:16**). At the sound of his voice, Mary realized that the one she was talking to was not a gardener, but her Lord! Mary turned towards Jesus and cried out in Aramaic, *Rabboni!* (that is, 'My teacher!'). It was now time for worship, not for asking questions. At last she understood clearly—Jesus was truly alive. She went to the disciples and told them, *I have seen the Lord!* (**20:18**).

Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene on the morning of the first day of the week, Sunday 16th Nisan. That evening he also appeared to the disciples (20:19a) who were all together (except for Thomas—20:24). None of them could think that it had been merely a dream, for they all saw him. Nor could his appearance have been wish-fulfilment, for the disciples were not expecting it; indeed, they were afraid (**20:19a**). Jesus was not hindered by locked doors when he *came and stood among them* (**20:19b**). He had not been there before, which is why John uses the word 'came', but there was no denying that he was standing there then.

Jesus' first words to the stunned disciples were *Peace be with you!* (20:19b). *Shalom*, meaning peace, was a common Hebrew greeting and a blessing in the first century. It was appropriate given the disciples' circumstances. They were still recovering from what they had thought was the loss of their teacher.

The world in general, and the continent of Africa in particular, needs to hear Jesus' words 'peace be with you'. Year after year, Africa remains a bleeding continent. If there is not war in the south, it is in the north; if not in the east, it is in the west, and in the central region too. May Jesus send peace to our continent! Yet when Jesus spoke these words to the disciples, he was focusing on peace of mind and heart. May that peace, too, be our experience in Africa as we wait for the peace in the external realm.

We need to grapple with the question What should be my contribution to the peace Africa needs? Much of the self-inflicted lack of peace in Africa has been born of animosity based on differences—whether ideological, ethnic or religious. Jesus' words 'love your neighbour' (Luke 10:27b) and his illustration of what this means (Luke 10:29–37) cut across any boundaries that have been placed by our differences. We are all called to live in peace. Followers of Christ are called upon to promote the ideals of their master—living together in peace and providing comfort to those who lack it. Those who have been widowed and orphaned by war, AIDS, famine or some other cause need to hear the voice of Jesus' followers (the church) echoing our master's words, 'peace be with you'. If the church of Christ lived up to its master's example, people's needs for food, clothing, counselling, encouragement or a sense of belonging would be met.

Just as Jesus sent his disciples (**20:21**) so also he sends us out of our comfort zone to those who need us. We will experience the joy that the disciples experienced upon seeing Jesus as we serve them (**20:20**).

Jesus ended this meeting with the disciples with a reminder about the promise of the Holy Spirit as *he breathed on them and said, 'Receive the Holy Spirit'* (**20:22**). He performed this symbolic gesture to remind his disciples of what p 1321 he had been teaching about the Counsellor and of what the Holy Spirit would do for them. He had told them that the work of the Holy Spirit would begin after he had gone back to the Father (14:16; 15:26; 16:7). He would then ask the Father to

send the Holy Spirit, who would be with them and guide them *into all truth* (16:13), even to the level of discerning how to deal with sin (**20:23**). We, too, need this reminder. We cannot do the task ahead of us on our own. It is only as the Holy Spirit enables us that we can turn Africa around. Combining our availability and the Holy Spirit's unlimited power, Africa can be saved—not just spiritually but also in all other ways.

At his second appearance to his disciples, Jesus focused on Thomas, who had expressed doubts about the reports concerning the first appearance (**20:24–25**). Jesus gently rebuked Thomas (**20:27b**, **29**), but also led him step by step to the confession; *My Lord and my God* (**20:28**). In so doing, he provided a good model for African pastors. Due to our tradition of a chief being a person of power, pastors in Africa tend to issue authoritative rebukes. But when we rebuke others, we must not lose sight of our goal, namely, bringing those we serve to confess Jesus as their Lord and God. Jesus gave Thomas the opportunity to put his fingers into his side and to feel where the piercing had been done (**20:27a**), to help him move from being a doubting Thomas to a believing Thomas. Are we prepared to patiently take others through the lessons to faith—addressing their doubts one by one? Such patience requires a focus on the needs of the sheep and not on the authority of the pastor. We may call ourselves 'apostles' and 'prophets', but our calling is to be shepherds of the flock and to care for our sheep. The Thomases in the African church long for a lowly shepherd to lead them step by step to see Jesus as their living Saviour and Lord.

20:30–31 The Purpose of This Gospel

At this point John reminds us that what he has written is only a small part of what he could have told of the wonders that Jesus did *in the presence of his disciples* (**20:30**). John, like all the other disciples (except Judas Iscariot), became the witnesses to what they 'heard, saw, looked at, and touched' (1 John 1:1). John was not reporting hearsay evidence, but incidents he had himself seen as one of the twelve (Matt 10:1–4; Mark 3:16–19; Luke 6:14–16). His report can be believed because the events described happened in the public eye, and he himself witnessed them.

John is also explicit about his aim in writing: he has chosen to describe the seven particular signs presented in this Gospel (see the introduction to this commentary) so that his readers *may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God* (**20:31**). The readers are not commanded to believe but are asked to examine the evidence of Jesus' words and deeds and to conclude that Jesus is who he says he is, namely the Christ, the Son of God.

Those who come to this belief will receive the blessing of *life in his name* (20:31). Note that the possession of this life is conditional on believing. A personal decision is required about whether to accept or reject this life that comes with faith. It is entirely accurate to say that this life 'comes with faith', for John uses the present tense for both the word translated 'believing' and the main verb translated 'may have', which in Greek, signals that the two things happen at the same time. Someone who believes is assured of possession of life from that moment on.

The life can be possessed only in Jesus' name. He is the one God has eternally chosen to deal with sin and death and to give life instead (see also comments on 14:6).

21:1–25 Jesus, the Encourager

In chapter 20 Jesus helped Thomas to overcome his doubts, and in chapter 21 he encourages seven of his other disciples and helps Peter recover from his triple denial of Jesus.

Seven of the disciples were together: Simon Peter, Thomas Didymus (a name that means 'the Twin', Nathanael from Cana, Zebedee's sons James and John, and two others—**21:2**). The reference to these 'two others' reminds us that Jesus does not only reach out to well-known disciples. This group decided to spend the night fishing in the Sea of Tiberias, where probably all of them had fished before (**21:3**). However, that night they caught nothing. *Early in the morning, Jesus stood on the shore, but the disciples did not realize that it was Jesus* (**21:4**). Jesus called out to them, *Children, haven't you any fish?* (**21:5**). The NIV has 'friends' instead of 'children', for the original Greek word can also be translated in this way. On hearing that they had caught nothing, Jesus instructed them to *throw your net on the right side of the boat* (**21:6a**). Probably believing that the speaker was a better fisherman than they were, the disciples did as they had been told. The result was that *they were unable to haul the net in because of the large number of fish* (**21:6b**). In 21:11 we are told that there were a 153 large fish.

The beloved disciple was the first to realize that it was not just an experienced fisherman who had told them where to throw the net, but the powerful, all-knowing Jesus. The beloved disciple then told Peter, *It is the Lord!* (**21:7a**). As soon as Peter was told this, *he wrapped his outer garment around him … and jumped into the water* (**21:7b**). *The other disciples followed in the boat* (**21:8**).

Surprise number one was the great number of fish they had caught. Surprise number two was seeing Jesus. Then followed surprise number three: *When they landed, they saw a fire of burning coals there with fish on it, and some bread* (**21:9**). Where did these come from? From the hand of Jesus! He had miraculously prepared a breakfast for his disciples. Though he could have provided the rest of the meal miraculously too, he chose not to do this, and told them, *Bring some of the fish you have just caught* (**21:10**).

p 1322 Simon Peter had reached Jesus before the other disciples, and he was the first to climb back on board when the Lord asked the disciples to bring some of the fish. He *dragged the net ashore* (**21:11a**). Surprise number four was that the huge catch had not torn the net (**21:11b**).

Jesus then invited the disciples to have breakfast, an invitation they all accepted. They dared not ask*, Who are you? They knew it was the Lord* (**21:12**) who knew all things (including where to catch fish); who could bring fire, fish and bread out of nothing and who could prevent an overfilled net from tearing.

Jesus was not only their host but also their servant. He *took the bread and gave it to them, and did the same with the fish* (**21:13**). As the disciples ate the fish and the bread that had been miraculously provided, they must have remembered Jesus' feeding of over five thousand men using five small barley loaves and two small fish (6:5–13).

What did Jesus want them to learn on this occasion? The answer must be related to why the disciples went fishing. It was not because they wanted to return to their original occupation. It was because they needed to be fed. Hunger comes to everyone, even a disciple of Jesus! After their unsuccessful efforts to catch fish, Jesus came and provided far more than they needed for a satisfying meal. Jesus wanted to remind them that he would provide for their daily situations and needs. He would take care of all their needs in the future.

Adeyemo, T. (2006). *Africa Bible commentary*. Nairobi, Kenya; Grand Rapids, MI: WordAlive Publishers; Zondervan.
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Theologians sometimes spend a lot of time debating whether miracles are taking place today or not. This debate has torn apart the church of Christ in Africa, as some assume that if you believe that miracles happen today you are Pentecostal, and if you do not, then you have not known the full power of Jesus. We need to remember that all believers are Jesus' people, and that all other human classifications serve no good purpose. This passage reminds us that Jesus is a Saviour of surprises. What surprises he will do depends totally on him. Today he may supply many fish, tomorrow the fire from nowhere, but he is the same Jesus, yesterday, today and tomorrow. We are not to focus on who we are but on who he is.

As Jesus reaches out to all, including the unnamed disciples (21:2), he still ministers to each at the level of his specific need. Peter had denied Jesus and was still living with that wound. So Jesus took Peter through the process of leaving what lies behind him and becoming the rock that Jesus had predicted he would be when they first met.

After they had finished eating, Jesus said to Simon Peter, *Simon son of John, do you truly love me more than these?* (21:15a). Jesus addressed Peter by his ordinary name (see 1:42) and not as Peter or Cephas, the name that he had given to him. Peter's denial had shown that he was not yet 'a rock'. He was still the ordinary Simon. Jesus was not using this name to condemn Peter, but to remind him that he was as feeble as any other man.

The comparison *more than these* (21:15) probably refers to the other disciples, though an ambiguity in the word translated 'these' leads some to interpret it as referring to the fish, which symbolized his life as a fisherman. The question recalls Peter's words in 13:37, where he had told Jesus, 'I will lay down my life for you.' It was only Peter who had made that promise. When the other disciples ran away (Matt 26:56; Mark 14:50) they were breaking no commitment. Peter, however, had indicated that his love would keep him faithful to the point of death. Jesus was asking Peter, 'Does that commitment still stand, Simon?'

After the pattern of questioning, answering and giving of an assignment had been repeated three times (**21:15–17**), Jesus told Peter, '*Follow me*' (**21:19b**). We are not told in what particular ways Peter was to follow Jesus, but it is clear that both his life and his death were similar to those of Jesus. Jesus knew that there were difficult times ahead for Peter, when he would not be in control of events (**21:18–19a**). Some early church fathers tell us that Peter suffered martyrdom under Nero in AD 64 or 65.

Jesus' answer to Peter's question concerning the beloved disciple, *If I want him to remain alive until I return, what is that to you? You must follow me* (**21:21–22**), reminds us that our life plans are in the Lord's hands. What matters is not whether we are martyred for Christ or keep serving Christ into old age. What matters is the Lord's will. As the Akamba say, *tinda na ukome yumanaa na ula uthokewe* ['it is up to the host to decide whether the visitor leaves or stays overnight']. To be like Peter is honourable, and to be like the beloved disciple is desirable, but to be in the Lord's will is profitable.

Those sons and daughters of Africa who, because they are Christians, have met their deaths at the hands of unbelieving 'Idi Amins' of various kinds remain our model to live for Jesus no matter what the circumstances. While our motive should not be to stir up bees, should they be stirred up by the faithful presentation of the word of God, we should faithfully bear their stings. The Lord's plans for our lives (whether they involve life or death for him) are of great profit. He can use us to

encourage others in the present, and in the future he will honour our stand. As he gives us life now, let us serve him faithfully so that the Lord will greet us with 'Well done, my faithful servant.'

Samuel M. Ngewa

Further Reading

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